

THE BREWING STORM

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A Chronicle of Monmurg · Book One

James

UNCORRECTED PAGE PROOF

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Journey of the Stone, Book One.

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PART ZERO: TWO ROADS TO MONMURG

CHAPTER ONE

The Envoy from Idee

Idee had taught Jude to travel light and trust little, and both habits served him well on the Onwallian trader that carried him west out of Scant, deep into the month of Flocktime. He had booked the passage himself, with Horace Baldpate at his shoulder as he had been for the better part of a year now — a seasoned sword for hire out of Onwal, broad through the chest, unhurried in his opinions, and possessed of the one virtue Jude prized above swordsmanship in a hired man: he knew the ports of the western world, and he had never once asked why an elf wizard wanted to reach a city under siege.

The mission, such as it was, could be stated in a single sentence, though Jude had turned it over enough times on the voyage that it no longer felt so simple. Find Karmirg. Bring him home, or bring back something that would serve as well. The half-orc had deserted the wars in Idee more than a year past, vanishing south with Gouge and a Reaver's letter of marque, leaving his hill-tribesmen leaderless and scattered before the giants they had provoked, and Idee — beaten low by the Herzog of the South Province and by the tidal wave that had drowned half of Naree before that — could not easily spare the men it took to replace him. Lord Anlauf Ogmotton had not ordered Jude to bring Karmirg back so much as begged him to, in the particular tired, unsparing way of a man who had run out of better options.

There was a second sentence beneath the first, unspoken even to Horace: that Jude was glad of an excuse to see Monmurg again, whatever the state of it, and that some of what he told himself was

duty toward Idee was really an old debt of his own — Karmirg, and by extension Gouge, and by further extension Lord Jamis, the patron who had once made use of him and might again, if the offer were sweetened correctly. A trade port at Naree, ships that no longer paid Onwal's tolls, silver enough to make the Sea Princes take an interest in a country they had never troubled to learn the name of. It was, Horace had said one evening over a shared bottle, a very good plan for a man with an evil mind, and Jude had not entirely denied it.

"You're thinking again," Horace said, on the third night out, watching Jude turn a coin over and over between two fingers without seeming to notice he did it. "You do that face."

"I'm listening," Jude said. "You've sailed more of these waters than I have. Tell me what Onwal thinks of the Great Kingdom's reach into the Azure Sea."

Horace obliged, at length, and by the time the wine was gone Jude had a clearer sense of the board he meant to play on — the Iron League clinging together by momentum more than strength, the Sea Princes indifferent to everything but coin, the old grudge between Suel houses that ran under half the politics of three nations like a fault line no one spoke of directly. He filed it away. Information was the only cargo he never ran short of room for.

The Keoland warships found them a week later, on a grey morning with the coast of the Pomarj a smudge to the northeast. Two men-of-war, flying the red-and-black lion of the crown over the standard of the Duke of Gradsul, closed on either bow with the unhurried confidence of ships that expected no argument, and got none. Ten marines came aboard, polite and thorough, and the merchant captain — a man Jude had marked already as more anxious than his cargo manifest justified — capitulated to their terms before Jude had finished dressing.

"They're diverting us," Horace reported, back from the deck with the particular blankness of a man delivering news he didn't like. "Monmurg's under embargo. All shipping bound there goes to Redshore instead, for inspection."

"Embargo," Jude said, "or war?"

"They didn't use that word. But I don't think it matters which word they use."

Jude weighed, briefly, the cost of forcing the issue — of putting both ships to the torch and swimming for it, of pressing the captain to run rather than yield to two hulls that could not, by any measure Horace could offer, actually outsail an Onwallian trader with a full head of wind. He decided against it before the thought had fully formed. Whatever waited in Monmurg, it would still be waiting after a day lost to Redshore, and a burned patrol boat was not a debt he wanted following him into a city he meant to ask favors of. He went up on deck instead, watched the Keoland colors flying off the bow, and said nothing that could be repeated against him later.

Redshore, when they raised it that evening, was not the fishing hamlet its reputation promised. It was a city — the oldest in Salinmoor and once its grandest, a faded sprawl of stone climbing the island's hills behind a working waterfront of rendering houses and oil sheds, grown rich on the whales that had run these waters since before Monmurg was a power. But a whaling port was built for whalers, and its handful of working quays could no more swallow the traffic of a blockade than a fishing skiff could carry an army. Forty-odd merchantmen lay at anchor in the channel between the island and the Salinmoor coast, more hulls than Redshore could unload in a season, and the beach below had sprouted a raw, improvised market of kegs and stalls and canvas awnings, merchants hawking wares to men who had nowhere else to spend their coin and nothing better to do while they waited for a war to end. Horace stared at the crowd of masts like a man watching money rot.

"There's no moorage here — not for this," he said. "Monmurg has docks that could take the whole lot and send for more. Redshore has a whaler's wharf and a beach. It would take a month to empty these holds, if they ever find the room."

"Then I expect a great many men are about to lose a great deal of money," Jude said, and went to find the sergeant of the boarding marines.

The marine had set himself up near the bow to deal with the passengers who wanted off, and a short line had already formed — anxious merchants who had done the same arithmetic Jude had and decided a ship bound nowhere was worth less than dry ground beneath their feet. Jude took his place at the back of it, Horace a silent bulk at his shoulder, and used the wait to watch how the sergeant handled the men ahead of him: brisk, bored, and not much interested in anyone who did not make himself a problem.

He gave his name plainly enough — Jude, of Idee — and let the sergeant read what he liked into the rest: a man of some means, traveling light, not fool enough to try smuggling contraband past armed marines with a straight face. He did not offer the word *diplo-mat* until he was asked, and even then he let it sit lightly, a card shown rather than played. It bought him passage ashore before nightfall, and a name — the Earl of Redshore, who alone among the men currently choking off Monmurg's trade might have the standing to let one small, insistent elf continue on his way.

There was no dock to carry them in. The trader lay anchored a hundred feet off the shore with the rest of the stranded fleet, and so the last stretch of the journey was made in a crowded longboat, Jude and Horace wedged among departing merchants and their salvaged bundles while two marines worked the oars. The boat threaded a slow path between anchored hulls that rose black and silent on either hand, lanterns swinging at their rails, and grounded at last on a beach already loud in the failing light — torches lit along the improvised market Jude had watched from the deck, hawkers calling over one another, the smell of tar and fish and frying oil thick over the shingle. Jude stepped down into it after the others, and let the crowd close over him and Horace both.

The castle sat at the end of a stone mole jutting into the bay, two keeps joined by a drawbridge, built for a siege from the sea and none at all from the land — a fortification that would have fit, Jude thought, comfortably inside one wing of Prince Jeon's palace, and said as much to no one but himself. The guard commander at the gate named a coin before he would carry word to his lord, and

Jude paid it without haggling. In Jude's experience, a man who bribed cheerfully was rarely searched carefully, and a diplomat with an open purse was a much more interesting guest than one who counted his silver twice.

"Please," he told the man, gesturing at the crowded bay behind him with the particular weary grace of a man too long at sea, "I would gladly pay more than my share for a hot meal and a place by the fire. Whether or not the Earl wishes to hear my case."

The guard studied him, studied the jingling purse, and let the drawbridge down.

They fed Horace in the kitchens, and led Jude up a worn stone stair into a hall hung with tapestries and warmed by a hearth too large for the room, where he waited alone long enough to notice the crest above the mantel — a Suel design, old and proud, worn thin at the edges the way old pride tends to wear. When the Earl finally came, he came unhurried: fifty-some years old, black-haired despite his Suel blood, a longsword worn with the ease of a man who had used it more than once and did not need to prove it now.

When the courtesies had been exchanged, the Earl poured the wine himself — a matched pair of goblets, old silver worn thin at the chasing, filled from the same jug and set side by side on the table between them. He nudged them a finger's width apart, leaned back, and turned one hand open toward the pair. "Choose," he said. "A guest should never have to wonder what his host has put in the cup."

It was an old Suel courtesy, and a gracious one on its face. Jude read the second thing beneath it without trouble — that a man who made a ritual of proving his own honesty was, in the same motion, watching to see how a stranger answered the offer. He did not weigh the goblets, or trade them, or make any show of the choosing. He took the nearer one, drank, and let the Earl see that the question had never troubled him, which was its own kind of answer.

The Earl drank from the other, and studied his guest over the rim with the frank, unapologetic interest of a man who had few visitors left to study. "I find something strange about you," he said. "An elf,

plainly enough. But I have never before seen an elf with your eyes."

Jude did not flinch from it. He had stopped flinching from it years ago, though he had never stopped noticing when someone else did — the faint slit of pupil that opened wide and strange in low light, snake-quick, nothing an elf's eye ought to do. "A dragon in the family tree, perhaps," he said, lightly, and watched the Earl decide not to press further, filing the oddity away instead with the same careful attention he gave everything else about his guest.

By then Jude had placed him — or placed his house. This was a Lorchester, of the family that had once held the whole of Salinmoor and worn a power to match the title, and that had since been pared back, holding by holding, until nothing was left them but this one island and the grander style they still insisted upon. The crown had stopped keeping them powerful; the whales had never stopped keeping them rich. Whale oil out of these waters made the Lorchesters, by every account Jude had heard, the wealthiest house in Salinmoor yet — which made the hall around him a small puzzle: the hearth too large and the fire too meanly fed, the silver good but worn, the meat and bread a poorer table than any rich man's steward would set. Not poverty, then. A man with money who could not bear to spend it, who let his own hall go shabby sooner than part with a coin. Jude filed it away as the most useful thing he had learned since the gate.

The conversation that followed told Jude a great deal more than he offered in return. The Earl held little patience for Idee's troubles — *this bores me, Jude* — but no shortage of opinion on the war he had been posted to enforce: that the Duke of Gradsul meant, in the end, to bring the four Oeridian princes of the Sea Principalities to heel and only then treat with Port Toli, whose slaving the Duke's whole crusade was nominally meant to end. It was, the Earl allowed with something close to satisfaction, a fine excuse for an old rivalry, dressed in the clothes of a moral cause. He did not call it that outright. He did not need to. Jude had spent enough years reading men who chose their words for what they concealed rather than what they revealed to hear the truth of it anyway, and he let

the Earl believe he had been subtler than he was.

Jude gave him, in return, the shape of a plan and little of its substance — that he meant to carry Idee's plea to Monmurg, and that the surest road to Prince Jeon's ear ran through the Lord of the Foreign District, a certain Lord Jamis, whose name he let fall as though it were no more than a traveler's good sense. He did not say he had served the man before. He let it stand as the route any careful envoy might take, and watched the Earl mark it down behind his eyes.

"You are not merely an ambassador from some small country I've never heard of," the Earl said at last, leaning back, wine in hand. "So it is fortuitous fate has drawn you my way. For both of us, I think."

"How so, my lord?"

"Just as your Lord Jamis has the ear of Prince Jeon, I have the ear of the Duke himself. I'm always in want of good agents to bring me information." A pause, weighted, deliberate. "Troop movements. The temper of the city. The state of its granaries. Someone in want of a patron with real pockets would do well to remember who offered first."

Jude turned his wine glass slowly and said all the things a frightened, over-matched foreign envoy ought to say — that he sought only to serve Idee, that he understood nothing of Monmurg's defenses beyond what any traveler might notice, that he was, alas, entirely out of his depth among houses so great and dealings so far above his station. He did not say yes. He did not say no. He let the Earl believe he had planted a seed in soil that might, given time and money, grow something useful, and the Earl seemed content enough with that to offer, unprompted, the one thing Jude had actually come for.

"There's a man in Redshore. Owen Black — once of the Sea Principalities' own navy, now a smuggler and a knave, but he knows these shipping lanes and these patrols better than any man alive, and he owns his own ship. For the right price, he might take you as far as one of the outer islands. Perhaps even to Monmurg itself."

The Earl's eyes glinted, amused at his own generosity. "Find him at a bar called the Whale. Loud, scarred, hard to miss. Tell him nothing happens in Redshore without my say-so, and that I hope, in time, we'll find each other useful."

Jude thanked him with exactly as much warmth as the offer deserved — genuine enough to be believed, careful enough to promise nothing — and left the castle a little after nine, Horace falling into step beside him on the road back toward the waterfront's raucous, torch-lit sprawl of makeshift taverns.

"An interesting man," Horace offered, once they were well clear of the gate.

"He wanted me for a spy," Jude said, "and gave me a smuggler instead. I'll take the better bargain." He glanced sideways at his companion, weighing how much of the rest was worth saying aloud even here, and decided: little enough. "Watch what you say tonight. We're about to go looking for a man in a room full of people who'll sell what they hear to whichever side pays first."

"I generally assume that's true everywhere," Horace said, and Jude, for the first time since the man-of-wars had come alongside, allowed himself something close to a laugh.

CHAPTER TWO

Owen Black's Passage

The wine merchant found them before they found the Whale — a well-dressed Oeridian with two armed guards flanking his cart and a keg of something pale and foreign-tasting he called Chardonnay, and Jude, recognizing an easy source of gossip when one presented itself, bought three bottles at a price the man plainly considered a personal triumph.

It bought more than wine. Loosened by coin and the rare pleasure of a customer who didn't haggle, the merchant offered up everything Redshore had been whispering for weeks: that some sorcerer had turned a sea monster loose among the islands off Monmurg's strait, and that no ship of the Sea Principalities' navy could pass north of it unmolested; that Port Torvin had burned to the waterline not a fortnight past, every man, woman, and child put to the sword or the flame, and with it the last shipment of grain the Yeomanry had sent to feed a starving Monmurg; that the pirates responsible flew no colors of their own, but were said — by rumor, only by rumor, the merchant was careful to stress, refilling his glass — to answer to the new commandant of a backwater called Saltmarsh, in a province long thought too cursed and too marsh-ridden to matter to anyone.

"And the Toli," Jude said, watching the man's guards for any flicker of recognition rather than the man himself. "You've heard nothing of them in all this?"

The guards said nothing. That, in itself, told him something.

"The Toli purchase whatever peace they can buy," the merchant said, with the vague unease of a man repeating something he

did not fully understand and did not wish to. "Strange things are happening in these waters that have nothing to do with dukes or princes."

Jude thanked him for his candor and his Chardonnay in equal measure, and left three bottles heavier and considerably better informed. The wine merchant had no notion where the Whale might be found, but a fisherman mending his nets at the water's edge did, and pointed Jude two hundred feet down the pier toward a raucous, lantern-lit tangle of driftwood tables that answered to the name. The way there carried him past the source of Redshore's wealth and its stink alike — the rendering sheds strung along the shore where the city boiled its whales down to oil, the reek of hot blubber and woodsmoke hanging greasy over the waterfront, thick enough to taste and clinging to everything it touched: the awnings, the fish, the crowd, the wine still on his breath. The smell of money, Jude supposed, and no sweeter for it.

Owen Black was not hard to find. A quiet word to the serving maid — that Jude waited on an old friend who owed him a drink — earned a knowing look and a nod toward the corner, where a scarred, loud, unmistakably Oeridian man sat with a knot of hard-looking company. Jude sent a mug across with his compliments and waited; and before he had finished his own second cup, the man drained the gift in a single pull, rose, and crossed the floor to settle into the seat across from them with the easy confidence of someone who already knew he was being courted.

"You have me at a disadvantage, friend," he said. "Who sent you my way?"

"He lives across the water, in the large stone construction."

Owen Black's grin widened. "Ah. Say no more. He wouldn't send you unless you had need of me."

The terms were simple enough, once the pleasantries had run their course: fifty gold now, fifty on landing, passage for two only, no promises about anyone else's ship in the harbor making the same run. Jude paid half up front and watched the man's eyes track the weight of the purse rather than its contents, filing away the

small, useful fact that Owen Black valued coin more than curiosity — a trait Jude had found, over a great many years, to be the single most reliable quality in a hired man.

They boarded within the hour. Owen's sloop proved fast and lean beneath a hull scorched black in patches along the deck — old fire damage, poorly scrubbed away, that the man explained with a shrug and no real elaboration: the ship had been stolen from him some months back, returned to him afterward, and he professed not to know how the scorching had come to be there. Jude let the story sit unchallenged. A man in his trade collected more secrets than he could use, and this one belonged to someone else's story.

They ran without lights through waters thick with anchored merchantmen, Owen threading the gaps between hulls with the unhurried skill of a man who had done it a hundred times before, and by the small hours they were clear of the bay entirely, running south along a coastline of green rolling hills that gave no sign, in the moon's poor light, of any war at all.

"There's not much west of Angler Island," Owen said, when Jude asked after the low smudge of land visible off the port bow. "Saltmarsh has docks now, if you believe it. New lord there, trying to make something of the place."

"And the sea monster the merchant spoke of?"

Owen was quiet a moment too long before he answered. "If there's truth in that rumor, I'd wager on one of the sea turtles out of the Dragon Isles. I've sailed past them myself. Strange storms out there — a mist once, thick as a hurricane, in a sea too shallow to breed one honestly." He nodded toward a point on the dark water Jude could barely make out, low clouds clinging to the horizon at the very edge of sight. "And there — do you see it? An old fort, built a hundred and fifty years back against the sahaugin. A Toli princeling holds it now. Ships come and go from there at all hours, and every time the Monmurgian fleet tries to sally in force, that's when the storms come up."

Jude filed the fort away beside the sea turtle and the mist and the burning of Port Torvin, one more piece in a shape he did not

yet have enough pieces to see clearly, and said nothing more of consequence until Owen's men put the longboat over the side within sight of Ensar's rocky beach, near dawn.

"When you reach the city," Owen said, taking the second half of his fee, "put in a good word for me with whoever you've come to see. Tell them Owen Black is well in Monmurg, and means to keep it so. That's the only message I need carried."

Traveling from Ensar to Monmurg went slowly, Jude and Horace hauling the wine crate slung between two poles like the poorest sort of porters — not the three bottles of Chardonnay, which rode easily enough in a pack, but the heavier case of fine Celene vintage Jude had carried across an entire ocean since Scant and kept back, untouched, as a gift for Lord Jamis. A tanner with a mule cart agreed, for two gold coins, to carry them the rest of the way to the city.

He talked the whole thirty miles, and Jude let him, offering wine and careful questions in the proportions that kept the man's tongue loose without ever making him suspicious of why an elf claiming to be from Redshore cared so much about ships and storms and Toli movements in the middle bay. He learned that the tanner had seen the same fortress-island Owen had pointed out, more than once, and that ships sailed to and from it freely by daylight, in numbers that had nothing to do with smuggling. He learned the name that went with it — Cain Toli — offered up for the price of a single gold coin and a shared bottle. He learned that the Monmurgian fleet had sallied twice in recent memory, and both times been driven back by storms that broke, with suspicious punctuality, the moment the fleet cleared the strait. And he learned, last and worst, that Port Torvin's destruction had been laid at the feet of a man called Captain Crimson — by all accounts a Toli agent, though rumored to answer, strangely, to the new commandant of Saltmarsh rather than to any prince of his own house.

"I'll tell you what," Jude said at last, as the walls of Monmurg rose ahead of them in the last grey light of evening, "I would pay you to speak of all this to a man I know here. A Lord Jamis."

The tanner's easy chatter dried up at once. "A man as important

as Lord Jamis," he said, careful now, "surely knows all that I know."

"Perhaps," Jude allowed, and let the matter drop, and pressed an extra handful of silver into the man's palm anyway, for a name and a fort and a suspicion he intended to make considerably more use of than the tanner would ever learn.

They reached the gates a little before eight, on the evening of the first of Wealsun — a year and a season since Jude had last stood inside them, and the city that opened before him was not the one he remembered. The Grand Market beyond the gate, which by his memory ought to have been a wall of noise and color even at this hour, stood half empty, its stalls given over more to the sale of bread and porridge than of silk or spice. The guards who searched them were thorough in a way peacetime guards rarely bothered to be. And when Jude gave his name and stated his business — an audience, if it could be arranged, with Lord Jamis — the escort that arrived to collect him came twelve men strong, polite, unsmiling, and entirely unsurprised.

"Leave the wine," the sergeant told him, when Jude reached for the crate at the Bailey's door. "You can tell Lord Jamis of your gift."

Jude left it, and Horace beside it, and let himself be led down a corridor he remembered rather better than he let the guards see, toward a small, well-furnished room hung with charts of the Azure Sea — and toward the one conversation, of everything that had happened since Idee, that he suspected would actually matter.

CHAPTER THREE

The War of Spies

Lord Jamis kept him waiting ten minutes, which Jude judged deliberate, and used to pace the small room's worn carpet and take its measure again: the charts, the navigation instruments gathering dust on a shelf that spoke of a younger man who had once sailed farther than most of his countrymen, the two chairs set at a careful, unthreatening distance from each other. He had sat in this room before. It had not changed. He was less certain, this time, that he had not.

"So," Jamis said, when he finally came in and settled across from him, unhurried, "you've returned from your journeys."

"I return in a season of plenty," Jude said, "and find, on arriving, a great deal of hardship."

"What brings you back?"

He gave it plainly enough — Karmirg, the ruin of Idee's hill levies without him, the hope of some loan or trade concession that might keep a small, drowning country afloat a season longer. He watched Jamis's face for the tell he half-expected and did not find one; only that same unhurried attention, and, every few seconds, a finger raised absently to his lips, moving as though shaping words with no sound behind them, a habit Jude found himself unable to stop watching.

"Let me ask a question first, Jude. Idee. What news of it — is there someone there you serve?"

"No one but your lordship, in truth," Jude said, and told the rest honestly enough, because honesty, deployed selectively, had always served him better than the alternative: how Lord Anlauf Ogmotton

— the ruler of Idee, a half-elf and a leader of rare charisma, his realm bled white by the Herzog's wars in the south and the wave that had drowned half of Naree — had staked the last of his hope and coin on sending Jude west after Karmir; the long crossing out of Scant; and then the blockade, the two men-of-war, Redshore, the Earl.

Jamis's stillness sharpened at that. "You've been in Redshore."

"I have. I spoke with the Earl himself."

"Did the Earl ask you to assassinate me?"

"No," Jude said, and put both hands up, palms open, letting the gesture do work his voice could not. "I swear it. Even had he asked, I would not have thought of it."

"I will know if you are lying to me."

"Then know that I'm not." He held the look a moment, then let his hands drop and his shoulders ease, and watched something in Jamis's posture ease with them. "He did offer me something, though I doubt it will surprise you. Coin, in exchange for whatever I might learn of you, and of Prince Jeon's intentions. I told him nothing that mattered. He gave me a smuggler in return, and I used the man to reach your gates, which I judge the better half of that bargain."

"That's whose ship my man in Ensar saw you with." Jamis studied him a long moment, and then, unexpectedly, laughed — short, dry, more relief in it than humor. "Yes. I see."

He rose, crossed to a cabinet, and came back with a single bottle and two glasses, and something in the room's temperature changed as he poured — the careful interrogation folding itself away, replaced by something closer to the old ease Jude remembered from years before. "My brother-in-law brought me this a week past. Try it."

"To your health," Jude said, lifting the glass, "and to the success of Monmurg in difficult times," and meant at least half of it.

It was there, over the wine, that Jamis began, in earnest, to tell him how bad things truly were — a telling that went on long enough, and ranged wide enough, that Jude understood he was being trusted with more than an old agent's due. A month and

a half past, an evoker out of Gradsul named Lord Phranck had come to Monmurg seeking an audience with Jamis himself — that was how the man first crossed his notice. Uncertain of Phranck's purpose, and curious to see how the Toli would answer his arrival, Jamis had set Gouge and Karmirg to shadow him as hired swords rather than reveal his own hand. Four Toli assassins had struck at Phranck on the docks that same visit — the sort of killers used only against great nobles, which told its own story about how seriously the Toli regarded him — and in the fighting's aftermath, Phranck had read the dying mind of one of the attackers and let slip, almost in passing, that a Toli adventurer named Cain Toli had come into possession of some rare and terrible artifact.

"An artifact," Jamis said, "that we believe controls one of the dragon turtles out of the Dragon Isles. The greatest of them — the very one we've paid our tribute to for a hundred and fifty years. We've lost three ships trying to run the blockade since. Every time we sally in force, a storm rises that has no business existing in these waters, and the fleet limps home, or doesn't come home at all."

"I heard something of a fort," Jude offered, "held in the middle bay. A tanner told me ships come and go from it freely, and that they leave whenever your fleet tries to sail."

"That would be Cain Toli's island," Jamis said, something sharpening behind his eyes at the confirmation. "You sailed past it yourself, on your way in with Owen Black."

The rest came in pieces, each one worse than the last. Phranck, it seemed, had not come to Monmurg out of simple diplomacy. He was a Suel evoker of no great house — a journeyman still climbing among the courts of Gradsul — and Jamis's brother-in-law there, a Suel courtier named Zafar Azane, had confirmed what the man's diplomat's manner concealed: that the Duke of Gradsul had granted Phranck secret office as an Inquisitor of the Office of Forbidden Magic and sent him south into Salinmoor to hunt necromancy. His quarry was a cult calling itself the Sons of Olan — necromancers who cohabited with kobolds in the marshes near Westkeep and brewed a black, madness-inducing drink, the same

black sickness now creeping through the Principalities. He did not hunt it alone: he traveled with a gnome alchemist, Seebo Beren, once assistant to the royal alchemist of Keoland, said to be seeking a cure for that sickness. And when Phranck left Monmurg, he had been taken captive by Cain Toli himself and held on that same island fortress, before escaping by means Jamis did not know and plainly wished he did.

"I don't know where Phranck's loyalties truly lie," Jamis admitted. "He works for the Duke of Gradsul, that much is certain. But he is ambitious past the point of easy use, and Zafar believes we might yet turn him — through Seebo, who he's close to, and who Zafar very much wants as an agent of ours."

There was more still: an elf spy named Kalisi, planted in Monmurg by Phranck months before and since turned, or apparently turned, into one of Jamis's own couriers — the same woman who had helped deliver a traitorous harbormaster into Toli hands at Port Torvin, only for the pickup to become the massacre that burned the town to the waterline. A Monmurgian merchant, grown rich smuggling goods through Saltmarsh under Keoland's nose, who Phranck had questioned and frightened badly enough to send running home. A mad alchemist in the foreign district who Phranck had also visited, for reasons Jamis had not yet untangled. And beneath all of it, a deeper and more unsettling shape: that the Duke of Gradsul, denied a Suel bride from any great house of Keoland for two generations running, had been offered one at last by the Toli — pure Suel blood to continue his line — in exchange for grinding the four Oeridian princes of the Sea Principalities into the sea, after which, Jamis suspected, the Duke would find himself very much alone with allies who had never wanted anything but his fleet spent and his enemies dead.

"The Scarlet Brotherhood," Jamis said, low, "have made inroads into the very Magical Academy at Gradsul. Zafar believes they're shipping arms into the Duchy of Berghof under everyone's nose, and that this alliance of Toli and Gradsul and Berghof is meant to clear the Sea Principalities from the board entirely. I don't say this

to Jeon. I don't say this to anyone, save you, now."

Jude sat with that a long moment, turning it the way he turned any problem too large to solve outright — into pieces small enough to be worked at one at a time. "And you believe I can help you sort truth from performance in all of this. More than Gouge could. More than Karmirg."

"Their loyalty is beyond question," Jamis said. "Their insight into magic is not. I need a scalpel as well as a cutlass, Jude, and right now the fog in front of me is thick enough that I can't tell which end of the knife I'm holding." He opened a drawer, and set on the table between them a familiar ring — the one he had taken from Jude years before, in the old days of half-trust and mutual use that had defined their arrangement then. "Take it back. You'll need it for my purposes. The truth is, I am desperate enough that I would take you into my service this hour, and trust you more, in this particular matter, than almost anyone else I have."

Jude took the ring, turned it once between his fingers, and put it on without further comment, which seemed answer enough for both of them.

What followed was practical in the way Jamis's instructions always were — precise, hedged, designed to be denied later if it came to that. Jude was to seek out three threads: Kalisi, who knew Phranck best and was, not incidentally, being tested for her true loyalties by being told rather less than she believed she was told; the merchant Phranck had frightened out of Saltmarsh; and the mad alchemist in the foreign district, whom Phranck had also visited and whom Jamis suspected knew more than he let on. Jude would live at Ferd's, as he always had, and receive his stipend and his messages through Kalisi, who did not yet know Jude answered to the same master she did, and whom Jamis meant to use, in turn, as a test — if word of some invented indiscretion of Jude's failed to reach Jamis by any route but Kalisi's own mouth, he would know exactly where her true loyalties sat.

"If you ever come to distrust her outright," Jamis said, "or suspect the Toli have turned her against me, come to me directly. I'll

know something is badly wrong. Until then, let her think you're approachable. Let the Toli believe it too."

"And if I need a man questioned somewhere quieter than an alley?"

"Ask Kalisi to send you One Thumb. You remember him."

"I remember what came of Karmirg's threats of vengeance, sworn from under his knives," Jude said, "which is to say nothing at all. He went on with his work."

Jamis's mouth curved, the closest thing to real warmth Jude had seen from him all evening. "Then you understand him well enough."

There was one more matter Jude would not leave unspoken, whatever else the night had cost his original errand. "Idee still stands, Lord Jamis, for now. If there's any way to warn Celeborn Landroval — Anlauf Ogmotton's regent — of what you suspect the Scarlet Brotherhood intends beyond the South Province, I would ask it of you as the last of what I came here for."

"I'll see a message sent," Jamis said, "though the seas between here and there are no longer safe for anyone to carry it. That is the truth of everything now, Jude. Nothing is safe. Not the seas, not the city, not the men who serve me." He rose, signaling the audience's end, weariness settling visibly back over him now that the performance of it was done. "At least you'll have seen Monmurg once more, before we learn whether it falls."

"I sincerely hope it does not," Jude said, and bowed the elf's quick, economical bow, and meant that too, more than he had expected to when he'd walked in.

Horace was waiting on the Bailey steps when the guards released him, wine crate at his feet, patient as ever. "Well?" he asked, once they were clear of the door and out into the cooling evening air.

"More of the same conversation we had on the ship," Jude said, which was not quite a lie. He nodded at the crate between Horace's feet. "And bring that — Lord Jamis has no need of it. In a city gone this hungry, a crate of good Celene wine will serve his purposes

better spent a cup at a time, loosening the right tongues, than it ever would as a courtesy gathering dust in his cellar. Come. I know a place we can take a room, and before the night's done I think I'll want you sober and watching the door."

CHAPTER FOUR

Ferd's

Ferd's had not changed in Jude's absence, which was itself a kind of comfort in a city that had changed around it in nearly every other particular. The same low-beamed common room, the same watchful proprietor cleaning the same glasses behind a bar he kept, by long habit, within reach of a loaded crossbow. A handful of new faces had drifted in with the hard times — Olman wildmen down from the Amedio jungle, a pair of Toli rats hunting odd jobs, men too proud or too rejected to find berths on a slave ship or in the navy — but the bones of the place were the same, and Jude claimed the same corner table he always had, back to the wall, a clear line to the door, and let seventeen pairs of curious eyes take his measure while Horace Baldpate set down the crate of wine that had survived, against considerable odds, an entire ocean.

It was an inn as much as a bar, in the way of the foreign district's better dives — two narrow rooms above the common floor, reached by a stair at the back that Ferd kept an eye on the way another man might keep an eye on his till. One had been Jude's, before he'd left for Idee; the other belonged, by long and unspoken arrangement, to Gouge, whenever business kept him in the city rather than wherever Jamis's other errands sent him. Karmirg, when he was still welcome anywhere near the place, had never troubled himself with a room at all, preferring to sleep it off wherever he'd fallen in the common room below — a habit that had cost Ferd more broken furniture than either of them cared to tally, and that Jude, reclaiming his old key that first evening, was privately relieved not to have to contend with just yet.

He did not see Gouge or Karmirg that first night, which did not trouble him; Jamis had made plain enough that their paths would need to cross, if at all, without acknowledgment. What he wanted first was smaller and more practical, and considerably less dangerous than anything Jamis had asked of him: a still, and the excuse it would give him to sit in this room for months at a time without anyone wondering why an elf wizard had suddenly taken such an interest in Ferd's custom.

Horace did not stay. He had carried the wine as far as Ferd's and set it down without complaint, but the place — its listening walls, its back-room schemes, the slow business Jude meant to make of it — was Jude's trade and not his, and he said as much, plainly and without offense. He would take a room down nearer the Harbor District instead, where a man who knew ships could find honest work along the wharves for as long as the war left any. They squared his wages there in the common room, honestly and in full, and parted on good terms. "You know where I'll be," Horace said, shouldering his pack. "Come find me if you ever want a blade at your back — and in this city, I don't imagine you'll go long without." Jude thought he was likely right, and told him so, and watched him go.

The alchemist he went to for the still was no accident of convenience. He was one of the three threads Jamis had set him to pull — the mad alchemist of the foreign district, the one Lord Phranck had called on before Cain Toli took him — and a paying commission made as good a key to that door as Jude was likely to come by. That he wanted the still in earnest, too, only made the cover the neater; Jude had always preferred an errand that served two purposes at once. The man kept a cramped, well-known curio shop off one of the district's squares, wealthy for all the disorder of it, cluttered floor to ceiling with jars and copper fittings and healing draughts and the particular chaos of a man who trusted his own memory over any system of order. He produced the components for a small still with the enthusiasm of a craftsman glad of honest work, and when Jude asked after recipes, pulled down a heavy, much-thumbed volume and opened it with something close to rev-

erence.

"The 'Magnum Opus,'" he said. "By Ujor Udias. Every alchemist worth the name owns a copy. This is mine." He flipped to a diagrammed page and tapped it twice. "Simple spirits. This is what you want."

"Is it the only copy?"

"The Magnum Opus'? No — every alchemist has a copy of the 'Magnum Opus,' though none so complex as the original. Simple things, truly. Very simple." He named a price, took his coin without counting it twice, and set Jude up with paper and quill to copy down what he needed, then went back to assembling copper fittings while Jude bent over the recipes, one ear on the shop bell.

It was while he wrote that the alchemist, glancing up from his work, went suddenly and frankly still.

"An elf," he said slowly, "but something else." He came closer, studying Jude's eyes in the lamplight with the same clinical attention he'd given the still's fittings. "You've been touched. Molded."

"Rather unpleasantly, they told me," Jude said, and did not look away. "Though I like to think not entirely into the shape my enemies would have preferred."

"A transmuter did this to you."

"One of the more sinister ones out of the southern lands, yes." Jude let the smallest, coldest edge into his voice, the one he reserved for a very short list of things. "You know of them?"

"I know of them. Not much, but I know they exist." The alchemist studied him a moment longer, something almost like pity in it. "You've been touched by the Scarlet Brotherhood, I take it."

"I'd love to compare notes with you sometime," Jude said, "because I intend to kill every one of them I find."

The alchemist did not press further, only handed him the last of the paper with a murmured *I understand* that Jude suspected was more honest than most people's sympathy, and went back to his fittings, and Jude went back to his recipes, and neither of them spoke of it again that evening.

He walked back to Ferd's in the dark with the still's parts promised for delivery within the week, three recipes for spirits copied out in his own careful hand, and the beginnings of a plan already forming — a still in the cellar, cheap liquor brewed from the noble houses' cast-off fruit and grain, and a room upstairs where soldiers and sailors and foreign-district toughs would drink themselves loose-tongued on his hospitality, never once suspecting that the quiet elf who kept to his corner was listening to every word of it. It was not the mission he had sailed from Idee to complete. It would, he suspected, matter a great deal more before it was finished.

Above him, past the gates and the guards and the long climb to the palace on the hill, Lord Jamis and Prince Jeon were already turning over the fates of princes and blockades in rooms Jude had no part in yet — though that, too, would not remain true for long. Somewhere closer, in a chamber he had never seen and could not have named, a masked young man he had not yet met was bent over a lump of clay and old magic, working toward a thing of his own that would, within a day, put both their names in the same room at last.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Ghost in the Halls

Paul Revero had been born into a scandal and raised inside its shadow, and by the time he was old enough to understand either for what it was, both had already hardened into the architecture of his life.

His mother, Lady Alaria, was Prince Jeon's sister. She had been sixteen when she became pregnant with Paul, unmarried, and she never named the father — not then, and not in the years after, however hard Jeon pressed her for it. He was angry, but not cruel, and he loved her: he kept both mother and child, housed them in a style equal to his own, and never forgave either of them for her silence.

Paul remembered almost none of his life before the age of six. What he had instead were fragments — his mother's grief, present even in memories that predated whatever accident had left him scarred; small magical creatures that visited him in dreams and, he suspected now, in fact; a room full of wondrous things, glimpsed and then gone. The fire that had taken his face, his hair, the ordinary use of his skin, arrived in memory only as an absence, a place where six-year-old Paul's recollection simply stopped and did not resume until he was old enough to understand that everyone around him flinched, however briefly, whatever they schooled their faces to show afterward.

He had grown up masked, therefore, first by necessity and then by habit — leather in the day-to-day, because it was lighter and quieter than metal, and clothing sufficient to keep the ruin of his skin from anyone's sight, because he had learned early that the horror people felt looking at him was a thing he could spare them,

and spare himself, by simply not being seen. He had become, by slow and mostly unplanned degrees, very good at not being seen. He knew the palace's back halls and servants' stairs better than its state rooms. He could take food from the kitchens, clothing from his own wardrobe, information from any conversation held carelessly near an open door, and leave no more trace of himself than a held breath.

It had not made him beloved. His uncle's household tolerated his presence at council and at table because his blood demanded it, and gave him nothing else — no post, no command, no duty of any kind, while cousins five years his junior took their first commissions in the Monmurgian navy and led mercenary companies in the port district. Paul understood, without anyone troubling to say it aloud, that he unsettled people: his face when it showed, his manner when he forgot to guard it, the blunt and often unwelcome accuracy of things he said before he had learned to weigh whether saying them was wise. He was, by his own private reckoning, considerably more intelligent than most of the men who were trusted with responsibilities he was not. It changed nothing. Cleverness that arrived wrapped in social wreckage tended to be received, he had found, as a curiosity rather than a qualification.

His mother had been the one fixed point in all of it — insular herself, frozen in a grief she had never fully explained even to him, but present, and his. When she died, in the spring of his twenty-third year, she came briefly clear at the end, gripping his hand while Jeon held the other. "Paul, what will you do without me?" And then, when Jeon pressed her — gently, but pressed nonetheless, one final time, for the name he had wanted for twenty-three years — she gave him nothing but the shape of a mercy: "He was a good man. Of royal blood, brother. I loved him dearly. I promised I would never reveal who he was." She asked only that Jeon do right by his nephew, and died before either man could ask her anything more.

Jeon wept, which surprised Paul more than the death itself had — a prince of pirates, a man who had buried soldiers and burned enemies and made peace with worse things than grief, undone for

a handful of minutes by his sister's hand going slack in his own. He composed himself quickly enough afterward, and was, in his own fashion, honest with Paul about what came next: the wing of the palace Alaria had occupied would go to more senior relations; Paul would move back into his mother's own childhood chambers on the east side of the castle, smaller, plainer, with a fine view of the sea he did not particularly mind; his attendance at council, tolerated until now at his mother's insistence, would quietly lapse. "I have no real use for you," Jeon told him, not unkindly, in the way a man states a fact he has turned over many times and stopped being able to soften.

Paul had not been able to leave it there. "You've never given me a chance," he said, and when his uncle asked, not unreasonably, what use he imagined himself to be, Paul offered the one true thing he had: that he moved through the palace unseen, that servants and guards alike forgot to watch what they said in his presence, that he had spent twenty-three years becoming a ghost in his own family's halls, and a ghost, properly used, heard things a garrison of loyal soldiers never would. Jeon had not said no. He had said, instead, that such work belonged to spymasters, that his own spymaster was a man named Lord Jamis, and that he would consider whether Paul's peculiar talents might be put toward something better than solitude — a door left ajar, where every door before had been shut outright.

It was the nearest thing to hope Paul had been offered in longer than he cared to count, and in the week that followed, waiting for his uncle to remember the promise amid a blockade and a council in constant session, Paul did what he had always done when the world declined to include him: he went looking for something to occupy the silence himself, and moved back into rooms he had not slept in since before the fire, in a wing of the palace that, he was about to discover, remembered a great deal more of his childhood than he did.

CHAPTER SIX

The Room Behind the Wall

The itching that woke him a week after his mother's funeral was not, at first, on his skin.

Paul had burnt the black opium stick down to a stub before he'd stumbled to bed — stronger than what he usually kept, thick and heavy in a way that had filled the small chamber with more smoke than he remembered lighting for, and the dreams that came with it were vivid in a way ordinary sleep rarely gave him. He woke uncertain of the hour, hands going to his face out of old habit, and found the itch not in the scarred ruin of his skin but somewhere behind his eyes — a memory trying to surface, insistent as a splinter working its way out.

Little friends. Small, magical, half-remembered things that had visited his dreams for as long as he could recall and never once, until tonight, felt like more than dreaming.

He got up, crossed to the balcony, and let the sea air clear the smoke from his head, looking down past the Royal Docks to where a scatter of lit windows marked Lord Jamis's residence on the cliff below. The dream did not clear with the smoke. He had lived in this room as a child — he remembered that much plainly enough, the bed, the balcony, the long climb of stairs — but the memory insisted there had been more to it. A room beyond a door, filled with wondrous things. Bottles. Devices. His mother close by, and beyond her, through some threshold he could no longer place, the place where he had played.

He went to the closet.

It took him longer than it should have to notice that the back wall

didn't sit quite true — a veneer of plaster laid smooth and painted over stone that had no business being plastered at all, the sort of thing done by someone who wanted a wall to look like it had always been a wall. He worked his dagger into the seam and peeled it back in long, satisfying strips, and beneath it found a stone door, old and simple, closed on a lock no more complicated than the ones he'd taught himself to pick from books he was fairly sure his mother had never known he'd read.

He dressed properly before he opened it — leathers, mask, gloves, the whole quiet armor of a man who did not want to be recognized by his own face — and worked the lock with his thieves' tools until it gave, and stepped through into a corridor three feet wide and reeking of years of undisturbed dark.

It sloped downward for sixty feet before opening onto a stair, and the stair dropped another eighty beyond that, deep enough that he lost any sense of where in the palace he stood relative to where he'd started. Dust and cobwebs thickened with every step. A guardroom, long abandoned, showed arrow slits looking out toward the sea — the same view as his own balcony, he realized, only far lower, a fortification built for a siege nobody living remembered planning for. And beneath all of it, walking corridors his feet seemed to know before his mind caught up to them, the flashbacks came faster: *I have been here. I have walked this before.*

The room, when he reached it, told him why.

Even in the torchlight, ruined as it was, he recognized the bed he'd slept in as a small child, his mother beside him; the table where she'd read to him from books whose covers he still remembered by color and weight. And past that, through a doorway with no door left in its frame — only scorch marks radiating outward across the stone, and the wreckage of a table and cistern and a scatter of burnt glass and metal — the place his memory had been circling since he'd woken. He knew it the way a body knows a wound long after the mind has stopped consciously guarding it: this was where the fire had started. Somewhere in the wreckage of that table, a smaller version of himself, curious past the point of caution, had reached for

something he shouldn't have and brought the whole room down in flame around him.

He picked his way through broken glass that still smelled, faintly, of ozone and old chemistry, to a row of squat barrels marked with three red X's apiece — and something in him, some old, wordless certainty, said *dangerous* before his mind had finished forming the thought, and behind it, fainter, his mother's voice: "Breathing in even a minute amount of that will kill you, Paul." He opened one anyway, carefully, and found a pale yellow powder he didn't recognize by sight but that pulled at some buried memory all the same, and took a careful sample in a shard of glass before sealing the lid again.

The oven in the room beyond gave up two rats, oversized and vicious, that he killed without much difficulty — one gutted on his dagger, the other burned to death against the flat of his torch, its fangs weeping a strange, faintly yellow fluid he chose not to examine too closely. A locked door farther on resisted his picks in a way no ordinary lock ever had, something on the far side pushing back against his tools as though the mechanism itself objected to his presence, and when he pressed his eye to the keyhole he found torchlight burning steadily beyond it — Lord Jamis's own residence, he understood slowly, close enough that his mother's secret room and the Admiral's private chambers had once, long ago, shared a threshold. He did not force it. Whatever waited on the other side would keep.

It was the chest, in the end, that answered the question the whole night had been building toward.

Three small clay figurines sat nested among a scatter of books — creatures like little gargoyles, wings folded tight to their backs. He lifted one free, and it woke: the clay warming to something like muscle in his gloved hand, wings shivering open, a mouth he had not noticed splitting wide to close a ring of small teeth on the leather over his palm. It drew blood, or would have, had the glove let it reach skin. He did not so much kill it as unmake it — pinned it to the table, worked his dagger into the seam of its jaw, and levered

the little body apart until the clay went inert in his hand, no more alive than the two that had never stirred beside it.

What it had been carrying sat where a heart should have been. He held the stone to the torchlight and turned it slowly, and it resolved into something he could name: an emerald, green and clear, cut into a small and deliberate heart. He did not pocket it at once but sat with it a while — a thing of value, shaped with care, left eighty feet beneath the palace among the ruin of his mother's work — before he went looking for its match. He found it in a smaller box set apart from the rest, one that, he somehow knew, had once made his mother weep for hours whenever she opened it: a second emerald, larger, cut not as a heart but as a many-faceted orb that broke the torchlight into a dozen green splinters. He weighed the two together in his palm, heart and orb, and understood that they belonged together without yet understanding how, or to what.

The books beneath the figurines were two he could not read at all — spellbooks, almost certainly his mother's — and a third, thinner, that he could. "The Homunculi," the title page read, the work of one Grayson Jamis — a name that meant nothing to him, set down in a firm and deliberate hand and echoed again in the crowded notes along the margins. It was the name itself that stopped him, though he could not yet have said why.

He sat with that a long moment, in a ruined room eighty feet under his own bedroom, turning a name he had never once heard spoken at any of the royal dinners or council sessions over and over, waiting to see if it would resolve into anything more than a stranger's name on a borrowed book. It did not, not yet. But it settled into him the way the stone door's lock had settled against his picks — a small, deliberate resistance, the sense of something on the other side of a wall that very much wanted to stay unopened.

He gathered what he could carry — the figurines, the box of letters, all three books, his sample of the pale yellow powder — resealed the barrel, and climbed the eighty feet and sixty feet and the last stretch of narrow corridor back to his own closet, pushing the old clothes back over the broken plaster, and sat on the edge of

his bed until nearly three in the morning with the letters unopened in his lap, because he already suspected, in the particular cold and certain way he suspected most things, that once he opened them he would not be able to go back to not knowing.

He opened them anyway. He had never once, in twenty-three years, managed to leave a door closed simply because someone had wanted it to stay that way.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Letters

There were a dozen letters in the box, tied loosely enough that Paul guessed they had been read and re-read many times before whatever grief finally sealed them away, and he read them in the order his mother had kept them, by lamplight, until the words on the page had gone soft with how many times he'd gone back over them.

Grayson wrote from Gradsul, from the Magical Academy there — from its School of Transmutation, one of the several schools of magic the Academy kept — which admitted, as best Paul could piece together, mostly the sons and daughters of Suel nobles from the Duchy, with the occasional outsider let in on sufferance or sponsorship. Grayson had gotten in somehow, and spent the letters' span working, with what read like real devotion, on a single project: *I have been working tirelessly on recreating the pale yellow powder — the very weapon that once turned the tides against the sahaugin. Its potential is immense, and I am driven by the hope that it will secure peace and prosperity for our beloved principalities.* He never said, in any letter Paul found, exactly what the weapon did. He wrote instead like a man trying to earn something — a peace with himself, a peace with his own family, and, running under every line of every letter like a current, a place in Alaria's future that his station alone did not entitle him to.

A name recurred through the letters that meant nothing to Paul on its own — Archibald, mentioned three or four times in passing, once with real warmth, never explained. And near the end of the stack, tangled together in a way that took Paul the better part of

an hour and a fair amount of frustrated arithmetic to untangle, a family tree he had not known he belonged to: Grayson's uncle was a man named Zafar Azane, a Suel wizard high in Keoland's magical academies — and Zafar's sister was Lady Jamis. Which meant, if the letters said what Paul thought they said, that Grayson Jamis was the son of Lord Jamis and Lady Jamis both — Prince Jeon's own admiral and spymaster — and that the young man who had loved Alaria and never quite managed to prove himself worthy of marrying her had been, all along, close enough to the throne to have made the whole scandal entirely unnecessary, had anyone simply been honest twenty-three years sooner.

Paul sat with the arithmetic of it until his head ached. "Lord Jamis does what Jeon says," he told himself, working it through out loud in the empty room, as if saying it might make the thing settle into sense. "Lord Jamis is a servant of my uncle. And if this is true, then Lord Jamis's son is —" He did not finish the sentence, even alone, even to himself. It felt like the kind of sentence that needed a witness before it could be trusted.

The last letter was stranger than the rest, and troubled him more. Grayson wrote of the man called Archibald — relentless, the letter said, in his pursuit of "The Magnum Opus," the true original manuscript, convinced it lay hidden in the dungeons of the Office of Forbidden Magic in Gradsul, guarded by inquisitors and wards no ordinary scholar had any business testing himself against. *His passion is infectious*, Grayson had written, *and I find myself drawn, against my better judgment, into the possibility of unlocking such mysteries*. Paul read that line four times and did not like what it implied. A man in love, trying to prove himself to a prince who would never quite accept him, pulled along by a friend's obsession into something that sounded, even filtered through twenty-three-year-old ink, considerably more dangerous than alchemy for its own sake.

He did not sleep that night, not properly. He lay turning the names over — Grayson, Zafar, Archibald, the strange half-remembered weapon meant to hold back the sahaugin, the family that had apparently been his all along without anyone troubling to

tell him — and by the time the sky beyond his balcony had gone from black to the grey of early morning, he had already decided what he meant to do with the knowledge, which was the one thing his mother, in twenty-three years of careful silence, had never once managed: he meant to ask, directly, of the people who could actually answer.

He dressed, gathered the letters, and left the homunculus book behind, tucked back into its hiding place beneath his bed — some instinct telling him that was not the thing to carry into Lady Jamis's house first — and went to find his grandmother, though he did not yet have the nerve to call her that, even privately, even once.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Grandmother

The servant who answered Lord Jamis's door kept his voice carefully level when Paul gave his name, and could not quite keep the fear out of it all the same. Paul had grown used to that particular failure in people, the way his presence made even well-trained composure crack at the edges, and waited without comment while the man went to announce him.

He came back within five minutes, which Paul understood — correctly, he would learn — meant Lady Jamis had not hesitated at all.

She received him alone, in a well-appointed study laid with wine and cheese and fruit as though she had been expecting a guest of consequence rather than the prince's nephew of dubious parentage, arriving unannounced — a woman in her sixties or seventies, hair gone to white shot through with the ghost of what had once been red, unmistakably Suel in a way that made the whole shape of Grayson's letters snap suddenly, uncomfortably, into focus. Paul had known, in the abstract, that Lord Jamis had married outside his own people. He had never once had cause to wonder what that meant for the blood running in his own veins until this exact moment, sitting across from a woman who might, if the letters spoke true, be his father's mother.

"I am flattered you have come to give me an audience," she said, when the servant had withdrawn and the door was shut, "even unexpected as it is."

"I'm sorry for coming without notice," Paul said. He had never learned the art of easing into a difficult thing, and did not attempt

to learn it now. "I've been going through my mother's possessions. I have reason to believe you are my grandmother." He set the letters on the table between them without further preamble.

Something moved behind her composure — fear, plainly, though whether of him or of what he carried he couldn't yet tell. "You have a son named Grayson," Paul said. "Had," she answered, which was not quite agreement and not quite denial. "We lost him many years ago."

"I think he was my father. These letters prove he wrote to my mother." He watched her take them up, watched her go still and then, halfway through, begin to cry — silent, controlled, the tears falling onto the ink without her seeming to notice. It took her the better part of ten minutes to finish reading, and when she looked up again, something in her had settled, the way a held breath settles once it's finally let go.

"It has been many years since I've seen Grayson's hand," she said. "He wrote to me too, when he first went to Gradsul — not so often as he wrote your mother, I think, but I kept every letter he sent, and reading these has brought me back to a time I try not to visit often." She set the letters down with a care that told Paul, more than her tears had, exactly how much they cost her to hold. "It is obvious they loved each other greatly. Something the court was never permitted to know."

"You didn't know either?"

"I had my suspicions." She studied him a long moment, the frank, assessing look of a woman deciding how much honesty a stranger could bear. "I will tell you the truth, Paul, because I think you would rather have it than comfort. I suspected, from the year you were born, that you might be my grandson. I hesitated to reach for you. Your accident left your lineage a mystery even to a grandmother's eye — I could not tell, looking at you, whose face I was looking for. And I did not want to reopen a wound, or risk a schism between my husband and Grayson's memory, on nothing firmer than suspicion."

"Lord Jamis doesn't know."

"He suspects, as I did. No more than that." She folded her hands in her lap, and for the first time since he'd sat down, something like real warmth entered her voice. "Your mother, Grayson, and Archibald Fryhone were the fastest of friends, growing up in this city. Archibald was my brother Zafar's ward — a bastard himself, born to a noblewoman of Port Toli, brought into my house as a boy to raise because Zafar saw in him the makings of a great scholar. Precocious. Brilliant, in truth, in a way that unsettled people twice his age."

"Who was his father?" Paul asked.

Something shifted in her face at the question — a hesitation her earlier candor hadn't shown, a quiver at the mouth she stilled almost before it formed. "A foundling has no father worth the naming," she said, smoothly enough, but a beat too quickly. "Zafar never told me whose he was, and I never had cause to press him." It was, Paul thought, the first thing she had said all evening that he did not quite believe — and that alone told him, plainly as any confession, that there was more to Archibald's parentage than she meant to volunteer. He weighed pressing it, decided the ground he already stood on was worth more than the ground he might gain by pushing, and let the moment pass instead.

"What happened to Grayson?" he asked instead. "The letters are twenty-three years old."

"I don't know for certain. But the last letter, about the Alchemy Caves, tells me most of what I need to guess." She rose, crossed to a shelf crowded with books, and drew a slow, steadying breath before she went on. "The 'Magnum Opus' that scholars study today has been edited by the Office of Forbidden Magic in Gradsul for centuries. But 'The Magnum Opus' — the true original, from which every copy was drawn — survives still, they say, kept in the dungeons beneath that same office, guarded by inquisitors, warded by magic no young man should have tested himself against. Archibald was obsessed with it. I believe, from these letters, that he drew Grayson into helping him search for it." She looked at Paul directly, and something in her voice hardened, grief giving

way, briefly, to something closer to anger. "There was a scandal, twenty years past. Archibald was banished from the academies. My brother Zafar lost his post at the Office of Forbidden Magic over it, and a friend of his lost the transmutation school besides. Zafar has never told me outright whether the inquisitors killed Grayson, or whether the wards themselves did. He has only ever hinted that Grayson died in the caves beneath the school, in Archibald's company, chasing knowledge that was never meant to be theirs. Archibald escaped. He was exiled to Salinmoor, and so far as I know, has not been seen in Gradsul since."

"Where can I find Zafar?"

"That may be difficult. He serves the Duke of Gradsul directly, and we are, as you're aware, presently at war with the Duke of Gradsul." She considered him a moment. "I could write to him. Tell him you wish to meet."

"I would go to him myself, if it came to that."

"Your uncle will not permit it," she said, not unkindly, "and he would not be wrong to refuse. But I will write." She reached out then, an open, uncertain gesture — an offer he could have declined, and did not — and the embrace that followed was awkward only for a moment before it became something more genuine than either of them had likely expected. She was crying again by the time she let him go, and turned her face away before she called for the servant to see him out.

She stopped him at the door with one more thing, though — crossed to a bookshelf, swung it aside on a hinge Paul would not have found without being shown, and revealed a second door behind it, plain stone, warded by something she could not open herself. "This once connected my husband's chambers to the prince's own residence," she said, resting her hand against it. "Grayson and Archibald used it, in their day, to see your mother without half the court watching. It has been sealed by an arcane word since Grayson died, and I have never brought myself to pass through it again. But this library is yours to use whenever you wish, Paul — and if you ever find a way to open that door from the other side, you will find

nothing here I would keep from you.”

Paul thanked her, and meant it more than the words alone could carry, and left the small palace on the cliff with a locked door behind him that he suspected, without yet being able to say why, he had already stood on the other side of once — three feet wide, sixty feet of dark corridor, and a lock that had pushed back against his picks as if something on the far side very much did not want to be found.

He went to find his uncle next. He had, after all, only half his answer.

CHAPTER NINE

What Jeon Feared

Jeon's guards made him wait, as they always did, and Paul spent the wait rehearsing how little of the last two days he actually wanted to explain before he was finally waved through into his uncle's study.

"This had better be important," Jeon said, not looking up from whatever correspondence had claimed the desk in front of him. "I'm dealing with a blockade, Paul."

"I've learned something important about my mother. And my father."

That brought his uncle's head up fast enough that Paul almost regretted the bluntness of it. "That was quick," Jeon said, something guarded already entering his voice.

Paul told it as plainly as he'd told Lady Jamis — the letters, the name, the son of Lord Jamis and Lady Jamis both — and watched his uncle's face do something complicated across the length of the telling: a scowl at first, tightening as Paul spoke, and then, gradually, as Jeon actually took up the letters and began reading them himself, something that looked almost like relief.

"Well, Paul," Jeon said, when he'd finished, setting the pages down with a care that surprised him, "you have brought great peace to my mind. I feared, if it ever came to this conversation, that I would like the answer far less." He was quiet a moment, turning something over. "Grayson Jamis was a good man. Honorable. Intelligent. I can accept him as your father far more easily than I could have accepted some of the alternatives I've spent twenty-three years imagining. He and your mother were inseparable as

children. I think she loved him a great deal, and I am — glad, in truth, to finally know it.”

“What alternatives?” Paul asked, because something in the way his uncle had said it demanded the question be asked directly.

Jeon’s face closed a little. “The letters mention a man named Archibald.”

“Yes. I don’t know who he is.”

“He was a demon, Paul.” The word came out with more weight than Paul had expected, weight that had clearly been sitting in his uncle for a very long time. “The thought of you having come from him was unbearable to me. He was cruel — and worse than cruel, because he was also brilliant, and his charm, false as it was, could work on anyone above him in station. Those beneath him, he tortured. Not always with his hands. He knew how to do it in ways that never came back to touch him. I told my father for years he was no good influence on your mother, and still he drew her in, and Grayson, and half the young courtiers of our generation, into whatever orbit suited him.” Jeon’s jaw worked once before he continued. “I kept you at arm’s length all these years, Paul. Not for your face. For that — for not knowing, until this moment, whether I was looking at Grayson’s son or his. I have watched you closely enough to know you are not cruel, whatever else you are. I did not know, until today, whether that was your own nature or simply the accident that spared you from developing his.”

Paul absorbed that in silence, turning over twenty-three years of a coldness he had always assumed was simple indifference, and found, to his own mild surprise, that he did not resent his uncle for it nearly as much as he might have expected to.

“There’s a man named Zafar mentioned in the letters,” he said finally. “I’ve spoken with Lady Jamis. I asked if I might meet him.”

“Zafar Azane,” Jeon said. “I know him well. Why do you wish to meet him?”

“To learn what happened to my father.”

Jeon set the letters down and studied him for a long moment, weighing something Paul couldn’t read. “You may need to travel

to see him," he said, "and Gradsul, Paul, is the last place in the Flanaess I could permit you to go. Not while the Duke of Gradsul's ships sit outside our harbor."

"I know what I'm asking for."

"You know what you are asking for. You do not know what you would be walking into." Jeon's voice sharpened, urgency replacing the earlier softness. "Zafar Azane is among the most powerful wizards in the Flanaess, and I could not tell you with confidence whose side he truly serves. I will not hand the Duke of Gradsul a hostage with your blood in his veins, however careful you believe yourself to be." He held up a hand before Paul could argue further. "I will write to him myself. Ask for an audience on the Sea Principalities' behalf, and let Lady Jamis arrange what she can through her own channels. If Zafar wishes to speak with you, he will find a way that does not require you to set foot in Gradsul. That is the most I will permit."

It was not everything Paul had hoped for, but it was considerably more than the flat refusals he had spent a lifetime collecting from this office, and he recognized the difference well enough to accept it without further argument. Jeon asked, almost as an afterthought, whether he might keep the letters — "for affection's sake," he said, and Paul, reading something in his uncle's face that didn't match the reason given, declined, and watched Jeon accept the refusal with a stiffness that told Paul his instinct had been correct: his uncle meant to use them for something Paul hadn't been told, very possibly a conversation with Lord Jamis that Paul had no wish to be a bystander to before he understood the ground better himself.

"One more thing, before you go," Jeon said, as Paul rose to leave. "I have a task for you, if you'll take it. I have reason to believe agents of Port Toli are moving through the foreign district — Suel, and dangerous, likely bound to Prince Sacnon himself. I do not want you engaging them. I want you to find them. Watch who they meet, who they speak to. I have reason to suspect someone in our own employ is working with them, and I would very much like to know

who." He paused, weighing his nephew with an expression Paul hadn't seen from him before — something closer to actual trust than anything twenty-three years of dinners and councils had ever offered. "Keep your distance. You've proven tonight you can move through this city without being seen. I would like to see what that's worth, put to proper use."

"It will be done," Paul said, and meant it more fiercely than he let show.

"Take a disguise from the wardrobe I'll have sent to your rooms. No one in that district can know who you are." Jeon studied him a moment longer, then returned to the papers on his desk, the audience plainly at its end. "Tomorrow, Paul. Begin tomorrow."

Paul left with the letters back in his own keeping and a task, at last, that was entirely his — and went straight to his rooms to finish what the last two days had already set in motion: pulling the homunculus manual out from under his bed, and beginning, in earnest, to build the one thing that might let him do his uncle's work without ever once having to be seen doing it.

CHAPTER TEN

Clay and Blood

The Homunculi, the tome called itself on its title page, the work of Grayson Jamis — and it set out the working with the patience of a man who had clearly done it himself more than once. The hand was Grayson's throughout, in the body of the text and in the careful notes crowding its margins alike; Paul understood he was reading his father's own script for what he was beginning to think of as the first time. Grayson claimed little of the craft as his own invention. The stones and the method both he laid at the feet of his uncle, the Lithomancer Zafar Azane — the man who had gifted him the paired gems, taught him their working, and whose famous animated blades had set Grayson down this road in the first place.

The foundation was clay, malleable and worked into the likeness of something small and lizard-like — not arbitrary, the text insisted, but chosen: durable where a spider's form was fragile, capable of blending into stone and shadow in a way a fashioned insect never could, ideal for a creature built to watch and not be watched watching. The clay wanted a drop of its maker's blood, worked into warm water until it took the enchantment properly. And at the center of the whole working sat the two green stones Paul had carried up from the ruined lab beneath his own floor — a Heartstone, embedded in the clay where a heart would sit, and a Mindstone, kept by the master, the true seat of the working. Zafar had learned the making of them, the text claimed, from the lost archives of the Arcane Order — a variation on the old soul-gem craft the Suel transmuters had perfected before the Twin Cataclysms took the rest of their empire with them. The ritual itself was almost absurdly simple

beside all of that: the master stood before the unfinished creature, focused his will through the Mindstone, and spoke two words — “*lapis philosophorum*” — and what woke afterward was not a servant exactly, but something closer to an extension of the caster’s own mind, given legs and eyes and a body that did not need feeding or watering to survive.

Paul’s first attempt, worked from the coarse clay the palace servants had brought him, came apart in his hands before he’d finished the shaping. His second lasted long enough to twitch once in response to the words before it crumbled entirely, and left him sitting amid the wreckage of it at ten o’clock at night with the uncomfortable certainty that the clay itself, not his skill, was the failure — grainy, poorly fired, nothing like the material the manual clearly assumed a serious artificer would use.

He dressed for the streets rather than wait for morning. The fake human face he wore for the streets — a skin of wax and paint drawn over his own, close enough to a real face at a glance that most people didn’t look twice, though anyone who studied it too long would catch the cracks — went on under a plain black cloak, and he left the palace through the Royal District’s gate with the guard’s polite, faintly unsettled deference following him out, and chose the foreign district over the longer, better-lit route through the harbor, because it was faster and because some part of him, he suspected, wanted the excuse to see it properly for the first time in longer than he cared to admit.

It smelled the way he’d been told it would — rot and salt and woodsmoke and worse, threaded through with the noise of taverns still lit and loud well past the hour any respectable district would have gone dark. He kept to the main street, one hand near his short sword, and told himself the figure he glimpsed twice, ducking into an alley mouth first eighty feet behind him and then sixty, was nothing worth stopping for.

The Grand Market, half-empty compared to what he remembered of better years, still had merchants trading by lamplight, and Paul found what he needed at a potter’s stall run by a broad, red-

haired man from somewhere far to the west — good Baklunish clay, waterproof, thirty pounds of it for three gold coins and a fourth for the bag, generosity the man plainly hadn't expected and took with visible gratitude. Paul lingered afterward longer than he'd meant to, drawn to a weaponsmith's stall where a dark, wickedly slender stiletto — Dolkheim steel, the man swore, though Paul's own reading of him said the finer points of that claim were more sales patter than fact — proved sharp enough to punch through chain mail his own broad dirk merely skidded off, and came home with him for forty-eight gold and a haggle Paul rather enjoyed losing.

The mask came from a stall near the back of the market, where a merchant kept executioner's hoods and cheap leather disguises beside a few odder pieces. One of the odder ones caught him: a mask built of narrow metal strips, interlaced and joined with tiny rings of chain, so the whole thing flexed and shaped itself to the face like a helmet of scales rather than a rigid plate. It was very nearly the thing he'd come looking for — metal, close-fitting, nothing like the fake human face he'd worn for years — but for one fault. It shone.

"Good work," Paul said, tilting it so the lamplight ran along the strips. "But it throws back every torch in the street. Have you a darker one? Something with less shine to it?"

Something shifted in the merchant's face at that — a small recalculation, there and gone, as if Paul had said a particular thing in a particular way and the man had decided what it must mean. He glanced past Paul at the thinning crowd, then reached below his counter and brought up a second mask that had never been on the rack: the same interlaced strips, but etched and blackened until they drank the light instead of returning it. "These," he said, quieter now, "are the make the monks of the Scarlet Brotherhood favor. Not a thing most men know to ask after."

Paul, who knew nothing of the Brotherhood and had asked after nothing but a mask that would not betray him on a dark street, paid what the man wanted, took the darker piece, and went back out into the night with no notion that he had just spoken the right words to the wrong person — and set something moving he would not

understand for a long while yet.

He was halfway back to the Royal District — the false face peeled off at a corner past the market and tucked away, the new mask settled cool and close over his own and the cloak drawn up over it — walking with more confidence than the last hour's shopping strictly justified, when the first sling stone caught him from behind.

It cracked against the back of his head and glanced away — the cloak drawn up over the new mask took the brunt, the hard metal turned the rest, so it did nothing worse than startle him — lead shot, he understood a heartbeat later, meant to kill rather than merely bruise, and the second came a breath after the first, glancing off his shoulder into the leather beneath his cloak. He turned, cross-bow already coming up out of habit more than conscious decision, and found two figures crouched in an alley mouth thirty feet off, reloading their slings with the unhurried confidence of men who had done this before and rarely needed a second attempt.

He didn't give them one. The bolt took the nearer man clean through the throat before he'd finished bringing his own sling to bear, and the second fled into the dark rather than test whatever had just happened to his partner. Paul crossed the thirty feet at an unhurried walk, weighing — with a coldness that would have startled him, had he stopped to examine it — whether the man bleeding out against the alley wall was worth more to him dead or questioned, and decided, in the end, that a live prisoner was worth considerably more than a dead mystery. He knelt, worked his thumb into the wound to slow the bleeding, and held it there with a steadiness that surprised him until the man's breathing evened out into something that might, with care, survive the night.

He did not carry the man. A masked figure hauling a bleeding body through the foreign district after midnight was precisely the sort of spectacle Paul had spent a lifetime learning not to make; better to leave him propped against the alley wall, his wound bound as well as it could be, and send back hands meant for the work. So he walked the rest of the way to the Royal District gatehouse alone — past the same guard he'd left by on the way out, who called the

challenge, then recognized him and let the gate swing wide.

"There's a man in an alley off the market, wounded but breathing," Paul told him. "Send a patrol to bring him to the palace dungeon. He's a personal interest of mine — he's not to be harmed, and he's to be kept there for me and no one else." The guard's face, taking the orders, did the particular careful thing faces did around Paul — not fear exactly, not anymore, but something adjacent to it, the beginning of a wariness he suspected, with some private satisfaction, might prove useful in whatever came next. A patrol went out before he had finished the climb to his rooms.

He slept badly and briefly, and woke to word that his prisoner had survived the night and been delivered as instructed, and turned, at last, back to the clay.

The good Baklunish material took the shaping the way the palace clay never had — patient under his hands, holding the small, precise lizard-form he wanted, wings folded flat along its back — and when he set the Heartstone into its chest, took up the Mindstone, and, focusing his mind down into it the way the text described, spoke the words, "*lapis philosophorum*," the little creature twitched once, twice, and opened eyes that were, he understood a moment later with a shock that took him a long minute to steady through, somehow also his own.

It was disorienting in a way nothing in the manual had quite prepared him for — half his awareness in his own body, sitting on the edge of his bed, and half suddenly low to the ground, seeing his own room from a lizard's-eye height, the strange doubled sense the old book had likened to a man trying to walk and read at once. He sent it crawling up the wall first, testing the grip of small clay claws against stone, then out under the door and down the corridor, following the sound of voices toward the servants' passage — a steward's voice, and a guard's, discussing, in the flat, unhurried tones of men repeating instructions they'd been given more than once, the prisoner Paul had sent down the night before, and Prince Jeon's standing order that everything his nephew did, everywhere he went, whoever he spoke with, was to be reported faithfully back

to the crown.

Paul sat very still in his own body while his small clay eyes watched the two men from ten feet up a wall they never thought to look at, and understood, with a clarity that felt like the first genuinely useful thing anyone had ever handed him, exactly how much this small, deliberate act of creation had just changed about what he was capable of — for his uncle's purposes, and, he suspected, before very much longer, for purposes entirely his own.

He called the little creature back before either man could finish speaking, tucked it into a pocket sewn deep enough to keep it hidden, and sat a long while in the grey early light turning over everything the last week had given him: a father, a grandmother, a dead man's half-told story about a demon named Archibald, a task from a prince who had never before trusted him with one, and, curled warm and strange against his ribs, the first working proof that he was, whatever else the city believed of him, considerably more than the ghost it had always been content to let him be.

PART ONE: THE PRINCE'S ERRAND

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Council in the Royal Tower

The second day of Wealsun dawned grey and salt-scented over Monmurg, the light struggling through a haze that had hung over the harbor for a fortnight. Once, in the days before the blockade, the jewel of the Azure Sea had woken each morning to the clatter of laden carts and the cries of dockhands hauling in the night's catch of trade — grain from Berghof, cheese and meat from the allied duchies, the endless commerce that had made the city fat and proud. Now the docks stood half empty, the granaries thinner every week, and the people of the foreign district eyed each other with the particular hunger of a city that knew, somewhere in its bones, that the worst had not yet come.

Keoland's navy sat across the trade lanes like a closed fist. The Duke of Gradsul, cunning where Monmurg's admirals had once been proud, had turned the merchant ships toward Redshore instead — a whaling town with neither the berths nor the warehouses to swallow what Monmurg's docks were built for. And somewhere out past the mouth of the Hool River, a pirate calling himself the Scarlet Rat — the same the Redshore quays had cursed as Captain Crimson — had put Port Torvin to the torch, taking with it the last dependable trickle of food that might have seen the city through the summer.

It was into this uncertainty that Paul Revero woke, in a chamber of the Royal Palace that had never quite felt like home, the morning after he had bent clay and old magic into the likeness of a small clay familiar no bigger than a large rat. He had slept poorly — he always did, the nights after discovering something new — but there was

work to be done today, and he intended to begin it before breakfast had properly settled. Prince Jeon, his mother's brother and the nearest thing Paul had to a father since her death, had set him to a task some days before: find the Toli agents moving through Monmurg, the enemy's eyes and ears working against the city from within its own streets.

There was, at least, a beginning already made. The night before, walking the foreign trade district in his dark, close-fitting mask, Paul had been set upon by two would-be robbers — men so poorly prepared for the attempt that he'd put a crossbow bolt through one's throat before the second could fit another stone to his sling. The second man had fled into the dark; the first Paul had staunched as best he could, bandaging the wound with more determination than skill, and left for the patrol to carry back to the family dungeon rather than let him bleed out in the gutter. A prisoner, Paul had reasoned, groggy with satisfaction, was worth a great deal more than a corpse.

He had dressed already — plain traveling leathers, buckled and belted — and stood now turning the last piece of it over in his hands: the black metal mask, lighter and more comfortable than it looked, a close lattice of small interlocking rings shaped to the contours of a face and cut through with fine geometric etching that seemed, in the grey morning light, to shift and rearrange itself the longer he stared at it. It lay cool and strange against his palms, and he was still considering it — as he did most mornings with all his masks, in the half-breath before he made himself faceless again — when a servant's knock interrupted him.

"Come in," Paul called.

The servant entered — and at the sight of Paul bare-faced, the burned and ruined flesh he kept from the world laid open to the morning light, the man immediately looked away, eyes sliding to the floor.

"Oh — a moment," Paul said, and lifted the mask to his face at last, settling the cool metal into place and drawing the straps tight before he turned to face the man.

"Forgive me," the servant said, still averting his gaze out of old habit. "Your uncle wishes to see you in his office. Right away, if you please."

"Of course. Tell him I'll come at once."

The servant withdrew. Paul took up the last of his gear — the black mask settled over his face now — and made his way through the palace's quiet upper halls toward Prince Jeon's study.

The guards along the corridor did not salute him so much as acknowledge him — a small click of the heels, a dip of the chin — but it was enough to mark how far his standing in this household had climbed. He was admitted without question.

Inside, Prince Jeon sat behind his broad desk, and across from him, in a chair angled just slightly away, sat Lord Jamis — a man Paul had come to think of, in his own private reckoning, as something between a patron and an obligation. Standing at Jamis's shoulder was a figure Paul had never seen before: an elf, which was uncommon enough in Monmurg to draw the eye on its own, but this one carried himself with a darkness that set him apart even from that rarity. His mouth was a flat line, his brow drawn, and he seemed to share, in the silence before Paul entered, some tense and unspoken understanding with the two older men.

"Paul — you've joined us," Prince Jeon said, gesturing to an empty chair. "Please, sit. This is Lord Jamis, of course, as you know. And this" — a nod to the elf — "is one of his agents. Jude, I believe?"

The elf inclined his head, once. "Yes."

"A wizard in Lord Jamis's employ," Jeon continued. "Reportedly quite knowledgeable in arcane matters."

Jude studied Paul — the dark cloak, the studded leather beneath it, and the strange mask he half-recognized. It took him a moment to place it: the same style worn by monks of a temple of the Scarlet Brotherhood that he and Karmirg had raided once, in another life, the one where he'd been turned into a snake for his trouble. He filed the thought away and simply nodded at Paul, offering nothing more.

Jeon cleared his throat gently, drawing the room's attention back

to the matter at hand. "Paul is one of my relatives — my nephew. I wish to include him in what we've been discussing. Lord Jamis tells me you've begun investigating possible Toli agents here in the city."

"Yes," Paul said. "Preliminary work, only just begun."

"I understand. Lord Jamis — would you walk us through what's transpired this past month?"

Jamis gave Paul a strange, searching look before he began — as though weighing how much of this the younger man was ready to hear. Then he answered.

"About a month ago, we had a visit from a wizard out of Keoland," he said. "I've spoken to you of this before, Jude. Lord Phranck — an evoker, from the Magical Academy at Gradsul, the same school my son Grayson attended, before he died there. Phranck came to Monmurg, apparently to make contact with me directly. He wanted to know my intentions toward the Duke of Gradsul. To this day I couldn't tell you his true purpose — whether he came to warn us, or to use us. He gave me information, and the name of a spy he'd embedded here. I still don't fully understand what game he was playing."

There it was, said plainly to the whole room: *my son Grayson*. Paul had sat with Lady Jamis only days ago and named her his grandmother to her face. Hearing Jamis set the name down so evenly — as a fact of Gradsul and nothing more — landed harder than the man could have meant it to. Behind the cool metal of the mask something crossed Paul's face, and he was glad, not for the first time, that no one alive could read what he kept behind it. He let none of it reach his voice.

"Was this before the blockade?" Paul asked.

"Shortly after it began, though before it was announced — and before Port Torvin burned."

"I've been in the city less than a week since," Jude said, softly, working out the timeline. "I came from Redshore — I remember the ships gathering there."

"That happened while you traveled here," Jamis said. "You wouldn't have known of it until you arrived."

"What's the latest word on Phranck?"

"Supposedly in Saltmarsh, though we haven't confirmed his whereabouts."

"That's across the bay."

"A day and a half by sea, through dangerous waters given the blockade — or overland, through the marshes and across the Hool, largely uncivilized country either way." Jamis's eyes flicked toward Jeon, just briefly, before he continued. "My reports say the man who burned Port Torvin and made off with its stores was an agent of Phranck's — though whose side Phranck himself stands on, I couldn't say with confidence. While he was here, four assassins out of Port Toli tried to kill him. I don't know what they hoped to accomplish. But during that same stretch, he made contact with an agent of his own, and later warned me of a traitor passing information to the Toli — my own harbor master, a man named Atare, who'd been in Gradsul on diplomatic business weeks before the fighting began, and was turned during that visit."

He paused, weighing his next words. "Phranck has reached me by magic several times since. I don't fully trust him, or know whether he even controls this 'Scarlet Rat' who burned Port Torvin — but the Rat's actions have hurt this city badly. You know our stores are dwindling. The food meant for the foreign and merchant districts through the summer was on those docks. It's ash now."

"And that's not even the worst of it," Jamis went on, his voice dropping. "Lord Phranck, as best I can determine, is an Inquisitor — from the Office of Forbidden Magic."

Paul blinked. "Say that again?"

"An Inquisitor. A secret order out of Gradsul that hunts down those who practice proscribed magic — necromancy first among their concerns. It's rarely troubled us here; we've little cause to define such things ourselves. But Keoland is exacting about it. Word is he's investigating something in Salinmoor, near Saltmarsh — some illness spreading through that border country."

"The black sickness?" Paul asked. "I'd heard something was moving through that swamp."

"The same. Though I suspect it runs deeper than mere disease — I believe he's chasing a resurgence of some old order, the Sons of Olan, tied to necromancers in that region generations back. Whatever the truth of it, the black sickness has struck the Principalities harder than it's struck Keoland. You've seen Westkeep. You know what it's done there."

"The Sons of Olan?" Paul turned the name over, searching old lessons for any thread of memory — Suel, surely, by the sound of it — and found nothing. "I don't know it," he admitted. "Only that it's Suel, not Flannish."

"There are several threads worth pulling," Jamis said. "First — an agent of Phranck's, a woman named Kalisi. An elf, here in Monmurg. She's had contact with Gouge in the past, and it was she who first named Atare as the traitor. My intention was to hand Atare to Phranck's people — Inquisitors can read a man's very thoughts, and I wanted the truth of whether the Duke of Gradsul is in league with Sacnon Toli, Prince of Port Toli. I mean to use Kalisi as a contact for Jude, but she has gone quiet these past days, and Phranck's recent actions look less like an ally's and more like an enemy's."

"Can we trust her, even nominally?" Paul asked.

"No," Jamis said flatly. "She's behaved in apparent good faith while here, but she belongs to Phranck first. I've had no way to verify her movements independently, and my plan to have Jude vet her loyalty is now frustrated by her absence."

"If we could confirm her loyalty to Monmurg, would that change things?"

"It would put her back on the table, yes. What would help most is learning whether she still has contact with Phranck — and where he is. However, we must find her first."

Beside Paul, Jude had said nothing this entire time, standing with a stillness that seemed almost unnatural, arms folded, the elf's stoic face never showing an expression. Paul found himself glancing sideways more than once, unsettled by the silence — the killer's stillness, he thought, next to his own restless need to ask, to know, to press.

"So — in light of everything draining our resources," Jude said at last, breaking his silence, "and her having given you nothing useful in weeks — where does that leave us?"

"At least two weeks of nothing," Jamis admitted.

"Two weeks isn't so very long, in a siege," Paul offered.

"I've tried reaching Phranck through an infiltrator bound for Port Toli, five days past. They've since crossed into Salinmoor. No word yet. And you'll recall he has the means to speak to minds directly, when he wishes."

"I rather expected a message from him myself, given everything," Paul said.

Jamis's mouth twitched into something almost like sympathy. "He reaches out to me, not to you. Count yourself fortunate — you haven't yet felt an Inquisitor's touch upon your thoughts, the way I have."

Paul absorbed all of it in a long, silent moment, counting the threads in his head — Kalisi, Atare, the vendor of the mask he now wore, the Toli themselves — while Jude remained a study in patience beside him, unmoving, unreadable as ever.

"Forgive the questions," Paul said finally. "You mentioned several avenues. Bringing in Kalisi seems straightforward enough. And Atare — do we know if he's fled?"

"Taken, weeks past. I did it myself. He had little to tell beyond what I'd already suspected, though he confirmed he'd been working for the Toli. I had Gouge and Karmirg deliver him to Port Torvin, where Phranck told me a contact would take custody."

"And?"

"That contact," Jamis said, "turned out to be the very pirate who burned the town to the ground. That is how I first learned the name Scarlet Rat."

Paul turned that over. "Do we think Phranck and the Rat are one and the same?"

"No," Jamis said. "The Rat serves the Toli, Lord Phranck, or himself; perhaps all three — it's possible Phranck curried favor with me under one banner and did unspeakable things under another. I still

cannot say where Phranck truly stands in all of it."

"Then what would you have us prioritize?" Jude asked, glancing between his two patrons. "Kalisi seems the quickest thread to pull. The hunt for spies within the city itself will take longer. Do you want us ranging beyond Monmurg as well?"

"It is my wish that Paul lead this," Jeon said simply.

"However," Jamis added, addressing the room, "Jude here is well-versed enough in the arcane that he'd do well against whatever the Toli assassins throw at us."

Jude took that as his cue. His flat gaze moved to Paul. "Have you crossed blades with any of their kind yet?"

"The day's barely begun," Paul said dryly.

"I meant recently — before today," Jude said.

"Not personally, no."

"Gouge and Karmirg killed four of them," Jamis said. "It was no small fight — magic and steel both. I don't wish to see you drawn directly into that kind of danger, Paul."

Paul glanced toward Jamis, trying to place whose caution this truly was. It was Jamis's own, he realized, not merely a relayed wish of Jeon's.

"However," Jamis went on, "I would very much like you involved in the investigation itself."

Jeon wanted him to lead, and Jamis did not want him fighting — an impossible pairing, when he turned it over, for how was a man to lead at all if he was never to expose himself to danger? The two wishes could not both be honored, and yet both had been laid on him all the same. The shape of it settled over Paul like a familiar, unwelcome coat. Being minded. Being kept safe by men who loved him and doubted him in equal measure.

Was he being coddled? He put the question to himself, though he already knew the answer to it.

Neither Jeon nor Jamis would ever say as much aloud — the one out of love, the other out of a caution that came, in the end, to much the same thing — but Paul understood well enough what the two of them intended between them: that he was a thing to be kept, and

guarded, and never quite risked. He tucked the thought away with the others he did not examine too closely.

"We've a council to attend," Jeon said, rising. "Please — the two of you compare notes, and bring each other up to speed on what you've each learned so far. When we return, we'll speak further on where things stand. Jamis, see that Paul has whatever resources he requires." He paused, softer now. "Paul — I heard of your business last night. Involving Jude in this may prove useful; his skills are considerable."

"Of course," Paul said. "Thank you, uncle."

The two lords left for their meeting with the admiralty, leaving Jude a moment to study his new companion properly — a mask of small interlocking metal rings, fitted close to the skull, cut through with intricate geometric patterns that seemed, in the shifting light, to almost move on their own.

A servant appeared at the door before Paul could decide where to take their conversation. "Please, this way," the man said, leading them to a small private study.

"Bring us wine," Paul told him as they settled in, and the servant bowed and withdrew to fetch it.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Masks and Measures

The study was small and close, lined with books neither of them would read that day, and for a long moment after the servant left, Jude simply studied Paul across the narrow table — the set of his shoulders, the deliberate stillness that the mask's discipline only reinforced.

"So — Prince Jeon is your uncle," Jude said.

"On my mother's side," Paul said.

Jude tilted his head, considering the way Paul moved, the youth still evident beneath a frame that hadn't yet filled out the way Jeon's had. "Then Lord Jamis must be something like a godfather to you."

Paul made a small, noncommittal gesture — not quite agreement, not quite denial.

"I feel at something of a disadvantage," Jude went on, "given you're wearing a mask and I'm not. Where did you get that thing? It's an interesting piece."

"I know it is."

"Custom made?"

"Why does it matter so to you where I came by it?" Paul asked.

"So where, then?"

"I bought it," Paul said.

"I've never seen one worn outside a temple," Jude said, and let a beat pass before he named it. "That is a Scarlet Brotherhood face — a secretive order out of the southern isles. Monks, after a fashion, though the fashion runs to poison and the knife rather than to prayer. They keep no open houses, and sell nothing honestly. A man does not simply happen on their mask at a market stall."

Paul only shrugged beneath the mask, an economical little motion. "It's comfortable."

And there it was. Jude turned the shrug over behind his stoic calm and found, to his own quiet surprise, that he believed it whole — that Paul had bought the thing plainly, worn it plainly, walked it up to a prince's council without the first notion of what it signified. No agent of the Brotherhood would ever carry their own face so brazenly into the open, before lords and guardsmen, a coin purse jingling on his hip; being unseen was the whole of what they were. Whatever else this masked young noble might prove to be, he was no creature of theirs — only someone who had come by a very dangerous thing in ignorance of it, which was, if anything, the more reassuring answer of the two.

"Well," Jude said, settling back, something almost like amusement in his voice, "if I'm meant to keep you alive, I hope the feeling runs both ways."

"The feeling does run both ways; I hope you're keeping me alive too," Paul said, dry enough that it might have been a joke.

"I've only been in Monmurg a week myself, little more," Jude admitted, and for the first time some of the guarded stillness eased from his posture. "One of the places Lord Phranck called on was a mad old alchemist in the foreign district — a cluttered curio shop off one of the squares. I went in under the cover of commissioning a still and came away with little else; whatever Phranck wanted from him, he wasn't giving it to a stranger. It's the only lead I have worth chasing, all the same — because I was followed there."

"That's the foreign district for you," Paul said, dry. "Half the men on those streets are being followed by someone, and the other half are doing the following. I shouldn't feel too special about it, if I were you."

"Not by an ordinary thug, though. Whoever it was turned invisible — I only lost them because I could do the same. That fits with what we just heard, about the assassins mixing magic and blade." Jude's fingers drummed once against the table. "Has anyone unfamiliar come to the foreign district these past two weeks?"

New arrivals, or old faces returning? I've been to Monmurg before, though nothing in my history should tie me to any of this — except perhaps an inn called Ferd's. I humiliated a man there once."

"To save yourself trouble, you should have killed him," Paul said, without much heat — and made a private note of it, for it was not the first boast the elf had folded into their short acquaintance, nor the second. Jude had a fondness for his own legend, Paul was beginning to see: humiliations dealt, foes bested, monks put in the ground. A man so pleased with his own past, Paul suspected, was a man who trimmed it to flatter himself in the telling — worth remembering, of a partner he had known all of an hour.

"Maybe. I don't know if I was followed over that grudge or something larger — hard to say. People are knifed daily in that district without needing an invisible hand to do it. But an invisible hand is exactly what I felt behind me."

"I can't imagine anyone bothers turning invisible just to rob a man," Paul said.

"Perhaps not." Jude let the thought trail, then shook it off. "In any case — I bought a still. I mean to use some of the local urchins, feed the noble houses' cast-offs through it — rotten apples, orange peels, whatever the kitchens throw away — and turn Ferd's into somewhere people are glad to drink, even now. Drunk men talk. It's a long game — a month out, at least, and it depends on food reaching the city at all."

"Should I take the lead from you, or you from me?" Paul asked. "Given Jeon's wishes."

"You've got quicker leads, it sounds like," Jude said. "So let's hear them. What have you actually been about, since your uncle turned you loose on this? He made some remark of business of yours last night, and left the rest to the imagination. I'd sooner have the whole of it — what have you turned up so far?"

"Last night, walking the foreign trade district, two men tried to rob me. I put a crossbow bolt through one's throat — he went down. The other ran off into the dark, but the wounded one I kept. He's in my family's dungeon now. I'm hoping to turn him into something

useful."

"You have a dungeon."

"Family estate. Comes with the territory, I suppose — I forget sometimes that I'm meant to be nobility."

"I don't imagine you visit it often."

"No," Paul said. "But there's a man down there now."

"Fresh catch," Jude said, something wry in it — and turned the whole of it over behind his easy tone. A dungeon that came with the estate, like a cellar or a stable. A young man who could forget, day to day, that he was meant to be nobility, when Jude had spent the better part of his own life clawing after a fraction of what this one had been handed at birth and never learned to want. He let himself wonder, as he had wondered before of other men, what he might have made of such a start — a name, a family seat, coin enough to keep men fed and loyal, a prince for an uncle and the whole weight of a great house at his back. A very great deal, he suspected. Rather more than the boy across the table seemed inclined to make of it. Give me the tools this one was born holding, Jude thought, not unkindly, and I would have had half the Azure Sea in my pocket before I was his age.

"I'm hoping he can point us toward others."

"Given the mask, I'd think you're rather memorable already. Do you have much evidence tying any of this together?"

"Not really. Hard to build a case against an enemy you can't see."

"You still haven't told me where you got that mask."

"I bought it," Paul said again, patient as stone.

"At a market stall? Used?"

"More or less, yes."

"Would you like us to go question your man, then?" Jude asked, and then, almost as an afterthought: "You mentioned a homunculus, earlier."

"I did. I have one."

"I know what a homunculus is... a myth," Jude said, faint impatience creeping in. Behind the words ran a colder reckoning. The homunculus was a story and nothing more — the sort of thing a

charlatan trotted out to gull a credulous lord, a painted clay trinket and a great deal of muttered nonsense passed off as high sorcery, all of it in exchange for coin. He had watched the trick worked more than once, on men who ought to have known better. So which was it here — was the boy simply lying, dressing himself up grander than he was? Or did he truly believe the thing, which would be worse still? Jude studied the masked young noble anew and wondered, not for the first time in the past hour, precisely what game Paul Revero imagined he was playing.

"I have one," Paul repeated, and something in his tone made clear this was not a small claim.

"Well, if it truly exists it will save us getting anyone drunk in a tavern to get their secrets," Jude said. "What manner of creature is it?"

Paul considered how much to explain. "A little construct — clay, mostly, though the old texts describe stranger materials for the making of them. Something a transmuter builds, like a familiar, following methods out of the 'Magnum Opus.'"

"The tome by Ujor Udias," Jude said. "I know it. Though the copy I've read makes no mention of homunculi at all. Who helped you make yours?"

"No one," Paul said. "I made it myself." And as he said it he reached into his coat, drew out the small clay figure, and set it on the table between them — no bigger than a large rat, delicate wings folded at its sides, a fine, smoky-black construct that might have passed for a child's carving but for the uncanny care of its making. It did nothing at all. It did not need to; Jude's eyes went to it and stayed.

Jude went still in a different way this time — genuine surprise breaking through his usual composure as he realized Paul may not be lying. "That's — no small feat, to manage alone." His eyes narrowed slightly, his stoic calm slipping for just a moment. "I've never kept a homunculus myself. I wouldn't loose one into the foreign district without giving it clearer purpose than wandering the taverns as a curious little lizard. And if it's anything like a familiar, you

don't want it caught."

"We don't," Paul agreed. "But I don't yet know where in the district to send it — that's why we should speak to the prisoner first, before we go turning over the foreign district in earnest. It was a poor attempt on my life, if I'm honest; the man may well prove worthless to us." He paused. "Then again, he may not."

"Everyone can be useful, even reluctantly," Jude said. "Something's better than nothing."

"Agreed," Paul said. "I'll send it down to the dungeon ahead of us, to keep watch on our man before we ever set foot inside — and you can judge for yourself, then, whether the creature earns the trouble I took in making it."

"Does it understand speech, or is the bond more direct than that?" Jude asked, leaning to study it more closely.

"It understands me well enough," Paul said, and did not elaborate further, choosing instead to simply watch as the little creature stirred to life at his silent will.

When the wine arrived — the finest Jude had tasted in weeks, a small mercy in a city running short of everything — Paul set the homunculus loose upon the table. It crept across the polished wood, then leapt for the wall and half-glided, half-scrambled its way along it, before slipping under the door and out into the corridor beyond, moving with a stealth Paul had not fully trusted until he saw it proven.

"You've managed all this on your own," Jude observed, something almost approving in it.

"No help required," Paul said, watching through the creature's borrowed eyes as it wound down through the palace's lower halls, tasting the stale, mineral air of the dungeons on senses that were and were not quite his own.

They gave the prisoner a quarter hour to stew before descending themselves — long enough, Paul judged, for fear to properly take root.

They left the study together and made their way toward a small, seldom-visited wing of the palace, where a narrow spiral stair

wound down into the stone beneath — turn after turn of worn steps carrying them out of the warmth and lamplight of the upper halls and into the cooler, close, mineral air of the dungeons below, further from the world of princes and councils with every descent, and nearer the one where matters like this were more usually settled.

The guards down below barely glanced up as the two of them approached, the dungeon strangely oversized for how sparingly Jeon seemed to use it — whether from mercy or from a simple preference for killing his enemies outright, Paul had never been entirely sure. In the single occupied cell, a young man sat curled in the corner, muttering under his breath, dirty-haired and hollow-eyed with the particular exhaustion of a life spent hungry in the foreign district.

The jailer, milder in manner than his trade suggested, met them at the bars. “Would you like him brought out, or would you rather question him through the bars?”

“Let us in,” Jude said.

“Chained to the wall, or—”

“That’s not necessary.”

“Shall I heat the irons?”

“Do,” Jude said, and the jailer made a show of it, picking through a cabinet of pokers where the prisoner could watch every deliberate motion.

“I’ll want a bowl of water,” Jude added, and the jailer handed one over before turning to set irons against the coals.

Inside the cell, the prisoner drew his knees up at the sight of them, clutching his filthy shirt like a shield.

“You should be afraid,” Paul said quietly. “Do you remember me?”

The prisoner only looked down, saying nothing.

“Let me take the lead here,” Jude murmured, low enough that only Paul might hear.

“Go ahead,” Paul said, and stepped back into the shadow of the cell’s corner, a silent, waiting presence.

Jude cleared his throat and let his voice carry the weight he'd learned to summon for exactly this kind of moment. "You should be afraid. Very." He watched the words land, watched the young man's shoulders curl tighter. "But we needn't be unkind about it." He offered the bowl of water, some of it slopping over the rim as he pressed it forward. "You must be thirsty. Have you eaten?"

"No," the prisoner managed.

"Of course you haven't." Jude took a sip from the bowl himself, then grimaced at the taste. "God, that's foul — you deserve better water than this, at least." He had a wedge of cheese in his free hand, and the prisoner's eyes went to it and clung — the raw, fixed hunger of a man who had not eaten in days. Jude followed the look and turned the piece over between his fingers. "Not this piece — this is the rind. You'll want a fresh cut."

The prisoner's gaze slid past Jude to the silent figure in the corner, and it was to Paul that he made his plea, quick and low. "I had no notion of who you were, sir. I saw a rich merchant heading for the Grand Market. That's all it was." Paul gave him nothing back — no word, no motion, only the blank ringed metal of the mask and a stillness behind it that might have held mercy or murder in equal measure. The prisoner found no purchase there, and his eyes dropped away.

"So you're not Toli, then."

"No, sir. Just a Monmurg man, born and bred. Not much kindness in this city for men like me."

"As you say. Here's our trouble, then — we need eyes and ears in the streets, but we can't very well trust you."

"You can trust me," the prisoner said, too quickly.

"We can't. So tell me — who do we contact if you go quiet on us? Who do we hurt, if it turns out you've sold us out?"

The young man blinked, confused.

"Who do we kill," Jude said, patient and terrible in the same breath, "if we lose touch with you and come to believe you've betrayed us?"

The prisoner curled a little tighter into himself, muttering some-

thing low and wordless under his breath, some private comfort even now, before he caught himself. "I — I don't know that I have anyone you'd want."

"You're not to be executed," Jude said. "Not yet, at least."

"I'm grateful for that, sir."

"We haven't decided, understand — we still can't trust you. Help me help you. You seem a decent, solid Monmurg man to me."

"I think you could trust me."

"I don't," Jude said simply. "I think the trust I could place in you would be cheaply bought. Who can you offer? A sister? Mother, father? Someone you couldn't bear to see under the irons."

The prisoner's eyes went distant, calculating. "My companion, from last night."

"He's worth nothing to you — ran the moment things turned sour," Jude said.

"Let me," Paul said from the shadow of the corner, stepping forward at last. "I don't imagine you remember," he said to the prisoner, "but he left you for dead. Ran the moment you took that bolt to the throat."

"And I thank you, sir, for the care your people have shown me since," the young man said, with something that might have been genuine gratitude. "You're likely right. He thinks me dead by now."

"He's probably surprised your head isn't already over the wall," Jude said.

"I don't rate the wall, sir. That's for men of higher station. The gutter suits me better."

"You rated a trip to the Royal Palace, at least," Jude observed. "That's because we haven't decided what use you are yet — but we do need someone. Convince us. Start simple: your name?"

"Gregory."

"That narrows it hardly at all. Dock district, I'd wager?"

"Born there, sir. I live and work in the foreign district now."

Jude studied him — no visible guild marks at first glance, no obvious felon's scars — and gestured for the poker regardless, more for effect than intent. "Take off your shirt."

Gregory complied, turning at Jude's gesture to reveal a tattoo across his back, faded but unmistakable to a trained eye.

"Thieves' guild," Jude murmured, half to himself, after a moment's study. "You can put that back on." He considered the young man anew. "Who's running things these days?"

"Janus."

"Janus," Jude repeated, tasting the unfamiliar name. "How long has he held that seat?"

"Near eight months."

"So if someone wished Monmurg ill," Jude mused aloud, "they'd first want their own people placed where it mattered." Eight months was a curious span — recent enough to trouble him, old enough to prove nothing at all. He turned the man over in his mind, though he had never laid eyes on him. A Scarlet Brotherhood hand, slipped quietly into the guild to bend the city's underside to some southern design? A Toli plant, doing the Prince of Port Toli's work in the dark? Or only some ordinary thief who had clawed his way up a shrinking pile in a hard season, and had the poor luck to be holding the seat when men like Jude came asking after it? Any of the three would look much the same from where he sat, and Jude had learned long ago not to guess before he had cause.

Gregory's eyes flicked between the two of them, something bolder creeping into his voice. "We're being robbed blind by this whole business, if you want the truth of it, sir. People are starving in the streets."

"Matters of state are hardly the province of a thieves' guild," Jude said — though he was less sure of that than the words made him sound. In a siege, every ordinary rule bent under the weight of hunger, and a guild was a fine quiet machine for moving things through a city unseen: goods, men, coin, word. Point such a machine at the right target, and it became a very useful thing indeed to whoever held its lever. "Which is why your Janus interests me," he went on, half to himself now. "Eight months in the seat — long enough to be comfortable in it, not near long enough for me to trust him on the strength of it. And Monmurg's been under siege the

better part of two months. A besieged city is a desperate one, and desperate men take work they'd never touch in easier times — for coin, or fear, or the promise of both."

Gregory only looked at him, plainly lost. Talk of sieges and statecraft and whose hand moved what ran a good deal further than a street thief cared to follow, and he managed at last, uncertain of the whole of it, "It's grown desperate, sir, right enough — a month and a half, two months. Past that, I don't take your meaning."

"If someone meant to bring this city low," Jude pressed, "that would make them an enemy of the state — and every guild member complicit, save for those with cause to claim otherwise."

"Of course," Gregory said, quick to agree, though he had plainly not yet seen where the thread was being drawn.

"And yet a thief is not a traitor," Jude went on, easy and unhurried, setting the pieces where the young man could reach them. "There's a wide gulf between a fellow who lightens a merchant's purse and one who sells his city to its enemies. The first is a nuisance — the sort of thing a prince has always suffered, and always will. The second is a rope waiting for a neck. So tell me: what cause might a guildsman claim, to be reckoned the one and not the other?"

Gregory turned it over, and Jude watched the sense of it arrive by degrees — the distinction itself first, then what it opened onto. "Loyalty," he said, slower now. "To the city, sir. And to one's own trade." His eyes lifted, wary and a little startled. "You're saying a thief who kept faith with Monmurg might be worth something to the prince himself. In a time like this."

"One hopes the guild is loyal," Jude said. "But whoever means to collapse Monmurg from within would first need the guild's own loyalties compromised, wouldn't they?"

Jude studied the young man's face for any telling flicker — a swallow, a flinch — and found nothing he could read with any confidence.

"So the true question," Jude said, "is how deep the rot runs in your guild. That's what I need from you, if you'd like to keep all your fingers where they are."

"Honestly, sir, the guild suffers same as anyone — trade's gone to nothing."

"Desperation, then. That tracks well enough."

"In better times, sir," Gregory admitted — and here his eyes went again to the silent, masked figure in the corner, for it was Paul he had marked, and Paul he answered to now — "we'd never have gone after a man like you. Certainly not with just the two of us; we'd have hired someone to lure you properly into an alley, if we'd had coin enough for it." Paul gave him nothing back, as ever — only the blank ringed metal of the mask and a stillness that neither forgave the attempt nor promised to punish it.

"What do you make of Janus? Fair hand at his work, given the circumstances — or does he make strange calls?"

"He skims more than his share off the top, if I'm honest."

"Greed, at least, is a predictable failing," Jude said. "Especially in hard times." What he wanted to know, in truth, was the measure of the man behind the guild — whether Janus kept to a thief's rules, with their lines and their untouchable quarters, or ran his people as something nearer a spy's net, caring nothing for the old restraints. "So — where do his lines fall? What does the guild leave well alone? What, or who, does a Monmurg thief simply never touch?"

"The Royal household, sir. That before anything." Gregory said it as a thing beyond question, a rule bred into every guildsman from his first cutpurse. "No thief with sense goes near the prince's people, whatever the purse — it's the noose for the man who tries, and grief for the whole guild after. Which is why—" His gaze went again to the silent figure in the corner, and the words came out something close to a plea. "Truly, sir, we'd no notion who he was. We'd never have marked him, had we known. It was an accident, start to finish — a merchant with a heavy purse, that's the whole of what we took him for."

"Of course," Jude said. "We're speaking now of saving your life in exchange for information worth verifying — so let's have the rest of it. Who else does Janus leave alone? Whose coin buys a thief's blind eye, and whose buys his silence outright?"

"The usual sort, as ever. But there are new players paying, this past year."

"The Toli?" Jude asked.

"Aye. Toli coin, these four months past — they've been thick in the foreign district." Gregory spread his hands. "Janus takes their money, that much I'd swear to; what for, I couldn't say. To my own mind it's only to leave them be — no thieving against their own, no trouble stirred up their way. Dealing with that lot's a death sentence in itself, so a man takes what they'll pay to keep clear of them and asks no questions." He hesitated. "If you want a name out of it, though — Cain Toli's is the one that comes up more than most."

"We're not speaking of nobles," Jude said. "Their hired hands."

"These are the hired hands, sir — noblemen, trained from birth in murder and in magic both. Several have passed through the foreign district these last months."

Jude's brow rose. "A family tradition, then?"

"Well known among those who know it at all. The noble houses of Toli raise their own to both crafts."

"Why would crossing them mean death, if not for direct attack?"

"Not attack alone, sir — even offense given would be treated the same as harming any noble house. Toli won't suffer insult to their own."

"Stop circling," Jude said, an edge creeping into his voice now. "Speak plainly. We're after the Toli rats specifically."

"Rats come and go, sir, they're everywhere in this city now — those aren't who you ought to fear. It's the noble assassins you want."

"How many have been seen?"

"Four, sir. Asking after certain people, meeting contacts, spending coin like it was water — odd behavior, the whole of it." He drew himself up a little, some thin thread of pride surfacing through the fear. "I've had eyes on this trade since I was near ten years old — seventeen now — and I know odd when I see it. Then, near five days past, all four of them went out of Monmurg at once, together, and none's been seen since."

"How can you be so certain?"

"They wear distinctive rings — easily marked, if you know to look."

Jude weighed the young man a long moment. "Are you being straight with us — mostly, at least?"

Gregory gave a quick, earnest nod.

"And can you reach this Janus yourself — sit across a table from him, not merely pass word up the line?"

A firmer nod this time, some small pride in it.

"Better than I'd hoped." Jude turned it over. "There could be real coin in this for you. But we'd want the man ourselves, face to face, and we're no guildsmen — so you'll arrange it, and you'll vouch for his safety in the arranging." Gregory's head bobbed, quick to promise as much. "He'll balk only at a trap, and he'd be right to; so we give him no cause to smell one. Somewhere open — a ship, perhaps, discreet enough, and none of the prince's fleet."

"Perhaps the Grand Market instead, sir, on a trade day."

Jude considered the crowded — or these days, half-empty — stalls of the Grand Market, the anonymity a thinning crowd might still afford. "That could serve. Still open ground, at least."

"He'll want an easy road out, sir, should he need one. He's not marching to the dungeon himself."

"Eight months in charge, you said. Do you trust him?"

"As far as trust runs in that business, sir — more than an outsider, certainly more than any Toli."

"I don't recognize you from the market myself," Paul cut in, gesturing to his own mask. "Was I even wearing this, when you first came at me?"

"No, sir, not when we first marked you," Gregory said.

"Wait," Paul said, working it through. "I wasn't wearing it?"

"We marked you before that, sir, coming out of the royal district — and there was something strange about your face even then, waxen and too smooth, with no proper expression to it. We saw you leave the stall, sir, then lost you a while in the crowd — and when we found you again, you were wearing the very mask you'd just

bought."

"What is that mask, truly," Paul asked, "to you? Speak plainly — I'll have the truth, or I'll have the hand."

"Truthfully, sir, I've only rumors of it," Gregory said. "That foreign spies are said to favor that very style, and that the red monks wear something near to it. Past that, I couldn't tell you what it signifies — I've no real knowledge of the thing, only what gets whispered in the district."

"So when you say you'd not have targeted me," Paul pressed, "you took me, from the mask alone, for one of these foreign spies?"

"No, sir, let me set it plain. We saw you come from the royal district, but dressed common — like any merchant. Strange, for where you'd come from. No mask yet, then — plain clothes, a coin purse jingling loud enough to draw any eye in the district. That's what marked you for us. We followed. There was something wrong about your face, though — human enough, but it moved strangely. Too smooth. Too perfect, if that makes sense."

"You weren't wearing the red monk's mask yet," Gregory continued. "We watched you buy it, off a vendor in the market — as if you didn't quite know what you were purchasing."

"There's a vendor selling these openly?" Jude asked, a little surprised at the notion. He turned it over — that Paul had bought a Scarlet Brotherhood mask off a market stall with no real notion of what it was — and considered his young companion anew, reweighing him behind that stoic elven calm.

"Yes, sir — he's the one you ought to speak with, truly, not me."

"We'll come to him," Paul said. "But I confess, I have no notion who that vendor is."

"No matter," Jude said, taking the thread back. "We're more interested in the coin trail regardless. Where do we find him — your friend who ran? Where does he drink, where does he sleep?"

Jude flicked a hand at the jailer — poker away, the good wine brought, not the swill already poured — and the small kindness loosened the young man's tongue.

"I like the sound of that, sir," Gregory said, as Jude poured a

glass of wine. "The Homely Wench, sir, in the foreign district," he went on, some hope creeping in now. "Down toward the docks, not up by the market wall. That's where you'll find the friend who ran out on me last night — Jobs, he goes by — he's about the place as often as not."

Jude inclined his head, content to let him run on. "And the vendor," he said, "the one who sold the mask — where does his stall sit?"

Gregory considered, plainly reaching for the little he had. "Looked to be from the east, sir. Some southern country — Spindrift Isles, maybe. I couldn't tell you much beyond that, in truth."

"I'd like to trust you," Jude said, weighing the whole account. "More than that — I'd like to use you, often, for information. I think you understand the value in that. Let's say you remain here a while longer, while we verify what you've given us — beginning with these assassins who supposedly left five days past."

"Five, yes, sir."

"They wouldn't have left without someone behind to relay word. That's exactly what we need to know."

"There's one I can think of, sir. New to the city, around the same time the others came. An elven maid."

Jude exchanged a glance with Paul. "I think I know who you mean."

"Yeah," Paul said quietly.

"Describe her," Jude said.

"An elf, sir. Comely, hard to pin down — she knows when she's followed, clear as day. Rumor puts her near Lord Jamis's residence more than once. No one's certain whether she serves him, or the Toli."

"If we managed this without involving Jamis directly," Jude asked, "how would you feel about becoming an informant?"

"There's real risk in it, sir." Whatever hope had crept into Gregory a moment before drained out of him now; his hands found the ragged hem of his shirt and worried at it, and his voice dropped low

and uneven. "If my own guild ever learned I'd sat here and talked — if so much as a whisper of it got back to them—"

"You'll get beaten bloody," Paul finished for him. "That's rather the point of it — we'll see it done ourselves, before you're ever let go. A man worked over by the prince's guards and dumped back in the gutter is no one's idea of a willing informant; the state of you is what keeps your own guild from ever guessing you sat and talked with us at all."

"I expect that's necessary, sir, honestly."

Jude studied him a long moment, weighing the man's nerve, and found it holding steadier than he'd expected. "We'll break the nose," Paul offered. "Take a finger, perhaps — something visible, so it's plain you didn't talk willingly."

"Have the guards rough him up properly before he's released," Jude agreed. "It needs to look convincing."

"Unless we go straight to Janus and strike our own bargain," Paul mused. "As guild master, he could offer cover of his own."

"What's the usual punishment," Jude asked Gregory, "for being seen speaking with the royal family?"

"If the street hasn't already learned who took me," Gregory said slowly, thinking it through, "then word likely hasn't spread — but if it's known I came from the upper city—"

"A hand?" Paul asked.

"That's my thought," Jude said.

"A foot instead, perhaps," Paul offered. "A man hobbling about tells its own story."

"Either way, it's a poor bargain for him," Jude said, and turned to Gregory. "Which would you rather lose, given the choice — or have you a better notion?"

Gregory drew a steadying breath. "Take my off-hand, sir, if it must be done."

"I'd hate to take it at all," Paul admitted, and meant it more than he expected to. "But it might serve you well, in the end — a life given properly to the crown's use."

"Truly, sir, only Jobs knows what became of me that night. I

couldn't say how many others saw."

"What if they believe you dead already?" Jude offered. "Tossed onto the body pile, and you crawled free on your own — you did take a bolt through the throat, after all." His glance slid sidelong to Paul, dry and faintly amused, for the thing had a neatness to it he could appreciate: the boy had handed them a half-made corpse without ever meaning to, and a man already near killed was the easiest sort to leave for dead and forget. Better luck than any planning could have bought them.

"I bandaged him after," Paul said — defensive on the surface, though he'd caught the drift of the game by now and was speaking to the man in the chair as much as to Jude. "Put my own finger to the wound and wrapped it. He'd have bled out in the gutter otherwise." Let Gregory hear it and remember: these were men who had troubled to keep him breathing.

Jude took up the thread without missing a beat, dry and half-fond. "Barely a bandage, and hardly proper care — but it held, and here he sits. Leave him for dead, let his own guild grieve him, and we've a ghost in their ranks who owes us the breath in his chest. Not bad at all." And it was, Paul thought, the first stretch of the whole strange day the two of them had moved as one thing, each reading the other's play before it landed — and he suspected Jude had felt it as plainly as he had.

"It isn't your vanishing that worries me," Jude said. "A man in your straits has nowhere worth running to. What worries me is whether you'd sell us out — whether the right coin, or the right blade at your throat, might buy someone a good look at our faces and the run of our business."

"Sell you to whom, sir?" Gregory said, almost sheepish. "I've no names for either of you, no faces — a masked lord and an elf, and that's the whole of what I could tell a soul. And what would I even say? That I was questioned in the prince's own dungeon, after being left for dead on a body pile? No one would credit a word of it. There's no one I could sell you to, sir, even had I the wish — which I don't."

"Fair enough," Jude allowed. "The story protects itself either way." He turned the whole account over once more, then laid it out plain, item by item, for the man in the chair. "So here is where we stand, and here is what you'll do. A man who crawls off a body pile is a man no one credits, least of all against the crown — so you walk out of here alive, both hands whole, and paid besides, the moment you've earned it. What you'll earn it with is a line to Janus. Go to him and make it plain we've no quarrel with the man himself; it's the Toli we're after, and whatever they've been about in the district these four months — the coin they've been slipping him to look the other way. You and your friend Jobs may know more of that than most; bring me the whole of it. And if ever you come to think Janus is bought outright, and not merely paid to keep his distance, that word comes to me before any other. There's a woman in this yet, besides — that elf you named, the one seen at Lord Jamis's door. She sits somewhere near the middle of it. Keep your ears open for her too."

"Should he make first contact as our man," Paul asked, "or investigate whether Janus is compromised, first?"

"Investigate first," Jude said. "How will you reach us?"

"Ferd's Bar," Paul said, before Gregory could answer — a deliberate choice, and made for reasons he kept to himself. He would not have a guild informant reporting to the Royal Palace, nor to any place that led back to it. Partly it was the family name he guarded: the Princes of Monmurg did not conduct this sort of business in the open, and a masked lord's dealings with thieves and Toli-hunters were better kept well clear of the palace gates. And partly — he owned it only to himself — he wanted this thread in his own hand a while before it reached his uncle's. Whatever came of Gregory's work, Paul meant to be the one who carried it to Jeon and to Jamis, in his own time and his own words, and not have it arrive at the palace ahead of him.

Jude turned to the prisoner, his brows rising. "You know Ferd's?"

"Know of it, sir," Gregory said. "We don't go in — only the worst

sort drink there."

"You should worry rather more about us, then," Jude said, "seeing as that's precisely where we do our business. How long do you need, to learn whether Janus is tangled up with the Toli scum?"

"Five days, sir," Gregory said.

"Five days, then — and here's what they earn you," Jude said. "Coin, and food besides, if it can be spared; I know well enough what a siege does to a man's larder. We'll begin with five gold, and go a good deal further should what you bring us prove worth the having. There's no ceiling on it, if you deliver."

"We have a bargain, then, sir."

Paul glanced at Jude. "Do we know anything more of the thieves' guild, from your own past dealings?"

The question drew something up in Jude he did not often let surface. "There was an assassins' guild in this city once," he said, slower now. "Not so many years back — a proper one, blades for hire and worse. It's gone. Broken."

He let a breath pass, and the memory came with it, unwelcome and vivid: a night, a narrow stair, three of them climbing it in the dark on Lord Jamis's own quiet order — himself, and Gouge, and Karmirg — sent to see the thing ended. Room by room through the guild's own headquarters they had gone, and by the time the dawn came up there was no one left inside to see it. Not one of the assassins walked out alive.

It was not the dying that had stayed with him. He had felt no horror at the deaths, nor at his own hand in them; the men had earned their ending, and he had made his peace with such work long before that night. What stayed with him was the manner of it — the way each of the three of them had gone about the slaughter, and what he had seen of himself in the seeing. Gouge had killed the way a hard man drinks, close and wet and unhurried, taking a plain animal satisfaction in the work. And Karmirg's orc blood had shown plainest of all, a red joy in the breaking of bodies that no half of his human side had ever quite civilized.

Jude — the elf, who might have fancied himself finer than either

— had told himself through the first of it that he was not as they were, that his own violence was a cleaner thing: done from across a room with a word and a gesture, fire and force and no blood dried on his sleeves. It was somewhere on that stair that the comfort of it came apart in his hands. A man burned alive at ten paces was no less dead, and had screamed no less, than one opened up with a knife; the distance had only spared Jude the smell of him. His savagery simply wore better manners. He stood no higher than the human and the half-orc at his back — he was only further from the mess they made, and had let that little space of air persuade him he was better. That was the thing the memory kept, and would not give back.

“I was party to the ending of them myself,” was all he said aloud, something old and unreadable passing across his face. “So I know what’s left of it. A straight thieves’ guild now, most likely — cutpurses and second-story men, not assassin-trained.” He turned back to Gregory. “What I most need to know is whether the Toli mean to rebuild what was broken — and whether Janus is taking their coin to look away. Even if he is, we might still find a use for him.”

“What else do you require of us, beyond hiring me?” Gregory asked.

“Well — the beating, of course,” Jude said, as easily as remarking on the weather. Gregory’s nerves showed plainly at that. “Don’t look so stricken. It’s no cruelty for its own sake. Turn you loose unmarked, and every man in your guild wonders why the crown handled you so gently — and wondering is the first step to knowing. A thief who crawls home half-broken is a thief who held his tongue under the irons; the state of you is your whole cover. Take the beating, and no one thinks to ask what you told us — because plainly you told us nothing.”

From there the two of them fell to arranging Gregory’s release — or rather, to toying with the man under the guise of arranging it, trading the grisly particulars back and forth with rather more relish than the task strictly required. He would take a convincing beating,

the sort any thief caught red-handed might expect; he might even “die” of it, for the story’s sake, with a few near-misses thrown in for good measure. His collar would be soaked in blood, to suggest the guards had tried to beat the truth from him before he bled out from the old throat wound, and his body left on the pile with the rest — so that when he crawled free, presumed dead, no one who had seen the guards take him would think it anything but an interrogation gone too far, and none of his own guild would smell a royal hand in it. They would see him properly mended after, they assured him, and could not resist needling him the while — for the clumsiness of the robbery that had landed him here, his poor aim, and whatever in the world he’d imagined he was going to do with that sling.

“The lure here is simply the coin,” Jude said, “and it’ll be plenty, if you deliver — enough to go a long way, so don’t lose heart. I’ll come by Ferd’s within three days. I won’t make a habit of the place myself, so when you’ve word, ask the barkeep for ‘the still’ — that signals him to send for us, if we’re not already there.” Gregory nodded along to each of it, quick and earnest, fixing the instructions in his mind. “We’ll shake on it, then,” Jude finished, “for whatever that’s worth between men like us.”

Gregory’s eyes drifted, all the same, to the poker cooling on the wall and the cabinet of irons beside it, weighing in his own mind the one part of this bargain he could not talk his way clear of — the beating still to come.

“Anything troubling you?” Jude asked, marking the look.

“The beating, sir.”

“We’ll see it’s bruises only. No broken bone.”

“I’m grateful for that.”

“Don’t take it too personally if it runs worse than planned regardless,” Jude warned. “I’ll bring a healing draught in three days, should it prove more serious. Understood? Anything else, concerning us?”

“Nothing, sir.”

“Good. And know this — people who betray us have an unfortunate habit of going missing, for reasons that never quite trace back

to us."

"Understood, sir. I've a good memory for such things."

They left him then, the jailer already moving to make good on the arranged violence — bruises only, the body pile, no true death in it. Out in the corridor, Paul retrieved his homunculus from where it had waited, watchful, in the shadow of the door.

"What now?" Jude asked. "We could send the little creature ahead, wander the district ourselves."

"There's a use for it yet," Paul said. "It could keep watch on the booth where I found that mask — mark who comes and goes, and whom the vendor answers to. And perhaps I go without wearing the thing a while myself."

"Wise, given all we've just heard," Jude agreed, and the two of them climbed back toward the light of the upper palace, leaving the dungeon and its bargains behind them.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Summoned to the Harbor Office

That same afternoon, while Paul and Jude were still at their work in the dungeon beneath the palace, a very different summons had gone out across the city. A runner had pulled Merrick away from a game of cards in the barracks common room with nothing more than “Lord Jamis wants you,” and Merrick — a ranger and navigator long attached to Jamis’s household, a man who had walked more of Helm Island’s coastline than anyone else still drawing breath in Monmurg — had known better than to ask why before he arrived.

He was Monmurg-born, the son of Captain Nado — a navigator of no small renown in the fleet, a man with salt in his veins and an old, undimmed hatred of the sahaugin, whose battle-tales he had poured into his boy from the cradle. What his father began, the sea had finished. Merrick had grown lean and sure-handed, strong without being a brute, deadly with a bow, and wise well beyond his years — though his wisdom owed less to study than to instinct, the same instinct that let him read a coastline, a tide, or a room full of scheming princes with equal ease. It was a night off the Scimitars, his quick reckoning saving a ship the dark and the rocks had meant to take, that first drew Lord Jamis’s eye; the admiral had claimed him for his own soon after, and set him to watch the waters around Helm Island. If Jamis privately held him the finest the Principality had to offer — as he had his father before him — he was far too careful a man to ever say so aloud.

Merrick walked the harbor district with the city’s troubles pressing close on every side, the way they pressed on everyone now. The

blockade had throttled trade to a trickle; Port Torvin still smoldered in memory somewhere near the Hool River; and beneath it all ran the newer, stranger rumor — that the fleets weren't merely losing to Keoland but had somehow stopped trying, held back from open water by something no one in the taverns could quite name. Merrick had heard enough of it that the strangeness scarcely registered anymore. He climbed the stairs to Jamis's office with his mind already elsewhere, and stopped short at the door.

A man sat in the chair across from Jamis's desk — rough-looking, sun-worn, armed with both crossbow and cutlass, and wholly at his ease in the room, sprawled in the seat with the loose comfort of someone long accustomed to closed doors and the powerful men who kept them.

Merrick did not know the face, but he knew the make of the man at a glance, and it settled a coolness in his gut. Here was older blood — privateer blood, of the breed that had come up a generation before his own, back when Monmurg's cut-throats still sailed openly under captains like Cross and their weather crossbowmen and called the piracy an honest trade. The streets and the sea had both had the shaping of him; it showed in the flat, unhurried eyes of a man who had picked pockets and cut throats with the same steady hands and lost no sleep over either. Whatever else he was, he was Jamis's — of that much Merrick was certain, for he was Jamis's too, the pair of them cut from the same bolt of cloth by the same patient hand, only a generation apart. And that was the very thing that unsettled him. Merrick was easy enough in this room; the stranger was easier still. It was the man himself he could not get easy with — and the man wore the look of someone who had never once in his life cared whether anyone could.

"I've not seen you before," Merrick said, more to himself than the stranger.

"I was summoned by Lord Jamis," the man said. "You a friend of his?"

"I'd generally know it, if someone were."

Jamis entered before either of them could press further, settling

behind his desk with the particular weariness of a man who had already had one difficult conversation today and expected this to be another. "I have no close friends, Merrick — you should know that of me by now. Associates. Enemies. I counted your father among the former, once, though there's precious little left of that to speak to, given his death. Gouge, here, I speak to about certain matters. He knows the way of them."

Merrick studied the stranger anew at the name — a name that meant something, even if the face didn't yet.

"The city's fortunes have gone from bad to worse," Jamis said, without preamble. "We've lost no ships in the last day, but last night a fog rolled over Helm Island — strange for the season, strange full stop; the winds should have scattered it, the water's not warm enough this time of year to raise that kind of haze on its own. When it lifted, we signaled the island, as we always do. The answer we got back wasn't properly coded."

"Has anyone gone to inspect?" Merrick asked.

"You're about to be the first."

"So I'm the first to hear of this."

"You understand I need more than intuition to call you in for something like this, rather than simply sending a routine crew to fetch the proper code." Jamis's mouth thinned. "I brought my suspicions to Prince Jeon. He rejected them — thinks me too alarmed. I believe Lord Fairwind has turned traitor to the other princes. You'll recall what I've said of Sacnon Toli, and how he's carried himself of late — I think Fairwind shares more sympathy for that man than he's ever let on. He made demands in council last month, over the trade money flowing through Monmurg. Jeon counts the man a friend — has for years, and will hear no word against him. But I have watched Fairwind closely where Jeon sees only an old comrade, and I have marked the snake coiled behind that easy friendship. I fear he's working with the Toli in some fashion."

He fixed Merrick with a look. "Have you noticed anything strange, on your patrols near Helm Island, these past weeks?"

"Nothing," Merrick said. "Nothing at all — I'd have raised it.

No strange sign on the beaches, no talk worth the name among the crews or along the docks." He turned it over a moment. "Though there are rumors — the men keep asking why we're not simply sailing out and breaking Keoland's blockade by force. We could, by most reckonings. Something's holding us back, and that's where the ghost stories start."

"Those rumors interest me a great deal," Jamis said. "There have been ships lost that ought to have won their engagements easily. The few survivors we've recovered speak of fog, and something vast coming out of the mist — like one of the Toli slaving ships, three hundred feet of hull crashing through a corsair before vanishing without a trace. Your report is the first confirmed instance of that same fog occurring so close to home. The noose is closing, Merrick. I don't know if it's the Toli — Gouge, you've had your own dealings with their agents, and with Lord Phranck — or something Keoland itself has set loose." He turned to the rough-looking man in the chair, fixing him with a direct look. "Is this Cain Toli's doing, Gouge?"

"I couldn't say," Gouge said, meeting the look without a flicker.

"Truthfully, I don't much care, just now," Jamis said. "I'm sending you both out on the corsair — you as my eyes, to watch how the captain handles his command and whether the island itself feels wrong. And I want to know, above all, whether Fairwind has betrayed us. If he has, Gouge, I want you to do what you do best, and see it through."

He turned to Gouge directly. "You'll have an ally aboard — the wizard Jude — though you're not to acknowledge him, nor speak to him. You'll go disguised as a weather crossbowman, your old rank — I've studded leather waiting for you in the back room; that armor of yours stays here."

"Fine," Gouge said, without warmth.

That Jude would be aboard came as no surprise. Where Jamis had his hand in a thing, he was as like as not to turn up somewhere in it. Gouge trusted the elf about as far as he trusted anyone still drawing breath — which was to say, well enough — but trust and

talk were separate matters, and he had never had much use for the second. "Good — that's easy enough."

"He travels with a young noble, Paul Revero — Jeon's nephew. No harm is to come to that boy, whatever else happens. I argued against his going at all, but Jeon wants him seen, wants him given some weight in the world. I'll say plainly: I need you watching over him as well as everything else. If he dies, it reflects poorly on both of us. Are you equal to this?"

"Whatever you put me to, I'll see done," Gouge said.

Jamis turned back to Merrick. "I know trust doesn't come easily where Gouge is concerned, from the outside. But he's loyal to me, and his judgment in this matters more than you know."

Merrick let his eyes travel over the shark-eyed stranger once more — the flask, the flat unbothered stare, the whole dangerous stillness of the man — and had to work to keep the objection off his face. *This one? Truly?* But he had never once had cause to doubt Jamis, whatever else he might doubt, and he was not about to start now over a man he had known the length of an afternoon. His trust in Gouge was worth nothing yet; his trust in Jamis was worth everything. "If you trust him," Merrick said, "I've no cause to argue it."

Jamis turned to Gouge. "Support Merrick's authority with the troops wherever it's wanted, and keep out of sight — show your hand only if you must. If you can work your way close to Fairwind himself, so much the better; a nameless crossbowman may go where my advisor cannot. But hear me plainly. Merrick knows this island and these waters as few men living do, and his is the wiser head by far. Heed his advice, and keep that knife of yours ready at his back — there is real worth in the man, and you'd do well to listen to it. It may be I'm only being paranoid, and all is well out there. But that failed signal sits ill with me."

"Strange fog, strange ships, strange signal." Merrick turned the three of them over together, and for the first time they refused to sit as three separate things. A fog risen out of nowhere; ghost ships sliding from the mist; a garrison that answered its own city in the

wrong code. Laid side by side like that, they stopped looking like ill luck and began to look like a design — one hand behind all of it, patient and unseen. And if that was so, a mere traitor in the Helm was the least of what might be waiting out there. He understood, of a sudden, why Jamis had reached past his honest troopers for the shark-eyed man at his side: whatever Fairwind had become, and whatever stood behind him, it would want meeting by someone who could face it on its own ground — quiet, and ruthless, and unafraid to do the ugly thing first. “Understood,” he said, and meant it rather more than he had a moment before. “And for what it’s worth — I’d sooner trust that suspicion of yours than the prince’s comfort. Whatever waits out there, I’d rather ride toward it beside a man already expecting the worst of it.”

“His mind doesn’t run half so dark as mine does these days,” Jamis agreed. “And I fear there have been infiltrations into the Royal Palace itself of late.”

Gouge stirred for the first time since the talk had turned to the island. “Do we know which direction the fog came from?”

“That’s the strangest part of it,” Jamis admitted. “It came from nowhere at all. Simply occurred. I’ve never seen its like — it felt summoned, to my mind, out of nothing.”

“The wizard who visited us before — Phranck.” Gouge’s flat eyes had gone somewhere distant, sifting back through old ground. “Would he have been capable of something on that scale?”

It was not the question Merrick had expected from the man, and he found himself quietly revising his measure of him. Whatever else the shark-eyed stranger was, he was not only a knife. There was a mind at work behind those dead eyes, and it was not idle — it was moving backward through things already done and half-forgotten, fitting this new strangeness against some older pattern only Gouge could yet see.

Jamis considered it. “You saw him fight the Toli agents yourself. He wasn’t weak — he could throw a fireball as well as any evoker I’ve met — but you watched them shut his casting down cold from thirty feet off, as if slapping the words from his mouth. Powerful,

yes. All-powerful, no."

Jamis straightened, and turned back to Merrick. "You'll travel as my advisor, under the captain's authority rather than your own — the unit carries two hundred fifty Marines; you'll fold into it without trouble. Can you follow Gouge's lead on this, knowing what the mission entails?"

"I'll have no command of my own, then," Merrick said, working it through.

"None to speak of — this sits outside the ordinary run of command entirely." Jamis said it plainly. "There'll be a Marine sergeant over the troops; he'll know your face, and know you carry my voice, and he'll ask your counsel because of it. But understand what that is and what it is not. You are the face of Lord Jamis out there, not his authority — the men will heed you for whose man you are, not because any writ compels them. There is no true command in it."

"That suits me better, if anything," Merrick said.

"Then hear the rest. Between you and Gouge, it is Gouge who decides — what he says stands, for the pair of you, and no one else need ever know it. This is quiet work, done in the dark, and it answers to no chain of command but mine." Jamis held his eye. "Are you willing to do what needs doing?"

Merrick was a moment answering. It did not sit easy, putting his name to a thing and another man's hand to the reins of it — a killer's hand, at that, one he had known the length of an afternoon. But he had never once had cause to doubt Jamis, and did not mean to begin now. "I am," he said at last, and the words came slow, and more resigned than willing.

Jamis turned back to Gouge. "You'll surrender the dragon-scale armor to my keeping, while you're gone. Your disguise must be convincing."

"Grudgingly," Gouge said.

"I'll have it cleaned, if that reassures you."

"Don't try it on. It won't suit you. Clean it if you like, provided I get it back."

"We'll see what the laundress can manage." Jamis looked be-

tween them both.

"Anything else you need of me?" Gouge asked.

He glanced at Gouge. "Choose a name for yourself, if you like, for the crossing."

"Aristotle," Gouge said. "Old one of mine."

"That'll serve." Jamis rose. "Keep your own eyes open out there — watch for signs of anything strange near Helm Island. You know that coastline as well as anyone alive, Merrick. If it's only Fairwind, we can deal with that. If it's something larger, tied to the Toli, I want to know it the moment you do. Now go — the ship leaves within the hour, from the Royal Docks."

"We'll want to stop by the tavern first," Gouge said.

"Five minutes, no more, and it'll still put you at the dock in time."

They went by way of a harbor-district bar Jamis's people knew well, where Gouge collected two flasks and put them on his tab with the air of a man who fully intended to settle it eventually, and then made for the Royal Docks, where a corsair sat loaded for battle — no small skiff, no token gesture, but a full battalion readying itself under the afternoon light.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Orders for the Helm

Of all this, Paul and Jude knew nothing. While Jamis set his other agents moving toward the harbor, the two of them took the back stairs up from the dungeon and returned to the little study, where the last of the wine and cheese still waited. It was past two in the afternoon now, the light through the narrow window gone thin and golden.

"We need another thread to pull," Jude said, dropping into a chair, "as we'll not get one on the Toli straight off. Gregory's efforts could take some time to get a result, and I am sure Jamis wants quicker ones. But someone is selling those masks in the open market — and you know what that mask is, don't you?"

Paul ran a gloved thumb along the ringed edge of his own. "I didn't choose it because it looks well," he said. "Though it is comfortable. I'll grant it that."

"You heard the prisoner. Assassins wear that face — it's near enough a badge." Jude leaned forward. "Keep it, by all means. It may serve. But I'd not wear it walking about day to day, if I were you. One of my own people might put a knife in you for it, and never ask why."

"Your people," Paul repeated, dry. "And why would one of your people knife me over a bit of metal?"

"Because of exactly what the boy told us — which is what troubles me. That a man could buy such a thing off a stall in the Grand Market, plain as buying fish."

Jude considered that, head tilting in the way Paul was already learning to read. "Unless it's a sign, and not a sale. You said the

vendor kept only the one on display — that you had to ask for yours.”

“I asked for a darker shade. That was all,” Paul said. “The one on display was a lighter tone; mine came from beneath the counter.”

“That’s no accident. A darker tone for those who know to ask.” Jude’s fingers stilled. “That mask belongs to the Scarlet Brotherhood. They keep no open temples, do no honest trade — and the last time I crossed their kind, I had to put two of them in the ground, and they repaid me in ways I’d sooner not describe.” Something old and cold moved in his eyes.

“Forgive me,” Jude said, quieter, collecting himself. “A sore subject. The point stands, all the same — whoever sold you that wants finding, and questioning, properly. That man belongs in a cell, and I mean it.”

“I’ve connections of my own in the market,” Paul said. “I don’t doubt you’ve a few as well. And I’ll not pretend it doesn’t interest me — there’s no harm I can see in tracing where the thing came from.”

“No harm.” Jude’s voice hardened by a degree. “It leads us to the Brotherhood, Paul. And they sit well above your Toli rats — greedy opportunists, the Toli, the whole breed of them. For all we know the Toli run errands for the Brotherhood and never learn whose hand feeds them.”

“And where do you come by that?” Paul asked, an edge rising to meet his. “Because you say it?”

“Because I’ve spent a lifetime doing the work set in front of me, and learning its shape.” Jude did not raise his voice, which somehow made it worse. “You’ll do this. What is it you object to — that we take the vendor, lean on him, threaten him if we must?”

“That we’d do it on no evidence at all,” Paul said.

“On no evidence that touches what you care for, you mean.”

“I care that we’ve the right man before we break him,” Paul said. “That is all.”

For a moment they only looked at one another, the disagreement settling into something that was not quite a quarrel and not quite

trust. It was Jude who broke it.

"Then we put it to Jamis," he said. "He's your godfather, near enough. Let him weigh it."

"Fine," Paul said. "We'll take it to Jamis."

They did not have long to wait. They sat glowering companionably over the dregs of the wine, and perhaps five minutes on the door opened and Lord Jamis stepped in, a long day of councils and hard errands written in the tiredness of his face.

"I see you've made short work of the refreshments," he observed, waving for a servant to bring more before he settled himself. "You've had time enough to take each other's measure, I trust. Tell me what you've learned."

"We've a lead I don't think much of, and Jude thinks a great deal of," Paul said. "The mask — the one I bought. It belongs to the Scarlet Brotherhood, some order down in the southern isles, beyond the Toli. Jude would have us trace the vendor who sold it."

Jamis's expression did not change, but something in his stillness sharpened. "The man who sold that mask will be looked into," he said. "By others. Not by you. Leave him be — don't accost him, don't bring him in." He let that settle. "Keep the mask, if you like, against some later need. But you are not to walk the city in it."

Paul kept his own counsel, though the ruling chafed — to be told he might keep the mask yet never wear it was to be handed a fine thing and have it taken back in the same breath, and he wondered, sourly, what he was meant to have for it.

"Now — what of the rest?" Jamis said.

Jude gave him the gist of it: the man who'd tried for Paul's life the night before, the thieves'-guild mark across his back, a guild master named Janus some eight months in his seat. "I've set him to learn whether Janus takes Toli coin. And he says it's common talk in the streets that the Toli assassins quit the city some five days past — all four at once."

"Five to seven," Jamis said. "It fits what I've heard."

"Which is strange in itself, that every gutter in the foreign district should know it. I asked whether any agent had stayed behind.

He named an elf — a woman, hard to follow, seen near your own residence.” Jude watched him carefully. “I took her for Kalisi.”

“Leave her to me — for now.” Jamis said it more gently than the rest of it. “Kalisi’s been missing these past few days. I can’t tell you what’s become of her — whether she’s turned, or been taken, or simply gone to ground — but I’ve agents enough out looking already, and two more blundering after her would only foul their work. When there’s cause to run her down, you’ll be the ones I send. Until then, leave her to me.” He drew a breath. “You gave the guildsman coin?”

“Five gold, to start.”

“Keep it minimal. We may want the funds before this is done.” He nodded slowly. “Turning him was well done. Where is the meeting to be?”

“Ferd’s Bar, three days on.”

Paul stirred at that. “He was nervous of the place. Said he’d be killed for setting foot in it.”

“He’s not wrong about its custom,” Jamis said, with the ghost of something that might have been amusement. “You know it well enough, Jude — you and the men who run it. You helped make its name what it is.”

“It’s a filthy hole,” Jude allowed. “But safe enough, for us — I’ve killed men there myself.”

“Just so.” Jamis let the silence hold a beat, then set his cup aside and leaned in, and the room changed with him. “But the guild and the mask must keep. I’ve other work for you now — the reason for this morning’s council. I want the two of you on a boat.”

Jude grimaced. “I hate the water. To where?”

“A corsair is making for Helm Island. You’ll be aboard her.” Jamis folded his hands. “Last night there was a storm in the straits — a fog bank, unnatural, that swallowed the whole channel for hours and then lifted as though it had never been. By day the Helm looks well enough from shore. But it has not answered with the correct signal — the watch out there swears all is well, yet they will not give us the day’s proper watchword.”

"So someone may hold the fortress," Jude said slowly, "and wears the garrison's face over it — under cover of that fog. Would that be the front of a larger invasion?"

"Who seizes a fortress meaning to stop there?" Jamis said. "Commodore Fairwind commands the Helm — a seasoned man, five-and-forty or thereabouts, no greybeard but no green recruit either. It may be nothing worse than a weary officer giving a wrong order. But we must know."

"And how are we put ashore?" Jude asked.

"Openly. Paul goes as himself, in daylight — as Prince Jeon's representative, and he'll carry a writ that says so. You'll be known to the captain as his man." Jamis's gaze moved to Jude. "You are to lend your arts where they're needed, and to see that no harm comes to Paul. The ship goes in force — two hundred and fifty Marines, a full crew. This is no secret errand; we send warships to the Helm often enough. Investigate the whole of the island. Root out any traitor, any Toli, any hand that shouldn't be there — and report to me."

"When do we sail?" Paul asked.

"Within the hour. Gather your kit."

Jude glanced, briefly, toward the door and the market beyond it. "Time enough to stop at a still on the way?"

"For something to steady your stomach on the crossing?" Jamis said. "No. Sober and armed, both of you. The tide won't wait, and neither, I think, will whatever holds the Helm."

Paul gathered himself to go, but Jude did not move. He had caught something in the set of Jamis's shoulders — an order not yet given — and he waited. Jamis marked the younger man out the door, and when it had closed he drew Jude a half-step aside, his voice dropping low enough that it would not carry.

"A quick word," Jamis said. The easy formality of the room had gone; what remained was harder, more tired. "This is more dire than I let on in front of Paul. What I gave the boy was the gentler shape of it — I'll not lay the whole weight on him, not yet. But I think there's more than a mistake behind the failed signal from the

Helm. I think it will be bad news, out there. I think Lord Fairwind may have turned traitor to the sea principalities."

"And if he has?" Jude asked.

"If he has, the whole island is lost with him. But it could be worse even than that. The Helm matters for more than its position in the strait — there are things kept there vital to Monmurg's defense. If those fall into the wrong hands, we are as exposed as we have ever been."

"Do I have leeway to act as I judge best?"

"More than my other agents," Jamis said. "I'm sending Gouge aboard the same ship. You are not to acknowledge that you know him — to anyone, least of all Paul. You are not the knife, Jude. Your task is to see that Paul comes home alive. But mark this well: the Helm must be retaken. It cannot remain in the hands of a traitor, or an enemy."

"Is there a signal, for Gouge — whether we take it ourselves, or wait for reinforcement?"

"Gouge's charge is simple enough to state, if not to execute: confirm that Fairwind is dead, or confirm that he remains loyal. That is the whole of his mission. The ship's captain is to know nothing of either of your true purposes — to him, this is merely lending aid to another prince's man."

"Will Paul hold any command over the Marines?"

"Not officially," Jamis said. "He travels as Jeon's representative, nothing more. My prince doesn't fully grasp how thin the ice beneath us has grown — but the guardsmen will be there regardless. If you reach the island, gain the Helm, and have Gouge and loyal Marines at your side, I trust you to keep Paul safe, and to take the place by whatever means the moment requires."

"What force does Fairwind command?"

"Better than four hundred men on that island. You'll be outnumbered near two to one. But between your gifts and Gouge's, I expect you can neutralize whatever needs neutralizing — assuming his men aren't all complicit; many may know nothing of what's occurred. What worries me more are the Toli assassins. Gouge has

proven himself against their kind before. I believe you will too."

Jude absorbed it all without visible reaction, his stoic calm doing its work even now. "Understood," he said simply. "I understand."

Jamis studied him a moment longer, as if weighing whether anything more needed saying, then let him go — to Paul, and the kit, and the tide that would not wait.

PART TWO: TO HELM ISLAND

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Royal Docks

At the Royal Docks in Monmurg, Tyrus and Folsom had already been standing at attention for the better part of an hour, part of a marine detachment — crossbowmen and infantry both — summoned down from the Harbor District with no more explanation than the rest of the gathering battalion had been given.

They were a mismatched pair to find shoulder to shoulder in a squad, though the docks knew them both. Tyrus was the larger — six foot four and built to match, with the loud, easy charm of a man half the harbor counted a friend. He had come up hard beneath it: the son of a serving-woman who spun him grand tales of a father he never truly knew, soldier and pirate by turns, the story always ending with a promise of the real one someday. Raised in the loft of his great-uncle Gaius — a freight-runner rough as a barnacled keel, who ruled his little island fleet by no law but his own — Tyrus had gone to sea by the age of eight and lost both his mother and his uncle to a house fire before he was fourteen. What he had carried away was a sailor's hands, a soldier's eye for tactics coaxed from rum-loosened veterans over long evenings, and the hard lesson that the surest way to win a fight was to talk, steer, or loom a man clear out of ever starting one. He loved the Monmurgian navy better than almost anything, and the three islands scarcely less — he knew, as few did, that they were the shield that kept Monmurg from being severed at the neck.

Folsom stood beside him, and if Tyrus was the harbor's friend, Folsom was its music. He was of ordinary height and evenly made — no warrior's build to him at all, though nothing gawky in it either;

the kind of man who crossed a crowded deck without ever seeming to be in anyone's way. A shipwright's son and a seamstress's, he had lost his heart to sound as a boy, when a wandering bard out of Gradsul pressed a fife into his hands and moved on; the melodies had never left him since. He had carried the gift into the navy, where his officers found ready use for it — signals passed ship to ship on a few clean notes, and, worth more than any signal, a tune to lift men's hearts on a long or a bloody crossing. Jovial, unfairly handsome, and no great hand in a fight, he would far sooner bind a wound than open one, and no one who had heard him play seemed much to mind. Somewhere behind the good humor he kept a quiet dream of making his way one day to Gradsul — a city he had never seen — to find the great college of bards he had only ever heard tell of, and learn what a man with a true gift might make of himself there.

Rumor ran fast and thin through the ranks — reinforcement, invasion, escort duty, no one quite certain which — and the fact that the Royal Docks themselves had been given over to the mustering only deepened the unease.

"Escort, they're saying now," Folsom murmured out of the side of his mouth, not troubling himself to come to any proper attention. "Though I heard invasion not an hour past, and a fellow down the line swears we're off to put down a mutiny at one of the beacons."

"They don't muster a full battalion out of the Royal Docks for an escort." Tyrus kept his voice low, his eyes moving over the gathering companies the way another man might read a darkening sky. He had spent half his life on these wharves, and knew what an ordinary sailing looked like; this was not one. "You want to shift grain or troops, you do it from the harbor quays like everyone else. The Royal Docks are for royal business — the prince's own ships, the prince's own eyes. This is something Jeon wants kept close under his own hand."

"Comforting," said Folsom.

"Count the ballistae they're hauling aboard. Count the cross-bowmen." Tyrus nodded at the men in studded-leather armor fil-

ing past. "That's no crew sent to fetch a cargo. That's a crew that reckons it may have to fight for one." He said it easily enough, for the sake of the younger troopers within earshot — but Folsom had known him long enough to catch the thread of disquiet running under the ease of it. "Whatever's waiting out there, somebody a deal higher than a sergeant is afraid of it."

Folsom let a slow breath go and, for once, found nothing light to say to it — which, in Folsom, was as near to worry as the man ever came.

It sharpened into something else entirely when a figure came down from the Royal Palace by its own private stair — dressed head to toe in black, plainly too warm for the weather, a silvered mask fixed over his face, and beside him a sour, tight-lipped elf in a wide hat doing a poor job of disguising what he was. The two of them drew stares the length of the dock before climbing to the sterncastle to speak with the captain.

"That's Paul Revero," Tyrus murmured. "Prince Jeon's nephew. Never laid eyes on him myself before now."

Tyrus and Folsom knew the old stories well enough — kings of legend who wore silver masks not from vanity but mercy, sparing their subjects the sight of some ruinous illness beneath. Whatever the truth of Paul Revero's face, the rumor in Monmurg ran that he'd been disfigured as a boy, in some accident no one spoke of plainly, son of Jeon's late sister Lady Alaria.

Down the line a sergeant's voice went up, brass and carrying — gear on, packs shouldered, every man ready to board the moment the word was given. The order rippled back through the ranks, and the dock dissolved into the ordinary chaos of it: men hauling up crossbows and bedrolls and bundles of bolts, chivvying one another into rough columns before the gangways.

It was amid that readying that Merrick and Gouge found them, crossing the dock with the particular purpose of men who already knew more than they meant to say.

"Tyrus — good to see you," Merrick called.

"Merrick!" Tyrus clapped him on the shoulder, then turned to

the disguised man beside him. "And who's this?"

"My colleague," Merrick said, giving the cover name they'd settled on. "Aristotle."

"Good to meet you," Gouge said, wearing the alias as easily as the borrowed studded leather.

"Likewise," Tyrus said, and for a moment the pleasantries ran on a beat too long, the whole exchange faintly absurd against the backdrop of two hundred fifty men arming for something none of them understood.

The sergeant's voice cut through it, warm with theater. "Merrick! Jamis said you'd be joining us." The warmth was real enough — the two of them went back a long way — but it thinned at the edges, and his eyes lingered on Merrick's face. The sergeant was fond of Merrick; he also knew what it meant when Jamis put his own scout aboard an ordinary crossing. It meant the crossing was not ordinary at all. "Can I ask why you're along for this?"

"Lord Jamis's orders," Merrick said easily. "Heard the weather's been rough out that way — wanted someone with a steady eye, in case we run into trouble."

"Any notion why we're bound for Helm Island?" the sergeant went on, unwilling to let it lie. "Escort work, is what I've been told — minding a shipment in. But it doesn't sit right, considering the muster and the choice of port. Nothing in it worse than that, I'd think. Would you?"

It was not quite a question, and Merrick knew better than to treat it as one. "Could be nothing at all," he said — and it could; that much was true. "A signal that came in wrong, weather playing tricks. Like as not we make port, find everything in order, and sail home bored of each other." Every word of it honest, and not one of them the whole of it — and the sergeant nodded slowly, no more convinced beneath it than before.

The sergeant's eyes moved over Gouge with open appraisal, and what he found there settled something cold in his stomach. It was not confidence he saw, nor a man playing dress-up in borrowed leather — it was a killer, plain as a scar. Gouge had a shark's eyes,

flat and incurious, and the flask never far from his hand told the rest of it, carried openly by a man who did not care in the least who marked him for a drinker. The sergeant had known the type the whole of his life; they were the men who had built the Principalities themselves, out of blood and plunder — pirates born, not cold exactly, not without feeling, but wholly untroubled by whatever they felt. You did not send a man like that to mind a shipment. Seeing him here, in this unit, on this crossing, the sergeant understood in his gut that things were worse than anyone had troubled to tell him.

“Weather crossbowman,” Gouge offered. “Just assigned.”

It was an odd thing to claim, and a prouder one than the man let on. The weather crossbowmen had been a true distinction once — the finest marksmen of the buccaneer crews, the men who could put a bolt through an enemy across a heaving deck in a full gale — but that had been decades gone, back in the wild, lawless days before Monmurg’s privateers were leashed and made respectable. No such rank survived in the navy now. A younger trooper would have heard the words as so much old sea-cant and thought nothing of them. The sergeant was not a younger trooper. He knew precisely what they meant, and precisely what it told him that a man should still wear the title with pride: here stood someone who had learned his trade among the old buccaneers, in a harder and bloodier age than this one.

“You do well in foul weather, then?” he said, and let none of it show.

“Best off the side of a ship, in the worst of it.”

The sergeant grunted, unconvinced but unwilling to press it with Merrick standing silent at his side. Instead he drifted a few paces down the dock to where Tyrus and Folsom waited, and dropped his voice to something meant for the two of them alone — men he’d sailed with long enough to trust with a worry he’d not have spoken aloud to anyone else. “I don’t suppose Merrick’s going to tell us what’s really going on,” he confided, with a short backward glance at Merrick and his shark-eyed companion. “But you don’t turn the Royal Docks over to a muster this size just to

mind a shipment. We'll board regardless — only keep your wits about you, the pair of you."

"Sounds good to me," Tyrus said cheerfully, and turned to the handsome, dashing figure at his other shoulder. "Folsom — give us a tune to march aboard by."

Folsom struck up something bright and quick on his fife, and to its rhythm the squad filed up the gangplank — twenty Marines in scale mail with shields and longswords and ten crossbowmen in studded leather without shields — thirty strong all told, Tyrus among the Marines and Gouge among the bowmen in his guise as Aristotle — plus their sergeant, and Merrick, who served as their scout-navigator and answered to no one unit alone.

"Keep an eye on that one," the sergeant murmured to Tyrus, with a nod toward Merrick's new companion — low enough to reach no one else, and if it carried as far as Gouge, the very man he meant, he gave not the slightest sign of caring.

"Yes, sir," Tyrus said, and said no more.

They cleared the Royal Docks by half past three, the corsair cutting a clean line out into calm water under a light and favorable wind — a pleasant enough afternoon for what was beginning to feel, more with every passing minute, less like an escort and more like a battalion bound for war.

Merrick had walked Helm Island's paths before, in the years Jamis himself had held the Helm — the barracks, the lighthouses, the roads between them, if never the fortress proper at the island's crown. He drifted near the captain and the two strange newcomers as the voyage wore on, close enough to catch fragments of their talk without seeming to listen at all, and found himself troubled by what little he overheard.

"I'm only going out there to confirm all's well," the captain was saying, more than once, as though repeating it might make it truer.

"You'll want to be prepared regardless," the elf told him, each time, urging a caution the captain plainly hadn't expected to need. Whatever authority the masked young lord carried, he seemed content to let it rest entirely behind the elf's judgment — a strange

enough dynamic that even Merrick, listening from a distance, could feel the captain's unease sharpening as the island drew near.

It came to a head as they closed on the southern beacon, a quarter mile off.

"I'd approach the docks cautiously," the elf said, nodding toward the pale tower ahead. "That lighthouse worries me."

"I see nothing wrong with it," the captain said.

"You've had no signal from it at all. You don't know what's happening there."

The captain looked ready to refuse — and then the masked lord leaned in and spoke, low and level and pitched for the captain alone, too quiet for Merrick to catch a word of. Whatever he said, it struck harder than all the elf's arguing had. Something in the captain's face shifted — worry sliding toward something closer to anger, and then past it into grudging assent — before he turned and called down to the deck. "Sergeant — second squad, into the longboats. Go up to the southern beacon, see what you find."

"Tyrus — get them ready," the sergeant said, and the deck erupted into motion, men hauling longboats to the port rail as the corsair began its slow turn.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Tracks on the Beach

They rowed in under a clear sky and calm water, twenty minutes to shore, the whole squad falling into the kind of stillness that comes over men who suspect, without quite saying so, that something is wrong before they can put a name to it.

Merrick felt it first in the water itself: more sharks cutting the surface near the rocks than he had ever seen in these waters in his life. He kept his longbow near but unstrung, and passed the word quietly down the boat.

"Keep sharp — there's more shark in this water than I've ever seen here. Might be something died upstream. Might not. Either way, mind yourselves."

"Sharks, near Helm Island?" Tyrus said, low. "There's never been sharks near Helm Island."

"I know," Merrick said, and said nothing else, because there was nothing reassuring left to add.

The docks, when they reached them, offered no better comfort. No one came to greet the boats — no harbor master, no watch, nothing but the beacon fire burning uselessly in broad daylight, and a guard tower standing empty above them where a dozen eyes should have marked their approach a mile off.

"Strange, this time of day especially," Tyrus muttered, and turned to organize the landing — shields to the front, crossbowmen behind, the whole squad forming ranks the moment their boots hit the dock. Thirty of them all told — twenty Marines behind the shields and ten crossbowmen at their backs — and to any eye watching from the silent tower they looked all of a kind: uniformed

men falling into practiced order, one hardly to be told from the next. Among them a tall man carried a fife where another might have kept a second blade, humming something low to himself as he checked his kit — that was Folsom, and he drew no more notice than that. Near him a lean, quiet crossbowman took his place in the second rank without a word — Gouge, though to the squad he was only Aristotle, a nameless bowman in a borrowed uniform, as unremarkable as he could make himself. Neither of them stood out in the least. Not yet.

“Should we send someone to the tower first?” Merrick asked.

“We go together,” Tyrus said. “But let’s see what the beach itself tells us before we move.” He glanced at Merrick. “See what you can find.”

Merrick moved along the tideline while the rest held position, reading the sand the way he’d read a hundred beaches before, and it took the better part of ten minutes before he found what he was looking for — a single print, recent, left since the last tide had scoured the shore clean. Bare. Webbed.

He crouched over it a long moment. A bare foot, and the toes webbed between — no gull-track, no seal-haul, nothing that belonged on any beach in the waking world he knew. His father had scratched this same shape for him in the ashes of a cook-fire when he was a boy, and named it, and taught him the question that had never left him since — the shark-men had been beaten out of these waters before Merrick’s grandfather drew breath, but were they truly gone, or only waiting? That it should be here instead, pressed fresh into the sand of Helm Island of all places — the very hinge of the Strait, the stone the whole Principality leaned its weight against — was not simply strange. It meant the old wards had failed, and failed quietly, with no one the wiser. It meant the deep had a road open to the heart of Monmurg’s defenses that no living man had thought to watch. He carried the knowledge back to Tyrus like something he’d sooner have left in the sand, keeping his voice low so the rest of the men wouldn’t catch the weight of it before he’d said it plainly.

"I don't want to alarm the others," he murmured, "but there's a print here I haven't seen on this coast ever."

"Spit it out," Tyrus said, catching the edge in his voice even from a distance.

"Sahaugin," Merrick said. "Shark-folk. I'd swear to it."

"Impossible," Tyrus said flatly. "They haven't set foot on this island in centuries."

"I know it. But there were sharks in that water on the way in, more than I've ever seen here, and now this. This island's held some manner of ward against them for longer than anyone living remembers."

"There are greater magics in this world than either of us is privy to," Tyrus said, though his voice had lost its certainty.

"I'm not fighting them in the water, whatever the truth of it," Merrick said. "Let's get up to the quay."

They climbed the stairs in formation — ten wide, three ranks deep, shields at the front, crossbowmen behind, Tyrus leading, Merrick falling back to keep watch on their rear as they advanced toward the southern guard barracks — a small one, quarters for forty men at most, nothing like the great garrison midway up the island — and the guard tower that rose beyond it.

The windows told the story before the arrows did. Twice, in the space of a hundred paces, someone caught a shape in a window — the tower, the guard barracks — gone the instant anyone looked directly at it, quick and shy and watching all the same.

"Someone's in the guard barracks!" Tyrus shouted, and the words had barely left him before a crossbow bolt struck his shield hard enough to stagger him — fired from an arrow slit in the tower above, from a shooter none of them had seen in time to dodge.

And then the tower's defenders were no longer hiding at all. Figures poured out onto every defensible ledge and doorway, weapons already leveled, and the fight that had been building since the empty docks finally broke wide open.

The volley came first — a hail of bolts from the tower's heights, most of it turned aside by raised shields, but not all of it. Men went

down in that opening flurry, hauled back behind the line before the next bolts could finish them — the first blood paid out of the thirty who had climbed the quay, and far from the last.

Up close, in the chaos of return fire, the defenders resolved into something far stranger than the mercenaries anyone had expected. Red-skinned, broad-jawed, unmistakably inhuman even through the visor slits of armor cut in an unnervingly familiar style.

“Hobgoblins,” Merrick called out, recognition dawning cold and sure. “I’ve heard of troops like these before — used by certain nobles out of Berghof. Gods know what they’re doing this far from home.”

The fight had no shape to it — all noise and blood and snatched shots, bolt answering bolt, the Marines firing from whatever cover the broken ground allowed while the tower’s defenders picked at them from the height. It was Tyrus who broke the deadlock, throwing his shoulder against the tower door alongside two of his men, feeling the bar within crack and give under their combined weight.

The door burst inward on five waiting hobgoblins, one stepping forward in a breastplate to meet the charge himself, and Tyrus went in hard, sword ringing against the creature’s blade in the first pass of what became a long and brutal duel. He took a hard hit, and another, blood running warm down his side, and held his footing anyway.

“Don’t give away more than you have to!” he called back to the men crowding the doorway behind him, even as more bolts rained down from above, putting another Marine out of the fight and wounding two more.

Folsom pressed in near the doorway, flinging a cutting verse at one of the defenders — a mocking sing-song that seemed to catch the thing somewhere behind the eyes, enough to sting and stagger it, not enough to fell it — before the Marines surged past their commander in a wall of shields, taking the remaining hobgoblins room by room.

“Well struck, Aristotle!” Folsom called over the din, snatching a quick, bright phrase on his fife even amid the chaos — a small thing

that steadied the men around him more than it had any right to.

The breastplated one was the strongest of them, and it wanted Tyrus. They hammered at each other in the choked doorway, shield and blade, neither giving ground, until the creature slipped a cut past his guard and opened his side a second time — deep enough to fold a smaller man in half. Tyrus only bared his teeth at it, took the blow, and drove his sword up through the gap at its armpit, in under the breastplate, until the light went out of its eyes. He wrenched the blade free and came up gray and streaming and still on his feet, because going down was not a thing he would let his men watch him do.

Somewhere in the churn of it the sergeant took a blow that laid his shoulder open to the bone. He only laughed at it — “Take my hair, then, if that’s the best you’ve got” — and kept his feet, and kept swinging, giving no sign of how deep the wound truly ran.

Room by room, the Marines cleared the tower’s lower levels, hobgoblins falling back as their numbers thinned. A trapdoor further up refused to budge under Tyrus’s shoulder, and rather than be caught exposed on a ladder, he climbed back down to regroup instead of forcing it.

Reinforcements found them there — more Marines rounding the corner, one pausing beside Folsom with open concern.

“You’re bleeding,” the man said.

“Must be someone else’s,” Folsom said, checking himself over and finding, to his own mild surprise, that he was mostly whole.

Merrick pressed forward alongside Gouge to finish one of the last defenders, landing a hard, decisive blow, and the hobgoblin who’d taken it staggered, badly wounded, before one of his fellows simply dropped his weapon outright at the sight of the reinforcements pouring in.

“We need archers up here — now!” Tyrus called down, and as the last of the defenders broke and ran, he turned to the men nearest him. “This one — the one who surrendered. Do we let him live?”

“Not a chance,” Gouge said, flat and certain, and it was done before anyone could argue otherwise. Tyrus let it happen and said

nothing — but it sat wrong with him all the same, some quiet part of him balking at the killing of a thing that had already dropped its weapon, however little it had earned the scruple. He set the feeling aside; these creatures had come to butcher his island, and mercy was a coin he could not spend today. He noticed, though, that he had wanted to.

The retreat, when it came, was ragged and short-lived — the fleeing hobgoblins picked off as they ran, unable to answer fire while their backs were turned, until the last of them vanished beyond effective range and the tower fell, at last, silent.

They had won it — the tower theirs, the last hobgoblins dead on the floor or fled, the air still but for the groaning of the wounded. And it was only then, with nothing left to hold himself upright for, that the sergeant's legs gave under him. He went down the wall in a slow, almost puzzled slide, one hand pressed to the ruin of his shoulder and the blood welling black between his fingers, as though he had held the wound off at arm's length the whole fight and only now, the work done, let himself feel it.

Tyrus was across the room and on his knees at the man's side before anyone else had so much as turned. They had sailed together more years than either bothered to count, and it was that, far more than the stripe of rank between them, that put the fear naked on his face now — a big man's fear, poorly hidden, at the sight of an old friend folding at last. "Easy," he said, getting an arm in behind him. "I've got you." The sergeant caught his wrist, and found the breath to say what he had already decided. "It's yours now — the squad, the whole of it. I can't hold the line, Tyrus, not with this arm. Take command. They'll follow you regardless, and you know it."

"You'll hand me nothing yet." Tyrus set both hands over the wound and spoke the words that had never yet failed him, and felt the torn flesh begin to close beneath his palms — not clean, not whole, for some wounds ran too deep for his hands to mend entirely, but enough to stop the black welling between the man's fingers and bring a little color back into his face. "There's strength in you yet," he said, quieter. "You'll not lift a shield again today —

but you'll stand, and you'll give the orders, and that's the better half of you regardless. Let me carry the line; you keep us pointed the right way." The sergeant got his feet back under him, grayed and slow but upright, and if he could no longer hold a place in the line he could still hold the squad together — and that, for the moment, was the more useful thing.

Victory wasn't fully theirs even then. Bolts still fell from the guard barracks nearby, killing three of the Marines before anyone could drag the bodies clear, and for a long, grinding stretch the fight settled into a stalemate — neither side willing to break from cover. Seventeen of the twenty Marines still stood, and with the ten crossbowmen the unit numbered twenty-seven of the thirty that had come ashore, most of them wounded, the crossbowmen holding the tower's upper floor without daring to show themselves at the windows.

"Is he dead," Tyrus asked, of the one hobgoblin they'd managed to bring down without killing outright, "or worth keeping?"

This one had been no common trooper. The fine bracers still on his arms and the Common on his tongue marked him for what he was — the leader of them, or near enough — and unlike the shooters who had rained bolts down from the tower's heights, he had never climbed to the upper galleries at all. He had run the defense from the ground floor, and it was on the ground they had taken him. No one among them spoke Hobgoblin, but the creature spoke Common well enough that it scarcely mattered, and the sergeant took him into custody on the chance he might prove useful, while the rest of the wounded defenders were put down without ceremony.

"There are still men on that wall," Gouge said, eyes already climbing the tower walls. "I want them dealt with directly."

"Now, then," Tyrus agreed, and sketched it out quickly — himself hammering on the main door to draw every eye, Gouge and Folsom scaling opposite flanks of the wall while the defenders' attention was fixed elsewhere.

"I'll go up quiet," Gouge said. "I don't fancy a volley of arrows

the moment my head clears the parapet."

Both of them made the climb in near-perfect silence, and Gouge risked a careful look over the edge rather than simply vaulting the wall — two hobgoblins standing there, swords drawn, listening hard to the racket Tyrus was making below.

"Surrender," Gouge called, in plain Common. "We've taken the tower."

"We surrender," one answered, broken but clear enough, and threw down his sword.

Gouge came over the wall anyway and struck without hesitation, driving a wound deep into the creature before it could think better of its own surrender — a hard blow, but not enough to drop it. The second hobgoblin drew a dagger despite its companion's fate and lunged; Gouge caught the worst of it on his buckler, took a shallow cut for his trouble, and put that one down with a return stroke. Then he turned back to the first, still reeling, and finished what he'd started with a short thrust from behind — the quiet, economical sort of killing he did best.

"That's the pair of them," Gouge said, with the grim satisfaction of a man closing accounts.

They found the hatch at the tower's summit and forced it open, only to discover the brazier that should have stood ready there was simply gone — no signal fire, nothing to warn the approaching corsair of what waited on the island below.

"We need to signal that ship, somehow," Gouge said. "A flaming arrow, anything that'll carry."

"Longbow's got the range for it," Gouge decided, weighing it against the heavier crossbows. "Two hundred feet further, easily."

"Let's put color to it," Folsom said, already digging through his entertainer's kit for anything that might burn bright and strange enough to read as a true signal rather than an ordinary fire. He found phosphorus and a twist of scraped copper filings among his oddments, soaked a strip of cloth in a measure of Gouge's own harsh liquor for good measure, and wrapped the whole improvised mess around an arrow's tip.

"Up and out," Gouge said, and handed the finished arrow across to Merrick — the only one who could make that shot. He nodded toward the distant ship rather than the water below. "Not down." Merrick set it to the string, drew to the ear, and loosed.

The arrow arced high, trailing a smoky, unmistakably blue flame across the evening sky, and a flare answered from the corsair a moment later — acknowledgment, at least, that someone aboard had seen it.

"Good work," Gouge said to Folsom, watching the flare fade.

But the ship sailed on toward the docks regardless, and a squad of Marines began disembarking even as they watched — and among them, unmistakable even at this distance in the last low light of evening, the glint of a silvered mask.

"Well, that tears it," Gouge said grimly, "there's the man we're meant to keep alive, walking straight into the worst of it."

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Corsair

For Paul and Jude, the crossing to the Helm wore an altogether different face. By three in the afternoon they had their gear together and were making for the Royal Docks, where the corsair sat low in the water under the weight of two hundred fifty Marines and their equipment. Paul had never crossed to Helm Island before, and he found himself measuring the distance with his eyes as they walked — a speck of rock and lighthouse fire sitting in the middle of the Monmurgian Straits, between the peninsula and the looming bulk of Jetsom Island, well clear of the cold northern waters where the turtle dragons were said to nest.

“Three to five miles, at most,” Jude said, following his gaze. “Not the half-day you were expecting.”

Around them, the dock swarmed with activity — scale-armored Marines hauling crates of bolts and provisions up the gangway, sergeants barking men into rough columns, the whole scene lit gold and hazy in the late-afternoon sun. Two hundred fifty men. Not an invasion, Paul thought, studying the orderly chaos of it, but not a courtesy visit either.

They were led up to the sterncastle, where the ship’s captain stood waiting — a weathered man of perhaps five-and-thirty, breastplate marking his rank, the kind of face that had long since stopped being impressed by lords and their nephews. Jude fell in a half-step behind and to the side, a wide-brimmed hat shading a face no one in Monmurg would mistake for human at ten paces, a borrowed quill tucked behind one ear to suggest scribe rather than blade.

"I'm Captain Richard," the man said, looking Paul over. "I take it you're the nephew of Prince Jeon."

"I am," Paul said.

"I can tell by the mask." The captain's eyes flicked briefly to Jude, then back. "Mind telling me why we've the pleasure of your company today?"

"I'm here as my uncle's personal representative, to see what's happening on the island."

The captain's mouth thinned. "I'd suggest you stay out of the way. You're welcome on the upper deck with me, and you may ask what questions you like — but understand, I command this expedition."

Paul held the man's gaze through the mask a moment, weighing his answer, then let his voice come rough and honest rather than smooth. "Jeon has granted me authority to take charge should the need arise, and I'd rather not have cause to use it. I've no wish to make that necessary. I hope we can remain on good terms."

The captain's shoulders eased — relief, Paul thought, at not having drawn some smarmier courtier for this crossing. "Very well. You'll find I'm quite professional, when it comes to command."

"We'll see," Paul said, and the captain almost smiled.

By the time the sun had swung well past its peak and begun its slow fall toward the water, the last of the Marines had boarded — thirty-man units in scale mail and shield, spears bristling, crossbowmen mixed among them, light-armored but carrying the heavier bows. The corsair pushed off from the dock at half past three, three masts catching the wind, and began its run across the straits — fast, lean, built for boarding actions rather than siege, three ballistae mounted along her deck in place of the catapults a larger warship might carry. Monmurg's corsairs hunted in packs, Paul had heard it said — wolves against the lions of the Keoland fleet, swift enough to flee what they couldn't overwhelm.

Standing near the captain on the sterncastle, alongside the first mate at the wheel and one of the Marine officers, Paul let a good half hour pass before he began asking questions in earnest.

"I've never been to the Helm," he admitted. "What fortifications does it have?"

"The keep itself sits on the island's highest point," Captain Richard said. "Three lighthouses — east, west, and south; we'll raise the southern one first. The quays sit behind the Helm, on the leeward side. Only the one true fort, though there are guard towers by most of the lighthouses, and a large barracks midway up the island, behind a wooden palisade, below the Helm proper."

"And signals to Monmurg — do they come from the keep itself, or from outside it?"

"Every lighthouse can signal after a fashion — change the color of the light, red for an attack. From here we can't see the eastern light, so it can't reach Monmurg direct, but the west could reach the Helm, and the east could relay word on to Flotsom if needed. Direct word to the city, though — that comes from the great tower at the Helm. Several braziers up there, each meaning something different."

Paul turned that over as the ship cut through the chop, the wind carrying the mingled smell of salt and pitch and the low murmur of a full battalion settling into the short crossing. Whatever the captain had or hadn't been told, this was no supply run — a battalion this size didn't sail for a courtesy call.

Jude knew the answer to his own question — Jamis had given it to him plainly enough, in private, before ever they sailed. He asked it anyway, watching the captain's face as he did: partly to keep the man a little off his balance, and partly to learn whether Jamis had let him in on the same suspicions, or left him to make this crossing blind.

"Why so many men," he asked, "if this is meant to be routine?"

"We're confirming Lord Fairwind's had no trouble," Captain Richard said, and the flatness of it told Jude the man believed that answer about as much as he himself did.

"You're not exactly subtle about it, if that's all this is."

"We're making contact with Lord Fairwind," the captain repeated, unmoved. "I take it that's your errand as well?"

"It is."

They fell into an uneasy rhythm after that — Jude pressing for details of the Helm's defenses, the quay's fortifications, the disposition of the garrison, and the captain answering each readily enough, though every time he did his gaze flicked to Paul, plainly weighing whether the elf's impertinence was a thing he was obliged to suffer. Paul gave him nothing to read either way, and so Captain Richard went on answering. When Jude suggested a few squads be kept ready to intercept trouble at the hard points, the captain's eyes narrowed behind his weathered calm.

"Who is this man beside you," the captain said to Paul, his patience finally worn through, "and why am I to suffer his advice?"

"He is an advisor," Paul said.

The captain turned to Jude, his jaw tightening at the curt non-answer — plainly affronted to be handed so little after asking so plainly, and just as plainly unwilling to let a masked lord's man see the slight land. "I'll do my job, sir — but understand, I've no intention of assaulting anything."

"I didn't say assault," Jude said. "I said be ready — should there be a catastrophic problem."

"You handle your business," the captain said. "I'll handle mine."

An hour and a half into the crossing, Helm Island rose out of the haze on the western horizon — a hunched grey shoulder of rock heaved up out of the strait, steeper and more solitary than Paul had pictured it, its crown already lost to the failing light where the keep stood on the island's highest point. The ship swung south along its flank, near enough now that the land gave up its detail: black cliffs worn hollow at the waterline, a scrub of wind-bent green above the tide, and the pale thread of a road switchbacking up through it toward the heights. The southern lighthouse stood a quarter mile off, pale stone against the darkening sky with its fire a steady orange stain at the crown, and beside it a wooden watchtower — forty feet of timber, clearly built to cover any landing at the small dock bay below.

The silent beacon only hardened Jude's resolve, and he pressed

the point once more, past the last of the captain's patience. "I'd have you approach those docks cautiously," he said, with a nod at the pale tower ahead. "The southern beacon should have hailed us by now, and hasn't — not once since we cleared the harbor. You don't know what's waiting beneath that light any better than I do. Send men ahead to be sure of it, before you commit the whole ship."

"I see nothing wrong with it," Captain Richard said, the words clipped with warning now.

Paul spoke before the refusal could harden — quietly, in the tone he kept for the rare occasions he meant to be obeyed. "Do as he asks, Captain. My uncle sent me to look at this island with open eyes, and I'll not have him told afterward that his corsair sailed a battalion blind into a silent harbor because her captain was certain all was well. A quarter hour's precaution costs us nothing. Being wrong might cost us the ship."

The name of Prince Jeon did what Jude's caution alone could not. Something in the captain's face shifted — worry sliding toward something closer to anger, and then past it into grudging assent.

It was a small thing, and it unsettled Paul more than it should have. He had spent a lifetime being looked past — the scarred nephew, the mask at the edge of the room, the inconvenience the family kept behind its walls and out of its portraits. Yet here was a hard, capable man three times his better in every way a ship could measure, setting his own judgment aside because Paul had spoken his uncle's name and let the mask do the rest. That was what the authority was, he understood now — not a thing he wielded so much as a thing other men agreed to see. A prince's blood outweighed a captain's certainty, and did so no matter what ruin the mask hid — perhaps the more surely for the not-knowing, since a frightened man will fill a blank with something worse than the truth. They would swallow their own good sense for a title and be grateful for the excuse. It was useful. He was not certain he liked knowing it, about them or about himself.

The captain turned and called down to the deck.

"Get the men ready! Second squad, stand ready!"

"Better to apologize afterward than end up as fish food," Jude murmured at Paul's shoulder.

"I'd rather make a proud man kneel and kiss the ring than that," Paul agreed, and watched the second squad assemble on the open deck below — thirty men in all, ten crossbowmen mixed among them, every one of them moving with the crisp discipline of soldiers who had drilled this a hundred times.

Beside him, Jude let his own eyes drift across the ranks, cataloguing faces out of old habit, and stopped on one — a man in studded leather among the crossbowmen, wearing his disguise as easily as a second skin. Gouge. Jude gave no sign of recognition, no nod, nothing that might mark the man to anyone watching, but he took careful note of who stood at Gouge's shoulder on either side, filing the faces away for later.

Thirteen minutes later, Captain Richard gave the order, and longboats dropped away from the corsair's sides, fifteen men to a boat, rowing hard for the southern lighthouse while the ship itself continued its slow curve around the island's edge.

"He's taking proper precautions," Paul murmured, watching the boats pull away.

"More than that," Jude said. "The southern beacon lies nearest the mainland of anything on this rock — it's the one light out here that could throw word back toward Monmurg, or pass it up the chain. Take it and hold it, and we keep a way to warn the city, whatever waits ashore. Leave it, and whoever holds the Helm decides what Monmurg is let to believe."

Rounding the island's southern face, they came upon a natural breakwater — jagged black stone jutting from the water, treacherous to sail but sheltering the leeward side, where the quays and the harbor's low stone buildings climbed the slope in weathered tiers and the water lay flat and calm in the shadow of the rocks. From here the whole anchorage opened before them: the long curve of the mole, the storehouses ranked along the waterfront, the switchback road toiling up toward the palisade and the barracks set midway on the height, and above all of it the keep on the island's crown, black

now against a sky gone to embers.

Paul scanned it for any sign of life and found none. No ships at anchor. No colors on the poles. No watch on the mole, no dockhands on the quay, no smoke anywhere but the cold, kept fires of the lighthouses. A working harbor at dusk should have been loud with the end of its day — and this one lay as quiet and unpeopled as a drawing of itself.

"Is that usual?" he asked, though he had already read the answer in it.

"It is not," the captain said, and his voice had gone very still.

They held their slow circuit past the eastern lighthouse — another stone tower, another bridge to the rock, no proper dock but mud flats where a determined man might still wade ashore — before the captain brought her about toward the main harbor, choosing the longer, more open water over the straight run in, as though the near path had grown teeth while his back was turned.

"I'd look for patrols by this hour," he said, low. "A shift on the wall, a boat on the water, a man to curse us for arriving at supper. There's nothing." He did not say the rest of it, and did not need to.

Paul watched the captain arrive where he had already arrived himself — the two of them reading the same silence and drawing the same hard line beneath it. This was no slack watch, no garrison gone lazy in a soft posting; a place did not fall this still by accident. It had been emptied, or it had been turned, and whoever had done the work had left the lighthouse fires burning so the change would not show until a ship sat in the harbor's mouth with nowhere left to run. Someone had dressed the island to look asleep. Men had done this, the captain plainly reckoned — a rival's soldiers, a bought garrison, treachery with a human hand behind it — and Paul reckoned no differently. Men had done it, and men would be waiting; and there, being reasonable men themselves, the two of them stopped.

Back toward the southern point, where they'd put the second squad ashore, a spark climbed suddenly into the darkening sky — an arrow, by the arc of it, trailing a smoky, unmistakable blue flame no ordinary fire-arrow ever burned. It hung a moment against the

cloud, and fell.

Jude marked it first, the captain a breath behind him. "That's the second squad," Richard said. "They hold the tower, then — and that's no fire a man lights for nothing. They're warning us."

"Then they've found ashore what we feared they might," Paul said, low.

The captain gave the order to answer it — a flare sent up from the corsair's own deck, seen and acknowledged and nothing more — but he did not check the ship's course for it, and neither Paul nor Jude pressed him to. The southern beacon lay behind them now; Fairwind's silent harbor lay ahead, and they were committed to it either way. All three of them understood the blue fire for a warning. Not one of them yet grasped how much of one.

"What would you have me do?" the captain asked — and the asking of it, from a man who an hour past had bridled at being advised at all, told Paul more than the empty harbor had.

Jude answered before Paul could, mild and unhurried, pitched for the three of them and no further. "Nothing that shows. We came to call on Lord Fairwind and take his report, so we call on him — put us ashore as though we suspect nothing, let the men look like an escort and not a boarding party, and we learn what's here before it learns we've guessed at it. Fort up on the ship now, or come about and run, and we tell whoever's watching precisely what we know. I'd sooner they went on thinking us fools a while longer."

Paul saw the wisdom of it at once, and the cost of it. To go ashore was the greater danger to his own skin and the lesser to the mission; to stay aboard was the reverse. "We go ashore," he said. "Quietly, and in no great hurry — as though the harbor master were only slow to his post."

"Agreed," the captain said, steadier now that there was a plan to hold to. "The Helm has to be secured either way. You take a squad down and go looking for the man; if he's not to be found, we search the barracks. And we give Lord Fairwind no cause for alarm — not until the ground itself makes us."

The corsair eased into her berth along the empty quay, her fend-

ers groaning against stone that no hand reached down to help her to. Up close the harbor was worse than it had looked from the water — two stone stairways climbing from the waterfront toward the higher ground, and the length of the quay wall set with squat battlements, hard points and archers' posts, firing slots cut to rake anyone crossing the open ground below. Every one of them stood silent, shuttered, unmanned; and thirty feet above, a second tier of the same sat just as still, the whole waterfront arranged for a defense that no one had come to make.

A Marine sergeant moved among his men, readying them — crossbowmen falling in behind the spearmen, shields checked, everyone scanning both port and starboard at once.

"Third Squad," the sergeant called, "this is us."

Ladders dropped along the ship's side. Paul counted his detachment as they assembled — ten men in scale mail, ten more with crossbows slung — and made his way down after them, careful, even now, not to tread on the captain's authority more than he already had. Jude came down at his heels almost as an afterthought — attaching himself to the venture the way he attached himself to most things, without asking leave and without being refused it.

The sergeant saluted as Paul's boots hit the dock.

"At ease," Paul said. "Fall in as you see fit. We're here for the harbor master, nothing louder than that." He glanced at the crossbows, still slung and unloaded, waiting on the order that would make them dangerous. "Keep them so — no loading until you mean to use them. I'd not have us look like trouble before we've met any."

Jude drew the sergeant aside a moment, voice pitched low. "A word on my signals, if it comes to that. If I say 'flee', that means find cover and kill whatever's coming at you, however you're able. If I say 'get out of here', that means leave — truly leave — because I may not be able to handle what's happening myself."

"Understood, sir," the sergeant said, repeating it back with the flat precision of a man who took orders seriously. "Flee means hide and fight. Get out means go."

"Exactly that. Let's move."

They set off down the length of the pier, Marines flanking, Paul walking beside them rather than before or behind, Jude a silent shape at his shoulder with one hand resting near a wand he had not yet drawn.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Empty Harbor

The silence was the worst of it. No harbor master waiting at the dock's end. No patrols on the stairs leading up. Nothing but the slap of water against pilings and the measured tread of Marines' boots on old stone, sixty feet of empty pier between them and the stairwell rising toward the island's interior.

Paul fell in beside the sergeant, keeping his voice low. "I don't mean to step on your command — but I'd have the crossbows loaded and ready now, if it were mine to order. This kind of quiet doesn't sit right with me."

"Nor me, my lord," the sergeant admitted, and raised his voice for the column. "Crossbows up!"

Bolts clicked into place along the line.

"A shield wall wouldn't go amiss, either," Paul said, low.

"Keep them moving for now, my lord," the sergeant answered, not unkindly. "A wall does us no good until we know where the blow falls — but ready's another matter." He lifted his chin at the column. "Stay ready, all of you."

Jude drew his wand and held it loose at his side, eyes tracking the shadowed hard points above — squat works of fitted stone and weathered timber, notched into the rock on either hand — as the line advanced, weapons loaded now, toward the waiting stairs.

The first volley came without warning — bolts hissing down from overhead, loosed through firing slots cut where fitted stone gave way to timber. The front rank took the worst of it on raised shields, iron points skittering off scale mail and burying themselves harmlessly in wood and leather. A shout rang out from somewhere

above, and figures began pouring down from the works to meet them at the base of the stairs — a full unit, moving with grim, unhurried purpose.

What followed was close and ugly. The two lines met at the foot of the stairs and ground together, the Marines locking their shields into a bristling wall and pushing up step by contested step while the hard points above rained bolts down the whole way. A crossbowman two places from Paul took a quarrel through the shoulder and dropped to one knee with a grunt; the man beside him hauled him upright by the harness without breaking stride, and the wall closed over the gap and came on. Iron rang on iron, boots scraped wet stone, and the sergeant's voice carried flat and relentless above all of it — "Push forward — shield wall, advance!" The defenders gave ground grudgingly, trading hurt for hurt, contesting every foot of the climb.

It was partway up the stairs that Jude checked mid-stride, his gaze snagging on the men holding the high ground.

"These aren't Fairwind's soldiers," he said, low and urgent. "Look at their faces."

Paul looked — really looked — and it struck him a half-beat before his mind could name it. Not men at all. Hobgoblins, red-skinned and unmistakably inhuman up close, armored in the exact cut of a Monmurgian Marine's kit, down to the buckles.

"Either his garrison's been replaced outright," Paul said flatly, "or the whole island's compromised."

"Either way, we cut through them," Jude said. "No surrender to expect from this lot — not like men who might yield."

The Marines pressed on, the sergeant driving the advance with a steadiness Paul was grateful for, and the wall climbed another few feet of stone before the resistance stiffened at one of the upper works — a knot of hobgoblins packed behind the timber breastwork, loosing bolt after bolt into the Marines below. Jude marked them, leveled his wand, and let the fire go.

Flame tore up and out in a rolling sheet, catching the dry timber of the breastwork as readily as the creatures crowded behind it.

Their screams were nothing like a man's — high, panicked, nothing a human throat could shape — and one of them did not clear the blaze in time, swallowed whole as the stone blackened and the timbers above it began to smoke and buckle.

"Keep moving with them," Paul called, holding to the second rank among the crossbowmen rather than the shield line, as the burning position collapsed behind the advancing shield wall.

The fighting ground on, the defenders thinning position by position as the fire spread from one nest to the next and the Marines cleared each in patient, methodical turn — shields up, bolts answered with bolts. At last only a pair of hobgoblins held out at the base of the stairs, fighting with the flat stubbornness of the doomed.

"I'll finish this," Jude said, and put a fire bolt through the nearer one; the last hobgoblin fell to the Marines' bolts a breath after, and the stairs went quiet.

It was only then, in the ringing quiet after, that Paul became aware of something worse unfolding behind them — shouts and the clash of steel carrying from the direction of the docked ship, and beyond it, along the shoreline, motion in the water that had nothing to do with any hobgoblin.

"Sea creatures swarming a hull," the sergeant said, and his weathered face had gone tight. "That's every sailor's nightmare, my lord, and it'll break even good men. If that's what's on the water, the crew won't hold long."

Paul was already moving. "Then we don't leave them to it."

Jude caught his arm. Everything in him called it folly — to run back toward the water and whatever was rising out of it, away from the high ground they'd bled for. Two hundred Marines aboard could not save that ship; two more would only drown with it. But he had come to the Helm to keep this one man alive, and a single look told him there would be no keeping Paul here: the desperation was plain on him, the fixed set of a man who had already decided and would go alone if he had to. A man went alone into that and died — and Jude's whole charge died with him. So it was against every cold instinct he owned, and knowing better

the whole way, that he let go of the arm and made ready to run.

“Sergeant — secure the landing!” Paul shouted back, gesturing at the cleared ground around the dock, and the sergeant rallied what was left of the squad to hold it. Paul brought his crossbow up — his weapon by preference, the one that let him strike from a distance and keep out of reach — the short sword loose at his hip for the close work he could not always avoid. Then the two of them broke away, sprinting back across the open ground toward the ship, Jude a half-step behind with a spell already half-shaped on his lips, following the one man he could not lose into a fight he was certain they could not win — and trusting Paul to see it too, before the sea made the choice for them.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Out of the Deep

Jude and Paul were still fifty yards from the water line when the first of them broke the surface — a shape man-like in outline and nothing like a man in any part of it, a wide, lipless mouth crowded with teeth, eyes flat and black and empty of warmth.

“Ready yourself,” Jude snapped, drawing up short, wand already rising.

A second one surfaced nearby, and beyond it, deeper down the dock, more still — dozens, climbing out of the water and righting themselves on webbed feet, cutting off the straight path to the ship entirely. Past them, barely visible through the chaos, the corsair itself was locked in close, desperate melee, her crew badly outnumbered.

It was Paul who did the terrible arithmetic this time, standing there with the crossbow up and nowhere worth pointing it. Two hundred feet to the ship, and a hundred of that already a churning wall of them, more hauling out of the black water with every breath. No fire could burn a lane through that many; no blade could cut one. He had run the whole way to reach the crew, and the sea had shut the door before he arrived — and somewhere beneath the dread and the hammering of his own blood, the thing Jude had known the moment they turned back reached him too. They could not save that ship. They could only die in front of it.

“Back,” Paul said, and the word cost him more than the running had. “We fall back. We can’t reach them, and I’ll not spend us for nothing.”

Jude was already at his shoulder, wand up, and gave no sign that

he had spent the last minute waiting for Paul to arrive there himself. "She's two hundred Marines of her own," he said, not unkindly. "Not undefended, even overrun. It's our own we can't lose now — they may be all that's left of us before this is done." *If anything closes on Paul, I put it down*, he told himself, and meant it.

Paul gave ground, crossbow up and readied rather than fired, Jude a half-step off his shoulder — and one of the shark-men broke from the pack and charged, a barbed spear leveled.

"Sahaugin," Paul said, recognizing it even through the dread. "They can't hold ashore for long — the farther we pull them from the water, the weaker they come. Uphill, away from the sea, and we don't stop to trade a blow we don't have to."

"The whole island counts as coastline, more or less," Jude said, and loosed a short, hard blast from his wand at the charging creature — enough to stagger it and buy them a step back, no more.

It came on regardless, spear and claw both, and Paul felt the barbed point catch him — once in the ribs, hot and sharp, and again as a webbed claw raked across his chest, the worst of it turned aside by the leather beneath. He staggered but kept his feet, and as the creature hauled its spear back for the killing thrust he stepped in under its reach and drove his sword up beneath its jaw to the hilt. The sahaugin convulsed, the spear slipping from its webbed hands, and Paul wrenched the blade free and let the thing fold at his boots. One down — but Paul knew it bought only a moment. Already he could feel the first drag of weariness in his arms and lungs, the leaden heaviness that would only deepen the longer the fight wore on; let it run too long, and exhaustion alone might finish what blade and claw had not.

"We're not finishing this — we're leaving it," Jude said through his teeth, backing another step. "One good burst to break them off us, and then we run. Together."

"Mind the two of us," Paul managed.

"Already accounted for." Jude drew the spell's shape tight around them both — an evoker's old trick of sparing chosen allies from his own fire — and let it go.

The blast rolled out over the cluster of sahaugin in a wash of white and gold, and this close, even sheltered from the worst of it, Paul felt the heat of it on his face. Two of the creatures never had the chance to scream. A third staggered, blackened and reeling, and the rest scattered, badly burned, barely still standing — and for a breath the way inland stood open.

"I've almost nothing left," Jude admitted, low, "and I'll not explain to Lord Jamis how I let them overrun us. Go — now, while they're reeling."

Paul broke away, moving fast and low, opening ground between himself and the nearest of them. One of the burned sahaugin lunged after Jude but couldn't close the gap after its own dash; Jude, giving ground as he went, put a fire bolt through its throat as it scrambled up onto the dock, and it dropped without a sound.

The last one on its feet lunged after them anyway, scorched black down one side, driven by the blind fury of a thing with nothing left to lose. Jude put it down where it stood rather than turn his back on it, then broke off at a hard sprint, Paul a stride behind.

"We consolidate with the unit," Jude said, breathing hard, scanning the water for any further shapes rising out of the dark. "Push toward the citadel together — no more splitting up."

They ran.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Nothing to Be Done

Up in the guard tower there was nothing to be done about any of it but carry word to the sergeant — the signal they'd sent, the ship still standing on for the docks, all of it.

The sergeant took the news with the flat calm of a man who had already run out of good options. "You're wounded," he said to Tyrus, unconvinced by any protest to the contrary.

"I'm fit to move, sergeant." Tyrus laid his own hands over the worst of his wounds, murmuring the words that had never failed him yet, and felt the ache close over into nothing more than memory. "Good as new."

"You can't march out there with archers still active in that other building," the sergeant said.

"That'd be my recommendation regardless — unless you've a better one. Our orders were to take the garrison. If Paul Revere dies out there before we can reach him, does that count as our mission failed outright?"

"You tell me," the sergeant said. "We're near a mile from those docks. Twenty minutes at a dead run, even without a fight in our way — and that corsair still carries the better part of two hundred more besides. There's nothing more we can do from here but rest, and watch."

So they watched — helpless, from a distance too great to close — as Paul's detachment marched the length of the pier toward the quay, and soldiers atop the walls opened fire on them in turn, the whole of it playing out across the bay as though it were happening to strangers, in another life entirely.

"How would we even get across to them?" Gouge asked.

"Far side of the bay, at the main harbor," the sergeant said. "If we're to reach them — or take the garrison we were sent for — it's the same road: across the southern bridge onto the island proper, then a good two miles inland to the garrison itself. And if the bridge is held — hobgoblins at both ends of it — we're as pinned to this rock as they are to that quay."

A flare of magical flame bloomed suddenly among the distant hobgoblin positions.

"Someone on our side is buying them time," Tyrus said, low.

And then the water itself began to move. All along the shoreline pale, man-shaped things were hauling themselves up out of the sea by the dozens — hundreds, then more than any of them could count — pouring over the docks and breaking against the corsair where she lay against the quay.

"That's sahaugin," Merrick said, the words wrenched out of him. "Hundreds of them. On the Helm. I can't credit it — this hasn't happened in centuries."

They could do nothing but watch it happen. The corsair — the better part of two hundred Marines the sergeant had been counting on — was swarmed from waterline to rail, her crew fighting a hopeless, crowded melee on a deck that was no longer their own, and one by one the shapes dragged them down and over the side into the dark. Before long the ship herself seemed to settle under the weight of them, the way a carcass goes under when the ants find it, until nothing showed above the rail but movement.

For a moment no one found anything to say. Then it came out of them in pieces, none of them quite believing the others or themselves.

"Two hundred men," the sergeant said, hoarse. "I crossed with half of them. I know their names."

"A corsair full of fighting men, taken off her own deck." Tyrus had gone still against the parapet, all his big-man's ease drained out of him. "By hands that came up out of the sea. I'd have called any man who told me such a thing a liar or a drunk."

Folsom had no tune in him now, and for once no jest either — only a stricken quiet, his face the color of ash, the sea closing over the last of her before his eyes.

Merrick watched longest of all, and when he spoke it came lower than the rest, something old and unhealed working behind his eyes. "The shark-men took my father," he said. "Out in the deep, years back, where a few of them still lurk beyond the old wards. My whole life I've watched the water for them and told myself it was a dead man's fear handed down to his son." He did not look away from the ship. "And here they are, dragging a battalion under off the Helm itself."

Paul's shore party fared better only because it was smaller and already moving. Caught between the bolts still falling from the wall above and the sea heaving up behind, the little knot of Marines fought clear at last and turned inland, taking the quay stairs at a dead run — the glint of the silvered mask among them one moment, gone over the lip of the quay the next, driven off the water and up toward whatever shelter the high ground still held.

It was Gouge who broke them out of it. He had seen the ship go down with the rest, and the fury in him was plain — but it was a working fury, the kind that hunts for a throat to put a knife into, not the kind that sits down in the dark to mourn.

"Every man on that deck died buying us time tonight," he said, low, "and I'll not stand here and let it go to waste. We came with a job; it's still a job. We find Revero, we take the garrison, and we make somebody answer for what's happening in that water. Grieve after. Move now — or sit here and go under with the rest of them."

"Can they even reach us up here, away from the water?" Tyrus asked.

Merrick called on everything he'd ever learned of the old enemy, and found some small comfort in the answer. "They can hold ashore near four hours before they'd suffocate for want of the sea — but they hate the dry, and they'd not come this far inland unless they were driven to it."

"Then we keep the high ground," Tyrus said, "and well clear of

any coast." He turned, quiet and hard. "And if it comes to a choice, Paul Revere comes first — above any of us. That's the mission. The elf can see to himself."

Merrick nodded, but he was not done. "There's more here than the mission, and I'll say it plain. The wards that kept the shark-men off this coast for a hundred years did not just fail on their own tonight — something brought them down, and did it quietly. This isn't only the sahaugin. Someone worked magic against the Helm, and unless we gather our strength and move as one—"

"Are you men drunk?" the sergeant broke in, skeptical of the whole account.

"Not yet," Gouge said, "though the day's given me every reason to be."

"You're speaking nonsense."

Merrick only nodded down at the water. "Then there's your nonsense, sergeant — going down with our own people in it. Believe your eyes, if you'll not believe me."

"Fewer fish-men, and firmer ground under us," Tyrus muttered, taking up his pacing again along the parapet. "That's all I ask of tonight."

They rested where they stood, tending wounds as best the hour allowed — Folsom moving quietly among the worst of them, a low and steady tune under his breath and the patient field-medicine, easing eight men who'd taken more than their share, until only two remained too badly hurt to march, one of them barely conscious.

"Do we leave them," Gouge asked no one in particular, low enough that only Merrick caught it, "or do we find some other use for men who can't walk?" Merrick went and checked on both of them himself before anyone decided, unwilling to leave the question to guesswork alone.

"You know this island as well as anyone breathing," Gouge said, following Merrick. He had no mind to sit pinned in the tower nursing the wounded while the night wore on and the sahaugin owned the water below — if there was a safe way off this hill after dark, the ranger would be the one to know it. "Can we move after dark,

staying off the beaches?"

"The hobgoblins at the guard barracks likely see well enough in the dark to trouble us at close range," Merrick said, "but not at any real distance, and moonlight weakens that regardless. We should be able to move, if we're careful. This stretch of island should already be swept clear of anything worse than birds and a few tree-dwellers — nothing left alive here that hasn't already been hunted off or killed."

"Then we move tonight," Gouge said.

The sergeant, when they laid the plan before him, was cautious to the point of reluctance. "I'd rather not send men out blind into whatever's still out there. But Merrick knows this ground better than any of us — send him ahead, under cover of dark, to learn whether the garrison still holds."

"I'll go with him," Gouge said at once.

"We both move well enough in the dark," Merrick said. "You watch my back; I'll find the way."

"If you reach the garrison and find it clear," the sergeant asked, "how will you signal us?"

Merrick checked his explorer's pack and found what he needed. "A tinderbox. I can light an arrow — enough for you to see from a distance, even if it gives away exactly where we are for a moment."

"That'll mark your position to the enemy as well as to us."

"If we're low against the wall by then, I doubt they'd risk exposing themselves just to answer it," Merrick said. "We'll work out the exact signal as we go." He looked to the sky a moment, reading the light. "And I'd not set foot outside these walls for an hour yet. Their dark-sight won't carry to us at any real distance — but a bright moon will, and I'd sooner make the crossing under a dim one. An hour buys us that, and a careless enemy besides: men stay sharp just after a fight, not so much an hour on."

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Garrison

Paul and Jude found the sergeant standing over one of the fallen hobgoblins, a boot planted on its ribs to be certain of it. Up close the thing was worse than it had been in the heat of the fight: a heavy, sloping brow over eyes gone flat and yellow in death, a jaw crowded with more teeth than the mouth could rightly hold, grey-red hide stretched over lean muscle. And buckled onto that inhuman frame, armor and weapons cut so near to a Monmurg Marine's own that they could only have come from the same craftsmen's hands — someone had armed these things deliberately, fitted them to pass, at a distance, for the very men they had been sent to butcher. Paul looked at that longer than at the corpse.

"Things wearing our men's kit," Jude said flatly, nudging the body with his own boot. "Someone armed them to pass for us. We push for the citadel."

"We push for the citadel," Paul repeated, weighing it.

The sergeant's face, when they asked him for an assessment, told them everything before he spoke a word. He pointed up the hill, where a column of some fifty men was already descending toward them at a steady march.

"My lord's wounded," the sergeant said, looking hard at Paul. "We need him safe."

"How far off, if they meant to rush us?" Paul asked.

"Not yet close enough to matter — but close enough."

"We're outnumbered outright," Jude said. "Is there any hope of joining the second squad?"

"Our best chance," the sergeant said, "is taking this squad and

fighting clear to the ship." He hesitated, reconsidering even as he said it. "No — we need cover, and quickly."

"Where?" Paul asked.

"The garrison." The sergeant pointed to a walled compound perhaps a thousand feet distant. "Defensible walls, at least."

"Then that's where we go," Paul said. "There may be men there worth freeing."

"Crossbows ready regardless," Jude added. "There could be enemies waiting there too."

They moved at a hard, disciplined pace rather than a rout — Jude insisting on the distinction even as they went — Marines in formation, shields still up, crossbowmen watching every shadow. Overhead, the column from the Helm continued its own march down toward the docks, ignoring them entirely, bound for whatever fresh disaster was still unfolding at the harbor.

"They're not even looking our way," Jude observed. "Good. Let them stay busy elsewhere." He glanced at Paul, weighing the wound still seeping under his torn leathers. "I can't heal you, but I can make you hard to find." He spoke the words of the spell, and Paul felt the world's attention slide away from him, his own hands fading from sight even as he watched. "Don't fight unless you're truly about to go down — it'll break the moment you do."

"Understood," Paul said, and fell in among the troops, unseen but for the space he left in their formation.

Six hundred feet from the garrison gate, the sergeant called a halt and stepped forward alone, calling up to a shape in the watchtower above. "Who holds this?"

"This garrison is still held for the sea principalities," the shape called down. "Name yourselves — and give the word."

"On the honor of Jeon," the sergeant called back.

A moment's pause. The sergeant glanced round at Paul, satisfied — the right word, and friends behind it.

The gates opened, and more guardsmen spilled out to help drag the wounded in — sea-principality men, plainly, faces drawn and hollow with the fatigue of men who had held under an unexpected

siege.

Inside, the garrison commander met them — a greying, square-built man whose relief warred openly with his confusion, for he understood no more of the day than they did. “You’re the relief,” he said, and it came out half a question. “We’ve held since the fog rolled over us yesterday — that unnatural fog, against what I still couldn’t rightly say. Come, bring your wounded.” Whatever he could not explain, he had plainly not let it stop him doing his duty.

Paul and Jude had heard rumors of the fog from Jamis before they sailed — a grey wall that had stood off the Helm the day before, seen from the Monmurg seawall, where no weather had any business making one. It had lifted by morning, but the signals from the Helm had been incorrect ever since.

The commander confirmed the worst of it: the Helm’s own signals had come through garbled and wrong, and since the fog he’d had no true word from it at all — no light, no runner, no answer to anything he sent. And yet the garrison’s full hundred men still stood, not one lost, the compound somehow left unassaulted even as everything around it burned — a strange island of order in the wreckage of the day.

The commander led Paul and Jude to a quieter corner of the compound. There, safe within the walls at last, Jude let the spell go, and Paul faded back into sight beside him — grey beneath the rim of his mask, one arm held close over the spear-wound seeping at his ribs. He straightened regardless, and made himself steady as the sergeant made the introduction plain. “This is Paul Revero, nephew of Lord Jeon. He’s come to speak with Lord Fairwind, over the silence from this island since the storm.”

“As you have said, the signal was sent,” Paul said, “but not properly coded. What’s happened here?”

What the commander could tell them, he told plainly, and none of it was good. The Helm had been taken, and most of the light-houses with it; of Lord Fairwind there was no word, though the commander believed him still holed up in the inner sanctum, a position hard for any force to take outright. The attackers were two

kinds, and working in concert — the red-faced men Paul named as hobgoblins, and, out of the water, the sahaugin, who had already dragged two ships under in the bay. The eastern light had gone dark with the rest, and a strange vessel prowled the water that any relief would have to swing wide of the island to avoid.

Paul turned the numbers over while a Marine bound the wound at his side with water and clean linen. He let them work, and fixed on the questions one after another, because the questions were a thing he could still do, and feeling the whole weight of the day was not. “Two roads, as I see them,” he said at last. “We wait it out — with me here, the Admiral answers within a day or two, likely enough. Or we move faster: reach a tower whose signal still works, and call for more men sooner.”

The commander sketched the ground for him — the bay, the garrison, the small southern island where the first party had landed, the citadel over all of it — and Paul studied it, working the logic aloud as much for himself as for the commander. “Because they command the water,” Paul said, “we can’t know the true scale of it. Not just what’s left of Fairwind’s men — a great deal more than that.” He held on the sketch a moment. “And we shouldn’t take it for granted that Fairwind sits in that sanctum holding out of his own will. He may be a prisoner in it by now. That changes what it’s worth to reach him.”

“You’re doing your best to put a bright face on it,” the commander observed, not unkindly — and left unsaid, plain in his face, was that he thought the truth a good deal darker — that Fairwind was most likely dead already, prisoner or no, and the Helm lost with him. He had watched the lights go out one by one and ships die in his own bay, and he did not believe a relief force, or a day or two’s patience, would answer what had come off that water. But his men had little enough to hold to as it was, and he kept the rest behind his teeth.

“We can’t sit idle on that either,” Paul went on. “A single runner’s too easily lost. I say we press the Helm — force word back to Monmurg that more men are needed as soon as we can.” Jude

shifted at his shoulder, half a step closer, a few words pitched low and meant for Paul alone; Paul took them up without a beat, as though the thought had been his own all along. "A small party to infiltrate the Helm. Five men, say. And a loud strike somewhere else to pull their eyes while the five climb — one of the beacons the enemy's taken, hit hard enough that every head turns to it and not to us."

The commander marked the whole of it, and marked what it meant: it was the quiet one setting the pace here, pushing his lord toward action, and the lord letting himself be pushed. "And who is this?" he asked, with a glance at Jude.

"An advisor of mine."

"Then let me say this to your advisor as much as to you. Any move toward the lighthouses now is near to suicide. The sahaugin cross open water as easily as you or I cross a room, and they're swarming this island in numbers no one living has ever seen." His mouth tightened. "And that's the strangest part of it — they've left the Helm alone for centuries, since they were broken here long ago."

"Unless," Jude said slowly, "whatever protection this coast once carried against them has failed — the old wards, the powder, whatever it was that kept them off. Something's changed, and this is only the next consequence of it."

"You may be right," the commander admitted, troubled. "Though if you are, it only bears out what I told you. Whatever held them off is gone — so the water's theirs now, all of it, and every beacon on this rock sits close enough to the water to become a grave. Send men to take one back, and the sea may have them before they ever raise the light."

Jude let it lie, and turned to practical matters. "Then we go carefully. We can hold this garrison — the red-faced men haven't the numbers to take it. But the beaches are a death sentence for anyone who tries them." Of the two threats, the commander reckoned the sahaugin far the greater; there were simply more of them, where the hobgoblins numbered perhaps a hundred at most, all come ashore

off the one boat.

Jude weighed the nearest lighthouse with the cold arithmetic of a man measuring what his own fire could and couldn't reach. Could he burn one of the towers outright — everyone in it, in a single stroke? He doubted it. The things stood near eighty feet, several floors apiece; a fireball would gut the base and all who sheltered there, but whoever held the upper stories would ride out the flames and come down after. Not that, then. He kept the reckoning to himself and let it go.

They had no way to signal, the commander said — every other tower taken, most likely by the sahaugin or the hobgoblins that came ashore in the attack. They had tried the lamps and gotten nothing back.

Jude considered it a long moment. "Then send one word, once the light allows: Karmirg." He offered the name flatly and did not explain it — that he had once run with both Gouge and the half-orc whose name it was, the three of them a crew together for years, in a life he no longer spoke of aloud. "If all three towers can see it, and the men we left at the first still hold it, they'll know it for a friend's name and answer. If the other two send back nothing but confusion, we'll have learned that as well."

"When the sun sets," the commander said, "we'll make the attempt."

"A sound plan," he added. "More than I had on my own. Rest while there's time for it — we'll bring food. The walls will hold; the sahaugin won't scale them, and the hobgoblins haven't the numbers to try."

"I need four hours to meditate," Jude said, "if I'm to recover what magic I've spent."

"You may have that and more, Gods willing — nearer nine, if the night is kind. And if we raise our friends out there, we may yet move as one."

"If those friends answer with a name we'd know," Jude added, "— Gouge, or Jude — then we can trust them with the whole of it." He gave the second name as evenly as the first, with no sign that it

was his own.

Sunset was an hour off, no more. The commander went to see to his own prayers while the quiet held, and Paul to whatever rest a wounded man could take. Left to himself, Jude found a corner and settled into the discipline of recovery — calling back a portion of the fire he'd burned through in the fireball's wake, taking the quick way rather than the full, so that he might rise ready if the signal came, or if it did not, and the night demanded worse of him instead.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Karmirg Signal

At the guard tower, near an hour after Merrick had counseled waiting, one of the remaining crossbowmen came hurrying in from the wall. "Sir — there's a signal from the direction of the garrison."

Gouge read it without difficulty, the old training surfacing easily even after years away from it — a light blinking out, over and over, the same broken word.

"K-A-R-M-I-R-G. Karmirg. Karmirg."

"Signal back," Gouge said. "G-O-U-G-E. And wait."

The reply came haltingly, half-garbled in the returning light, but the meaning resolved clear enough: the garrison was held, a hundred and twenty-two safe within its walls, though the Helm itself had fallen. Paul Revere was there among them. "Come as soon as you're able," the message closed.

Gouge weighed the twenty-seven exhausted men left to him against a hundred and twenty-two already behind stone walls. "We go tonight," he said, and sent it back — then turned to what was left of the group. "No time for a full rest; we'll take that once we're inside with them. But we hold this bridge and tower behind us — leave men here to keep them, and a way to signal if Jeon sends another ship."

He turned to Merrick. "You know this ground better than any of us. Lead us in — I'll be at your shoulder the whole way."

Merrick studied him a moment before he answered — the flask, the flat eyes, the ease with which the man had shed the name Aristotle the instant it stopped being of use. He had known him for Gouge since Jamis's office; what he found himself wondering now

was whether even that was the whole of it. "And what's your true name," he asked, half in earnest, half worn thin by the day, "when you're not playing at being someone else?"

Beside them Tyrus had gone still, and Folsom with him. The two had marched and bled the length of the day alongside a crossbowman they'd taken for a fresh transfer — Aristotle, lately assigned to their squad — and only now, watching him read a signal no common bowman could and hand down orders no common bowman would, did the shape of him settle into place. Not a soldier at all. One of Jamis's own, slipped quietly into the ranks under a borrowed name and a borrowed uniform, sent aboard to do the kind of work the admiral did not commit to paper.

"Jude knows it. Karmirg knows it. That's enough people carrying it for one lifetime." Gouge let the silence hold a beat, weighing the faces turned toward him and deciding, plainly, how little he could give them and still have them move when he told them to. "Gouge will do. My cover's spent either way — a man can't do what I've done today and still pass for a fresh transfer. So you have the name, and the fact of me: Lord Jamis put me on that ship, same as he put Merrick, and for reasons that are his and mine and no one else's. Beyond keeping the lot of us breathing, what I'm here to do stays with me." His flat gaze moved from Tyrus to Folsom and back. "Keep the rest to yourselves. A name like mine, said in the wrong room, gets a man killed — and it's usually the man who said it that goes first."

"Understood," Merrick said. Tyrus gave a slow nod after him, a big man quietly setting right everything he'd assumed about the silent figure who had stood at his flank since the Royal Docks.

The party that would make the crossing was a small one — Gouge and Merrick, Tyrus and Folsom, and two of the crossbowmen still unwounded — while the rest, the injured among them, stayed to hold the tower and the bridge with the sergeant. "Stay off the beaches," Gouge told them, one last time, before they set out. "None of us see well enough at night to trust to it blindly, and the sahaugin own that water after sundown more

than they ever have. Mind the bridge, and mind each other.”

And with that, the six of them slipped from the tower’s shelter and out into the night, bound for the garrison across the island, and for whatever waited with Paul Revere behind its walls.

PART THREE: THE MARINES' PATH

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Word From the Tower

Sunset came grudgingly, the sky over the Helm gone the color of a healing bruise, and with the last of the light the garrison commander made good on his word. Up on the watch-platform a signalman knelt behind a squat brass lantern, working its shutter in short, practiced strokes — the hinged plate clacking open and closed across the lit face of it, throwing the old code of the sea principalities out across the water in clean pulses of light. It was slow work, and patient, and it went on a long while before anything troubled to answer.

“Karmirg,” the lantern said, over and over, into the gathering dark. “Karmirg. Karmirg.”

For a long stretch there was nothing but the commander’s patience, the creak of the platform underfoot, and the small tin rattle of the shutter. Then, faint but unmistakable, a light kindled far off in the direction of the Southern Guard Tower — a name flashing back across the strait, deliberate and slow, as though whoever held the lantern on the other end wanted no chance of its being misread.

“G-O-U-G-E,” the signalman read off, letter by letter.

Paul let out a breath he hadn’t known he was holding. “That’s him,” he said. “Or someone who knows to say so.”

“Either way,” Jude said, “we’re not alone out here anymore.”

What followed came in fits and starts, the signalman calling each word as it resolved and the commander shaping it into sense for the two of them at the rail. The Marines who had landed at the southern docks had met hobgoblins of their own — the same red-skinned horror in borrowed armor — and cut their way into the

wooden watchtower there. Twenty-seven of them still stood where thirty had begun the day. They had watched the corsair go down, and could say nothing of how it ended, only that the ship had gone under the swarm and not come up again.

"Say that part back," Jude cut in, before the commander could move on. "The ship. It's actually gone — the whole of it."

The commander watched the next pulses resolve and did not soften them. "They didn't see the end. Only that she was overrun, and that nothing's come off that water since." He let a beat pass. "They assume the worst. So do I."

A second question rode under the tower's report the whole while, and it surfaced now, insistent: they wanted word of Paul, and would not let it lie. A prince's blood was no small thing to lose track of in the chaos of a battle, and they had watched his detachment march the length of the pier and then vanish into the fighting with no way to know whether it had come out the far side.

"They had you as far as the stairs," the commander said, reading. "No further. They'd hoped you reached us, and hadn't dared let themselves believe it." The far lantern stuttered a last small flourish, and something in the commander's tired face gave by a fraction. "They believe it now."

Then came the reckoning of it, and here Jude left off watching the light and set to the arithmetic behind his eyes. The garrison's own hundred. The twenty who had come ashore with Paul. The seven-and-twenty holding the southern tower. Set that against a night that had already taken a whole corsair down into the water, and it made a thin tally — three knots of men on three separate stones, not one of them yet able to see or reach the others.

"And Fairwind's garrison," Paul said slowly, turning the map of it over. "The Helm was held by a hundred and fifty before any of this began. Where are those men now?"

That was the question no one in the room could answer, and the commander's mouth thinned around the admitting of it. They had not marched back out. Whether they lay dead in the fortress, or sat penned somewhere as prisoners, or stood the walls this very night

under whatever flag had taken the island, not a man in the garrison could say. "If they live, and they're still ours," the commander said, and there was something close to hope in it, "that's a hundred and fifty swords we want badly. Enough to turn the whole of this."

Or a hundred and fifty turned against us, Jude thought, and kept it off his face while he thought it. It hung on one man, and the man was Fairwind. If Fairwind had truly gone over, then his garrison had not been overrun at all — it had changed hands with him, a hundred and fifty trained Marines who knew this rock better than anyone now crawling across it tonight, waiting behind those walls not as a prize to be freed but as the hardest teeth on the island. Allies, if their lord was a prisoner or a corpse. Enemies, if he was a traitor with his men still at his back. Until someone knew which, Jude was not willing to write that number onto his own side of the ledger, whatever comfort the commander drew from it. He said none of that aloud; the garrison had little enough to hold to already.

"We'll be fighting sahaugin on top of hobgoblins regardless," was all he gave the room, low, watching the shutter clack out its patient rhythm over the strait.

"The sahaugin are a different problem, and a later one," Paul said. "They can't keep this ground and they know it. It's the hobgoblins, and whoever set them ashore, that we answer first."

The tower meant to hold its position no matter what came — that much the flashes made plain — if only so no relief ship out of Monmurg went sailing blind into the same trap that had already swallowed one corsair.

Paul followed that to its hard end. "Then that tower is our voice to the city. It was raised to throw word the whole way back to Monmurg. Can it still?"

The answer came slow, and it was no. Whatever the tower had been built to do, the hobgoblins had stripped it of the doing — the great signal-brazier hauled off with everything else worth carrying, leaving the men who held it a scant handful of short-range flares. Enough to wave a ship off the rocks at close quarters; nothing that would carry a single word across open water to the city.

"So they can shout to a ship in the harbor," Jude said, "and say nothing at all to the one man who could send us a hundred more." He did not make a complaint of it. He was only fitting the walls of the box they stood in, one plain fact at a time.

"And if the sahaugin take a mind to that tower?" Paul pressed. "Twenty-seven men behind a poor wall, with the sea at their heels."

It was a poor wall, the tower's own men allowed through the shutter — modest works, and they asked for relief in the same breath they said so. But up off the open beach, with even that much stone between them and the water, they did not yet name the shark-folk their worst danger; and when Paul put the sense of that to the commander, the man only nodded. It squared with all he knew of the old enemy. The sahaugin could haul themselves ashore and bear it a few hours before the dry began to kill them, but they loathed the exposure and would not drive inland unless something drove them first. A wall, however mean, told against them as it never told against men. Down on the sand they were a horror out of legend; a dozen steps up a tower stair they were only mortal, and running short of time.

One message remained, and it came last, in a longer and more deliberate hand than the rest — Gouge's own, unmistakable even reduced to the clack of a shutter. "Coming tonight," the signalman read out. "Gathering what men I can. We'll slip the hobgoblins somehow. Expect us before morning." Whatever came after that, the light did not try to say. It would have to be settled face to face, once he and his had won through the dark.

The signalman let the shutter fall still. Paul looked out at the black water, the last of the day gone now, the island's fires — theirs and the enemy's alike — the only light left between the garrison and the Helm's brooding silhouette.

"Then we'd best have a plan ready," he said, "by the time he comes through that gate."

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

All In

They took a brief rest where they could find it — a bench, a corner of the commander's own quarters — and by nine that evening, restored enough to think clearly, Paul and Jude found a quiet moment alone. They had turned all of it over already, in pieces, across the length of the day; what was left now was not to argue it afresh but to lay the pieces in a row and settle them.

"Same question we keep circling," Jude said, pacing a short line across the floorboards, restless in the low lamplight. "All in with the commander and the garrison behind us — a hundred twenty men, near enough — or hold what we have and wait on Monmurg."

"We've no way out either way, short of another ship," Paul said, settling into the chair across from him with the deliberate calm of a man determined not to match the elf's agitation. "Two days before Jeon sends one. Three, at the outside."

"A long two days, with hobgoblins loose on this rock." Jude stopped his pacing. "The commander has food and water for weeks — we could fall back here and hold, if it came to that. But holding isn't winning, and I don't know that Gouge's thirty keep the southern tower if the enemy decides to lean on it. Sit still, and we spend those men a night at a time."

"Then we don't sit still." Paul said it as the settled thing it had already become between them. "We go all in. Lord Jamis was plain — the Helm has to be secured. We hold the barracks, but the barracks were never the island. Without the keep, we've taken nothing."

That much they had agreed on hours ago. It was the how of it that had kept turning.

"The old plan of it was a small party into the Helm," Jude said, "and a loud strike somewhere else to pull their eyes off us while we climbed. A beacon, we said." He shook his head slowly. "But every beacon on this rock stands with its feet in the water, and the water is the sahaugin's now. The commander told us as much — send men to take a beacon back, and the sea has them before they raise the light. A diversion that drowns before it draws a single eye is worse than none at all."

Paul had come to the same place from the other side of it, and said so. "Which leaves the one target that isn't a beach. The Helm sits on the island's crown, as far from the waterline as anything out here — the sahaugin can't reach it and can't hold near it. If we're to make a loud noise anywhere tonight, the safest place to make it is against the keep itself." He turned it once more and found it held. "So the assault is the Helm. Hit the gate hard enough to fix every eye on it, and slip a few men in by a quieter way while it holds. The distraction and the prize become the same stone."

"Safer, and simpler," Jude agreed. "One objective, up out of the sea's reach, instead of two — and the second of them a grave."

"And once we're inside, we do what the moment asks," Paul went on. "Free Fairwind, if he's a prisoner in his own sanctum. Finish him, if he's the reason any of this is happening." He let that sit. "Either way the keep falls. That's the whole of the charge."

"I'll not vouch for the man," Jude said. "Prisoner, dug in alone, or turned — any of the three would keep him just as hidden from us until we're standing in it." He looked at Paul. "You're certain you're ready for that. Tonight."

"Yes." No hesitation in it this time.

"Then the commander's the one who can tell us how it's done — where the wall's weakest, how the gate's held." Jude paused. "But it's you who puts it to him. You do the talking, not me."

"I'd have thought that your part," Paul said. "You're the one who's soldiered through wars like this one."

"And the one they keep squinting at." Jude's mouth twisted, dry. "Every time I open my mouth in that hall I can watch the same

question go round the room — ‘and who exactly is this.’ A strange elf with a wand and no house at his back, telling seasoned Marines to storm a keep. It carries no weight, whatever sense is in it. But you carry Jeon.” He fixed Paul with a level look. “You’re the prince’s blood and his voice on this rock, and that is the one thing here a soldier can’t simply wave off. An order in your mouth is an order; in mine it’s a notion he’s free to weigh and set down again. I want your authority pushing this, not my own — so you front it, and I’ll stand at your shoulder and hand you whatever you don’t yet know.”

Paul took that in, and found, a little to his own surprise, that it did not chafe the way it once might have. “Then I front it,” he said. “How would you have me pitch it?”

“Gently,” Jude said. “A diversion — an assault meant only to draw the eye. A man doesn’t care to be told he’s storming a keep; tell him he’s mounting a distraction that happens to open a door, and he’ll thank you for it. He’ll not want to climb a ladder under a rain of arrows besides — no sane man would. Offer him a hole blown in a wall, a guard or two silenced, a stretch of stone scaled in the dark, and he’ll say ‘good, let’s do that.’” Something dry crossed his face. “Which likely leaves the doing of it to him, the two of us, and whatever crew Gouge brings through the night.”

“All in, then,” Paul said, and it carried the weight of a thing decided rather than proposed.

“All in,” Jude said.

Paul got to his feet at last. “I’ll bring the commander in — and put it to him myself. Let’s give him a door worth opening.”

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Commander's Ledger

The garrison commander came within minutes of being sent for — a greying, square-built man with the patience of someone who had answered a great many royal summonses in his time and expected this to be one more. He inclined his head to Paul. "Prince. How may I serve?"

"Your best count," Paul said, "of how many hold this island against us."

The commander did the sum with the ease of a man who had already run it a dozen times that night. "A hundred hobgoblins confirmed, moving in and out of the Helm, and smaller bands of twenty or thirty sighted about the island. Add the fifty the southern tower met — thirty of them still standing against our men — and whatever took the beacons besides, and the whole of it likely runs past two hundred. Perhaps two hundred fifty." His mouth thinned. "The strength of a warship's complement, near enough — though we've seen no warship in the bay to have carried them."

"They came in under the fog," Jude said quietly.

"They did. It killed every man's sight past five feet; they could have ferried a small army ashore in boats and no lookout the wiser. I'd wager they overran the hundred and fifty who garrisoned the keep — whether those men are dead now, or penned, or turned to the other side, I couldn't tell you. As for the gate, they'll have had a hand inside to lower the bridge; there's no moat out there, only the ramp and the drawbridge, and fifty feet of fitted stone doing the rest. And mark this — the gate was never broken. It stands whole, the only way into the Helm there is. Strange, that the keep's own

garrison would let an enemy walk in through its one door."

Jude leaned in with a concern of his own. "Is there any water-fed way into the interior — old tunnels, sewers, anything the sea might climb? If the wards are down, I'd not have the shark-folk coming up beneath our feet."

"Rumor speaks of a smugglers' cave beneath the Helm, navigable by small boat, the mouth of it somewhere on the northern coast — treacherous water, a small craft its only hope, and nothing I've laid eyes on myself. The Admiralty keeps that knowledge close; admitting to it at all would be treason on my part." A dry glance. "If the hobgoblins found their way up through it, I couldn't begin to tell you how."

Paul laid it out plainly then — the thing he and Jude had already settled between them. They could not sit and hold; a relief ship was two days off at the soonest, and the hobgoblins would bleed the garrison a night at a time in the meanwhile. Jamis's charge was the Helm, and the Helm had to be taken. They meant to go all in, tonight, and put the whole of their strength behind retaking it.

The commander wanted little convincing. He was a fighting man before he was a careful one, and the waiting had galled him as much as it had them; before Paul had finished he was already nodding, turning past the whether of it to the how. "You'll get no argument from me on that. My only quarrel is how we spend the men we've got — I'll not throw them at that gate to die for a gesture."

"We take back the Western Beacon first," he offered. "Fifty men could manage it tonight, and we want a light burning out there — for the shipping's sake, and to carry word to Monmurg that the southern tower can't."

"No." Jude said it flatly, and gentled it only a little when the commander's brow rose. "Every beacon on this rock stands with its feet in the water, and the water is the sahaugin's now — the wards that kept them off are down. Send fifty men down to the tideline to raise a light and the sea takes them before the flame's caught. We'd spend them for nothing and warn no one." He let it settle. "The one

place on this island the sahaugin can't reach is the Helm itself, up on the crown. If we're to spend lives tonight, we spend them there — not on a beach."

The commander weighed it, and Jude watched the sense of it arrive behind his eyes. "You're right," he admitted at last, grudging. "I've thought of that beacon as a prize to be had back ever since its fire went out. But a dark beacon we can retake another day. Drowned men we can't." He set the notion aside. "The Helm, then."

"The Helm the way they took it from us," Paul said. "A loud push at the front to fix every eye there, and a small party over the wall on the seaward side while it holds."

"You'd scale the cliffs first, then the garrison-house wall, and drop into the court from above," the commander said. "It wants real skill at the climb, and few enough men to go unseen — put a crowd on that wall and the defenders simply cut them down as they come."

"Rope carries most of it," Jude said. "And I've magic to lift a man where rope won't reach."

The commander's eyes sharpened. "You can carry a man up on the air?"

"I can."

"Then keep the party small, and it might be done — most of their strength drawn to the gate, only a token left above to watch the sea." He studied Jude a moment. "You mean to rescue my lord Fairwind."

"If he lives, and can help us take the Helm — yes," Jude said, and the question of it carried more weight in his mouth than the words alone explained. "Even a gate opened from the inside would be worth a great deal."

"Everything turns on how many he has left against how many hold the walls," the commander said, and his face promised little. "Charge that gate outnumbered and it's a slaughter, my lord or no."

Paul turned it toward the practical. "Have your men bring up what hobgoblin dead they can from the harbor once it's dark — the armor above all, and no needless risk taken for it. If we can pass for

them at any distance, once we're inside, so much the better."

"You've a hand for disguise, then?" the commander asked, studying him anew.

"I've made masks before. Bring me a body to work from and I'll match the shape of it well enough — the jaw, the coloring, whatever's left of the hair. Helmets and low light carry the rest." Paul said it evenly, and did not add how much of his life had gone into learning the trick of it.

"The party's yours, then, and under your own authority rather than mine," the commander said. "I'll hold the garrison and make the show at the gate — a ram assembled in plain sight, fire traded at range, enough to fix their eyes there. When your man out of Monmurg reaches us, put the whole of it before him and settle the particulars; he'll want his own say." He studied Paul a moment longer. "You mean to go over that wall yourself."

"I do," Paul said.

"You're certain of it."

"I am."

"Then be ready when the hour comes." The commander inclined his head. "I'll see the bodies brought in, the men readied, and a diversion standing by the gate. Spend as few lives as you can out there — the sahaugin have made this island dear enough already." And with that he withdrew, leaving Paul and Jude alone once more with a plan settling, however roughly, into place.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Two Kinds of Skill

They sat together afterward in the quiet the commander left behind, the lamp burning low, the night outside gone fully dark save for the distant, watchful glow of the Helm's stolen fires.

"You'd no objection to my telling the commander you could carry a man up on the wind?" Paul asked, something almost teasing beneath it.

"None — though it was a little funny, hearing it said so plain." Jude allowed the ghost of a smile. "I don't lead with what I can do, as a rule. But the man had all but decided I'd be no use to him, so I let slip I was a caster, and that settled him quick enough."

Paul turned something over a while before he spoke again — the matter that had sat at the back of his mind since the tower flashed a killer's name across the dark. "This Gouge, then. The man we're waiting on. I know next to nothing of him — a few of my uncle's stories, and none of them kind."

"You know more of him than you think," Jude said. "He crossed with us on the corsair. One of the crossbowmen — studded leather, a borrowed name, standing shoulder to shoulder with men who'd have gutted him if they'd known what he was. You walked that deck past him a dozen times and never marked it. That's rather the whole point of the man."

Paul had, and it unsettled him more than he let show. "That's the piece I keep worrying at. My uncle keeps men like that — set down on the same deck as a prince's own blood, hidden in plain sight, and no one the wiser." He looked at the elf directly. "I know almost nothing of that world of his. And you're a part of it, plainly

— you knew him on sight, where I never did. So tell me. What is Jamis's business, truly, and what are the men he keeps to do it?"

"Dangerous, and quiet, and better left unnamed — that's the business," Jude said, and something guarded eased in him by a degree, the way it did only when the room held no one but the two of them. "As for the men — I'll speak to the one who's coming, since you'll be at his shoulder by morning. I know Gouge better than almost anyone still drawing breath. We ran together once, years back — the two of us and a third, in another life. You don't forget a man you've bled beside." He left the third unnamed, and Paul did not reach for it. "So take this from one who's worked at his side, and not from palace gossip. Whatever the commander's put in your name tonight, when it comes to the sharp end, you let Gouge lead it. He'll not defer to rank, yours or any man's. It's the work he was made for, and in the doing of it he answers to no one but Jamis."

"And if I disagree with him?"

"Hold your own judgment; I'd never tell you to go silent and simply obey. But know what you're about when you do it. Arguing isn't in his nature, and never was. I've come nearer to it with him than any man living, and I'll tell you plainly — every time, I went in half-expecting one of us would have to kill the other before it was done." He said it without weight, which made it land the harder. "It never came to that. He's never once raised a hand to me. But I've never made the mistake of thinking he couldn't."

Paul turned that over, gauging the elf as much as the warning. "And what is he, under it all?"

"A knife," Jude said simply. "Built to kill and little else — he'll open a throat and have the blade home again before you've marked it gone. It isn't cruelty; it's trade. Point him at the right thing and there's no better man on this rock tonight. Point him wrong, and you'd not care to be near the discovering."

"You make him sound a good deal like you," Paul observed, dry.

"There's a difference." The humor cooled a shade. "I throw walls of fire, and I've filled a tower with men and lit the whole of it up around them — I know exactly what I am. But I'll argue a thing half

to death before I do it, where Gouge won't argue it at all. Two kinds of skill, and two kinds of man." He let it sit. "One thing more, since you're asking after the whole of him. He drinks — but never much before a job, not in all the years I knew him. A flask in reach and work in front of him, and you'll have the sharp Gouge and not the other kind."

Paul took the whole of it in — the warning, the boast folded inside it, the old loyalty the elf tried and failed to keep from his voice — and thought he had the measure of the wizard a little better for it. A man in love with his own legend, plainly. But a man who had bled beside another and still spoke of him with something close to care. That, Paul thought, was worth the knowing too — perhaps more than anything the elf had said about Gouge.

"You should rest," Paul said, "before he comes and there's no time left for it. I'll keep at the masks."

"You're set on making them yourself."

"One that passes is worth every hour it costs. Two or three, and I'll call it a triumph." Paul turned a strip of leather over in his hands. "I saw enough of them at the dock to begin from memory, and there'll be a body or two brought up to work from directly. I can't fight in their plate anyway — a cloak and a hooded face read well enough at a distance, in the dark."

"I'll not need any of it," Jude said, the fondness for his own legend creeping back. "I'll be over the wall and in the air the whole approach, watching from above, while the rest of you are down in the muck. If I ever find myself wanting a hobgoblin's face, something's gone badly wrong — picture it, one of them drifting past the real ones on the wind, disguise half-slipping. They'd wonder what in the world they were looking at."

Paul laughed despite himself, and filed it away with the rest: the elf did enjoy an audience.

"I'm going to recover what I can before he arrives and puts an end to my peace," Jude said, rising. He weighed, a moment, how far to push it — he had spent freely already, the fire on the docks and again among the shark-men, and a longer meditation would give

more of it back if the hours allowed. "I caught a little rest earlier and have some of it in hand. I'll see how far the night lets me go before I'm called on again." He was already turning for the corner. "Brief Gouge yourself when he lands — I can't have the trance broken to do it, or I lose what I've clawed back. And remind him of the water caves beneath the Helm, wherever their mouth lies. It may matter before the night's out."

"I'll hold all of it for him," Paul said. "Go rest. I'll be here."

"Back when I've what I can get," Jude said, and left him to the lamplight and the work of paper and paste and borrowed faces — while beyond the barracks walls, the island waited for whatever Gouge would bring with him out of the dark.

PART FOUR: GOUGE'S CREW

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Through the Woods

At the Southern Guard Tower, the hour of waiting had worn thin. Merrick had spent it turning the lantern-signals over in his mind, and Gouge had spent it, as he spent most things, in restless silence, until word came at last that Jude and Paul Revero reached the barracks — a hundred twenty men there, and urgency besides, since the island lay ringed by sahaugin and no relief could reach it until they were driven clear.

“That hand on the far end of the light,” Merrick said, a question plain beneath it. “Who is it we’ve been talking to, all this while? Back and forth, lantern to lantern, a whole conversation carried on light alone — and no garrison sergeant signals like that.”

“Jude,” Gouge said, and something close to respect moved under the flat of his voice. “I’d know his hand anywhere — the code he set, the old name he leaned on so we’d take it for friends and not a trap. He’s pretty sharp with a signal lamp, that one: says a great deal in very little, and nothing a hobgoblin could puzzle out.” He let it rest there, and turned to the crossing they had worked out between them — a small party going ahead on foot, two swordsmen and two bowmen, while the tower’s own sergeant held the rest back, to guard against anything still lurking behind them and to warn off any ship that came sailing blind into the strait.

By ten they had said what needed saying and turned to the question of when to slip away. With the moon obscured, sooner, Merrick judged, was always better than later, and the plan settled quickly enough: the tower’s archers would loose a volley toward the barracks grounds to draw any watching eyes, while the party slipped

out the back under cover of the noise.

"We go out while they're looking elsewhere," Merrick said, turning it over aloud, and gathered the four who would go with them at the base of the tower — Tyrus and Folsom, and two crossbowmen, all of them waiting on his word.

"I'll lead," he said. "I know this ground better than anyone left standing."

"I'll be close behind you," Gouge said. "Not far enough to lose sight of you."

"Stay behind him," Merrick told the rest, "and I'll stay quiet as long as I've got him in view."

They went out the back of the tower and struck for the bridge, Merrick moving first and alone, reading the coastline's broken shapes the way another man might read a well-worn page — thirty feet, forty, the moonlight finding him for an instant and losing him again just as fast. He crossed a hundred fifty feet before he judged it safe to look back, found the ground beyond the bridge clear of any watching shape, and signaled the rest forward.

Gouge came next, and came beautifully — a shadow among shadows, not so much as a whisper of cloth against stone — with Tyrus close on his heels, keeping himself deliberately between the ranger and the men still coming up behind. The two crossbowmen fared worse. A buckle knocked despite every care, a boot caught on loose stone in the dark, and somewhere behind them a sound carried far enough to matter.

The first bolt hissed past a heartbeat later, then two more — all wide, but close enough that no one could pretend the noise had gone unheard. Fire answered from the tower above, the archers there doing what they could to cover the retreat.

"Fall back," Tyrus called to his own men, already turning.

"I can drop a fog bank over them," Merrick offered. "Cost me, but it'll hide the retreat."

"Do it," Tyrus said, and Merrick let the spell go, a grey curtain rolling low across the ground exactly where the trailing men needed it most. The two crossbowmen fell back toward the tower

under its cover, while Merrick, Gouge, Tyrus, and Folsom pressed on, four now where six had started, and reached the bridge without further incident.

At the rail, Merrick leaned out and looked down into the black water below — sharks cutting pale wakes beneath the surface, and further off, unmistakable even at this distance, a sahaugin riding one of them like a man might ride a hound.

"We don't cross bunched together, and not near the edges," he said. "Down the center, in pairs, and we regroup on the far side."

"Gouge and I first," Tyrus said. "You two follow."

They went in twos, weapons drawn, exposed the whole four hundred feet of open span but shielded at least from anything watching along the water's edge. No one so much as glanced their way. The four of them gathered again on the far bank, checked once more for any fresh signal from the tower, and found none.

"We stay off the coastline from here," Merrick decided. "Deeper into the wood, even if it costs us time — better that than being seen from the water."

He led the way into the trees, hugging the edge of the palm growth where the shadow ran deepest, the party trailing in careful order behind him. The distance to the barracks was less than a mile as the gull flew, but stealth stretched it to the better part of an hour, the four of them threading through sparse woodland and scattered palms until, close to eleven, the barracks' palisade rose ahead of them — watchtowers dark against the sky, Marines pacing the wall in plain sight.

"Do they see us?" Merrick murmured.

"Not yet," Gouge said. "We're still under cover."

"We need to be recognized, not mistaken for something worse," Merrick said. He turned to Gouge. "Try the wall — see if you can find the door."

"This wall's climbable," Gouge said, studying the palisade's dark bulk, already sizing it for a way over.

"Climbable, if it comes to it," Merrick judged, "but risky — a hundred twenty men posted along that wall, watchtowers spaced

the whole length of it. I don't think we need to sneak in at all, honestly. They know we're coming — the signals have made that plain enough. This is obviously us, not hobgoblins."

Merrick weighed the distance to the wall — seventy feet, with a bare thirty-foot clearing between the treeline and the palisade itself — and judged a quiet word wiser than any climb. At his nod, Folsom shaped a few soundless words and sent them out on his own small magic, a voice arriving in a distant guard's mind rather than his ears: *We're here — Gouge and his party, at the edge of the woods.*

The answer came back the same way, calm and already expecting them. *We've been watching for you. Follow the west wall to the front gate, and you'll be let through.*

They moved along the base of the palisade with weapons still drawn, and by the time they reached the gate it was already lifting, the four of them slipping beneath it into the compound proper — where the garrison commander stood in a breastplate, waiting to greet them.

"Merrick — good to see you on your feet," the commander said, taking in the others with the quick recognition of a man who had held these waters a long while. "Tyrus, too. Good you've made it up." He drew himself a little straighter then, and put the thing plainly, before any of them needed to wonder at it. "You'll mark me for one of Lord Fairwind's officers — this garrison is his, every man behind the wall. And loyal to the Sea Princes, every one — the same as Lord Fairwind himself. If he's still alive in that keep, then getting him out of it is the first work before us."

"And how does it stand to the south — the beacon's ground you've just come off?" the commander asked.

It was Tyrus who answered, the southern position being his squad's to speak for. "Held, near enough. Some five-and-twenty men in the guard tower with the sergeant, set to sit tight and ward off any ship that comes blind at the strait. The beacon itself was never taken — but it stands dark all the same; we hadn't the men to spare to light it."

"A mercy you hold it at all," the commander said.

"We took that tower off a nest of them to begin with," Tyrus put in. "Hobgoblins — the same red-skinned lot in our own kit. Cost us, but we cleared them out. And the water the whole way between is thick with sahaugin; we crossed only by keeping well off the coast."

"Both, then." The commander's face darkened. "Hobgoblins and sahaugin."

"We watched the corsair go down ourselves, from the tower," Tyrus said, the memory of it plain on his face. "Overrun in the bay, and under before we could lift a hand — two hundred men, and not one come up since." He hesitated. "The signals said Revero reached you. Is the boy whole? I'd not have watched that and then learned we'd lost him at the last."

"He reached us," the commander said. "Alive, and here."

Gouge's eyes moved over the compound, searching. "Where's the elf?"

"Not here — resting, and not to be roused," the commander admitted, then studied Gouge more closely, something like recognition settling over his face. "You'll be Gouge, then, by the look of you. And Folsom — welcome. Paul Revero wishes to speak with you. Come."

He led them down into the heart of the barracks, toward what had clearly been made into a command office, and there, waiting for them, sat young Paul Revero — no sign of Jude beside him. In person he cut a strange figure: a silver mask fixed over his face, tight leather clothing that clung close despite the warm night, gloves worn even indoors. The four of them filed into the room and paused at the threshold, uncertain, for a moment, quite what they were looking at.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Prince in the Mask

The commander led them down into what had been made a command office, where Paul Revero rose to meet them — a strange figure by any reckoning, the silver mask fixed over his face, gloved and close-wrapped in leather despite the warmth of the night. Gouge's crew took his measure the way men weigh a thing they cannot quite place.

"Which of you is the Gouge I've heard so much of?" Paul asked.

"That would be me."

Introductions went round and told Paul more than the names did. Tyrus he marked for a loyal soldier, and Folsom for something lighter — a musician's ease about him, out of place in all that armor. Merrick named himself Jamis's man and left it at that — but Paul knew what it meant when the admiral kept a man close, and marked him for no common Marine: someone Jamis was grooming toward a captain's rank, or Paul would have wagered his mask on it. But it was the crossbowman who held his eye — and, past him, the elf. Gouge moved and spoke like no common bowman, and when the talk came round to Jude there was something in it Paul had not looked for: a plain, unforced regard, the mark of old history between them. Jude had told him as much himself — that the two had run together once, bled beside one another in some earlier wars — but hearing it and seeing it sit on a man like Gouge were different things. Paul had taken the elf for a braggart at their first meeting, all wand and swagger, half in love with his own cleverness. The docks had begun to teach him otherwise; the sahaugin had not cared how a man talked, and Jude had proved worth more in that black water

than any three who kept their mouths shut. And now a knife of a man — hard, unshowy, no one's fool — reckoned that same elf worth crossing a war beside. Such men did not waste their trust on braggarts. Paul, who wore a false face of his own, knew how poorly a first glance served, and set his aside to look again.

He laid the situation out plainly, and the commander filled the gaps where the keep's own bones were concerned. The Helm stood taken, better than two hundred fifty of the red-skinned things holding it, and the sahaugin thick in every reach of water round the island. Between the garrison's own hundred and the twenty who had come ashore with Paul, they could field near a hundred and twenty men — enough to make a great noise at the front gate, nowhere near enough to storm a keep built to hold off a fleet. So the plan he and Jude had settled on, across the hours of waiting, was quieter than storming: the garrison would mount a loud show of force at the gate to fix every eye there, while a small party slipped in over the seaward wall and went down into the keep after Lord Fairwind.

"Fairwind's the whole of it," the commander said, earnest. "He's the one man alive who can raise the warding again. Get him free and whole, and the sahaugin are the sea's trouble once more, and not ours."

Gouge let that stand, and did not add the rest of it — that Jamis had put him aboard to learn whether Fairwind was worth the freeing at all. That was not a thing to say in this room, in front of a man who so plainly loved his lord.

The garrison commander turned to the newcomers. "There's another way. I raised it with Lord Paul already, and he was against it, for reasons I respect — but hear it yourselves, and judge. Rumor tells of a smugglers' cavern running up under the Helm from the seaward side — a passage beneath every wall and watch on the rock, for a man who can find its mouth. Slip in by that, and I'd have no need to spend my men on a show at the gate at all."

Paul gave him a long, cool look. He had thought the matter closed — the wall, the diversion, the whole shape of it agreed with this same man before ever Gouge's crew came through the gate.

"No." Gouge said it flat. "Two things I'll hold to tonight, and neither bends. First — we keep clear of the sahaugin. That cave comes up out of the water they own; we'd go blind through the dark toward a mouth that might open on a room full of them, with no way to call for help when it did. The wall is dry ground and open air, and they cannot follow a man into the sky. We take the wall."

Something in Paul eased at that. He had half-expected the man Jude painted — a knife that answered to no one but Jamis, built to kill and little else — to reach for the boldest road going and haul them all down it. Instead the caution sat as plain in him as the competence did, the two together in a single refusal. A killer who weighed the cost before he spent it was a far better man to climb a wall beside than a fearless one.

"And the second?" Paul asked.

"We go small." Gouge let his gaze travel the room. "A handful, no more. Send a company at that wall and the watch cuts them down as they climb; send four or five, quiet, under cover of your diversion, and we're over and gone before a head turns. Numbers are what kill men on work like this." He let it rest. "I've done a deal of it."

It was the most anyone in the room had heard the crossbowman say, and no one moved to gainsay it.

Paul had favored the wall from the first, and Gouge's certainty only settled him the surer in it. Whatever the cave had promised — a way to Fairwind unseen — it was not worth a blind crawl through water the sahaugin owned. "The wall, then," he said, "the diversion to hide a small party going over and in. But I'll not settle the last of it without Jude. It's his arts that will carry us over that wall, and the particulars are his to settle before any of it is fixed." He looked to the commander. "Rouse him, if his trance can be parted gently. This won't keep until three, and neither will the dark."

The commander went to fetch Jude and found him already stirring, as if he had felt the thing being decided without him.

Gouge met him at the door with something close to warmth, a hand put out where another man might have embraced him. "Not

quite an embrace, Jude — but you're worth a good deal more to me than a handshake."

Jude took it and blinked the last of the trance away. "What hour is it?"

"Half past eleven. We move within it."

"You could have left me till one." There was little heat in it; he had never truly counted on the whole night, and he shook off the stiffness as he heard the plan laid out — turning his practiced eye, as ever, on the parts that leaned on his craft. The lift over the seaward wall. The painted hobgoblin faces Paul had spent the evening building. The bank of fog Merrick could throw up to blind a pursuer. "The wall, then," he said at the end of it. "I carry you up one at a time, and we go in quiet. It'll serve." Whatever doubt had still moved in the room went out of it at that.

"Then I'll ready my end," the commander said, rising. "Braziers and a ram where they can't be missed, and noise enough at the gate to turn every head on that wall." He bent his head to Paul. "You'll have no way to send us word once you're over, my lord — I know it. So I'll hold the noise at the gate as long as I dare, and no longer; be quick. The Gods keep you out there." And he went to rouse the garrison to its part, and took his plain love of his lord out the door with him.

Gouge waited for the latch before he spoke again, and what was left in his voice had no warmth in it. "The rest of this stays between us. I'd not say it in front of that one, and now I needn't. But hear it straight before we go over any wall — Jamis did not send me to free Lord Fairwind. He sent me to learn whether Fairwind's worth the freeing at all."

Paul held very still. "Go on."

"The warding that's kept the shark-folk off this rock a hundred years and more doesn't simply come undone," Merrick said, low. He knew these waters as few living men did, and did not offer it lightly. "Someone let it fall — and of every soul on the Helm, Fairwind is the one who held its keeping."

"Suspicion, is all — no proof, one way or the other," Gouge said.

"But it's why Jamis set me on that ship, and why I'll take the man alive if the night lets me. A traitor's no use to anyone with his throat opened, and we'll want him breathing regardless: someone must know how the warding is raised again, and the sea sent back where it belongs."

"And why now?" Jude put in. "That warding held a hundred years and better. The sahaugin don't cross it on a whim — someone gave them cause, or gave them leave." He looked to Merrick. "An old bargain gone sour, perhaps — sea-elves, merfolk, whatever swims out there that a man in Fairwind's seat might once have come to terms with."

"If there was ever such a pact, I never caught wind of it," Merrick said, "and I've watched this water longer than most. But I've never been under it. Whatever bought the Helm its hundred years of quiet, it's spent now."

"Which is the other thing we go to find," Gouge said. "Not only whether the man turned, but what he traded for it, and to whom."

It should have struck harder than it did. Instead Paul found the pieces only settling into a shape he had half-drawn himself — on the corsair, and again on the garrison wall — the island dressed to look asleep, Fairwind too conveniently silent behind his defenses. He looked to Jude, and read in the elf's want of surprise that this was old knowledge between him and Gouge, carried the whole way and never once laid before him. He let the sting of it pass; there would be time to mind that later, or there would not.

"Then it's the truth of the man we're after," Paul said, "as much as the man." The garrison would make its noise at the gate; the rest of them — Gouge, Jude, Paul, Merrick, and what few more were worth the climb — would go over the wall and down into the Helm after Lord Fairwind, to settle the truth of him there, in the dark, where only they would see it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The Little Scout

"I've a way to see the grounds of the Helm before we set foot on them," Paul said, and drew a small clay figure from within his coat.

"What is that, exactly?" Merrick asked, leaning in.

"This." Paul held it up to the lamplight — a clay lizard no bigger than a large rat, its wings folded neat against its sides. "I send it on ahead — up a wall, along a ledge; it climbs well, and glides from one surface to the next. And I see and hear everything it does, the whole while, from wherever I've gone to ground. It can go over that seaward wall and show me what waits on the far side before a single one of us starts the climb."

"That's remarkable," Merrick said, something like wonder breaking through his exhaustion.

"Is that — witchcraft?" Folsom asked, eyeing the little creature with open suspicion.

"It's a homunculus," Paul said, with the patience of a man who had corrected the same mistake more than once already. "Not whatever you were about to call it. A homunculus."

"We ought to write songs about it," Gouge said.

"Please don't," said Paul.

"Can it be hurt?" Tyrus asked, studying the figure in Paul's palm. "It's clay — is it even alive, properly?"

"It can be damaged. Destroyed, even," Paul said. "But it's not alive, no, and I take no hurt when it does. If I lose it I can make another — not quickly, and not easily, but I can."

Merrick's gaze had settled on the little thing, though his mind had plainly gone elsewhere. "That smugglers' cave the commander

spoke of," he said. "We're not going near it — Gouge has the right of that, with the shark-folk owning that water. But it sits wrong with me all the same. If a way in exists, the enemy can use it as readily as any smuggler — more readily, coming out of the sea as they do. Have your scout keep an eye to the rocks as it goes. If something's crawling up into the keep from below, I'd sooner learn it now than feel it at our backs later."

"It'll watch for it," Paul said. "One more thing to look for."

That settled, he turned to the other work the evening had cost him. At his word the commander had earlier had the hobgoblin dead carried in from where they'd fallen — with their rope and stripped helmets besides — and Paul had spent the hours since bent over them with a small cosmetics kit, fitting the red-skinned look onto his companions with paper and paste and pigment by lamplight.

"These are rough," he admitted, working a last one into shape. "But in the dark they'll buy a second glance instead of an arrow on sight. It's the armor that does the real work — their leather and scale sit near enough to Marine issue, only the coloring wrong. We marked as much on the ones we fought earlier. In their gear, at a distance, we pass for theirs — long enough, maybe, to get the jump on anyone who stops us."

He glanced at Tyrus, and at the sheer size of him, and let it go unspoken; some men were harder to hide than others, and both of them knew it.

"When do we want the commander moving on the gate?" Tyrus asked.

"We'll want to be well clear before it starts," Paul said. "The noise draws every eye to the front — that serves us — but we can't be crossing open ground while it's still quiet. Twenty minutes ahead of them, thirty."

"Agreed." Gouge measured the dark beyond the wall. "Once they move, they'll light the braziers and make a show of the ram. Call it for half past midnight. How long to reach position from here?"

Ten minutes, he was told — carefully, across some seven hundred and fifty feet of open ground.

“And send word to the South Beacon before any of it begins,” Gouge added, “so they don’t take the racket for an attack on themselves and spend men we haven’t got to spare.”

“I’ll do it now,” Folsom said, and sent it on the shuttered lantern — the message going out across the black water that whatever they saw near the Helm this night, they were to hold, and wait for a second signal before they stirred.

“Then that’s the whole of it,” Gouge said. “The six of us, out through the north exit, and up the coast from there.”

CHAPTER THIRTY

Over the Wall

They slipped out through the north exit in the deep hours between the second and third of Wealsun, six shapes moving into darkness that gave back nothing in return.

Merrick went first, peeling off wide of the cliffs, well clear of anything the walls might see, moonlight finding him for one bare instant before the shadows swallowed him whole. The rest followed in a loose, careful line — Merrick, then Paul, then Gouge, Jude, Folsom, and Tyrus bringing up the rear, thirty feet of separation held between each of them, trusting that a thousand feet of distance from the barracks walls would be enough to keep them unseen, disguises or no.

They came at last to a spot high above the coast, looking down on a stretch of beach far below — steep rock the whole way, waves breaking hard against a cliff face that offered no easy path down.

"This the stretch your smugglers' cave is meant to open on?" Jude asked, low.

"Somewhere along here, if it's more than rumor — high above the rocks," Merrick said, his eyes to the black water. "We've no need of it ourselves. But if the enemy's been coming up that way, this is where we'd catch the sign of it."

What caught every eye instead was a ship riding at anchor off-shore — lit by lanterns, foreign in her lines, three or four hundred feet out from the cliffs. No colors flew from her at all.

Jude studied the cut of her. "That rig's built for speed, not war," he said. "One of the newer Onwal traders, unless I'm much mistaken — yard-built clear across the ocean, and there's little afloat

can run one down — a corsair couldn't do it. Not a hull you'd look to find anchored off a besieged rock."

"Not one of ours," Merrick said. "None of us knows her by sight."

"Could be honest trade, caught out by the blockade," Tyrus offered.

"Not tonight," Paul said. "Not with all the rest of it."

As they watched, a skiff slipped from a fold in the coast that had seemed to hold no opening at all and struck out toward the anchored ship — a Monmurg smuggler's craft, small and bay-built, the sort only a pilot who knew those rocks could thread through them in the dark. The point it came from was the one stretch of shoreline that curved out of sight: the smugglers' cave, past any doubt now, and in use.

"Then the way in's compromised," Paul said quietly, "or someone down there is a part of this."

"Or Fairwind arranged it himself," Gouge said, "and got in past his depth for the trouble."

The larger ship rode low and heavy — loaded, not taking on. Whatever was leaving the Helm under siege, someone had judged it worth a foreign hull and a hidden cave to move.

Then a figure resolved on the ship's deck, directing the hobgoblins at their cargo — shock-white hair, skin pale even at this distance. Gouge went very still.

"That's Toli," he said, and there was no doubt in it at all. "I've put four of that kind in the ground myself, on the Monmurg docks, a month back or near it. There's no mistaking the look."

Of them all, only Gouge had ever crossed blades with the Toli — he, and Karmirg, who was not here to say so. It was, Paul thought, exactly what Lord Jamis had feared: the Toli, tangled in the heart of it.

"I'd not chase whatever's on that ship," Paul said, "and lose the men who are actually running this. We make for the wall, as we planned." No one argued him.

They worked up the coastline into deeper cover — a better eye

on the ship, and nearer the wall besides — near enough now to watch the skiff reach the larger vessel and begin passing up barrels, the rough size of any in a Monmurg warehouse. And then, from the barracks walls behind them, shouting broke out, hobgoblins running for the front gate in numbers.

The diversion had begun. The pale figure glanced once toward the noise and turned back to his cargo, unconcerned.

"Then we move," Gouge said, "while their eyes are all one way."

The commander's account held true — an entrance on this stretch of wall, reachable by a fifty-foot climb, with a tower door waiting somewhere above it.

"I'll go first," Gouge said. "Best suited for the climb." He crossed the broken ground to the foot of the wall and started up its face, fingers and boot-tips reading the stone in the dark, while the rest held in cover and watched thirty or forty hobgoblins stream past toward the fighting at the gate, not one of them sparing a glance for the shadows along the cliff.

"Bows ready, if anyone up top marks him," Merrick murmured, and watched Gouge climb — unhurried, sure-handed, a man who had gone up a great many walls he was never meant to — until he rolled over the parapet and was gone onto the wall-walk. A moment later a rope came snaking down the face of it, made fast somewhere above.

One by one the others broke cover and crossed to the foot of the wall — quick, low, hooded shapes flitting over the broken ground, each dash timed to the stream of hobgoblins still pounding past toward the gate. The dark hid them and the uproar at the front covered whatever the dark did not; no head turned their way, no cry went up, and in a few held breaths they had gathered at the base beneath the dangling rope.

Jude took the rope in hand and spoke low the words that lift a man's weight from under him. "Paul — start up; I'll ease you as you climb." He watched the strange work of it even as he shaped the spell. "Unsettling to see, if I'm honest."

"I appreciate the honesty," Paul said, and climbed, the spell eas-

ing him the last of the way in slow, careful pulls until he came over the parapet and crouched on the wall-walk beside Gouge.

"Still pass for a hobgoblin, on my knees like this?" he asked under his breath.

"Near enough," Gouge judged. "You'll do, against the bigger ones."

Tyrus climbed the rope cleanly and crouched at the parapet. Folsom came after with rather less grace, owning no great love of heights, but made it up all the same. Jude followed, dropping into the shadows unremarked. Merrick held the rope at the foot of the wall through all of it, his eyes going again and again to the anchored ship, and climbed last, drawing the line up behind him.

Six of them crouched now along the wall near the tower in the dark, the battle at the gate still burning below. Ahead, a door stood open into the tower itself, a single hobgoblin guarding it, and beyond that, a hundred feet off, a larger cluster of thirty or forty more, all facing the fighting, none of them looking back.

"I'll take the door guard," Gouge said quietly. "Quick and quiet — doesn't matter who backs the play."

"I can draw a few eyes instead," Folsom offered. "Stumble out like a straggler, make some noise, give you the moment you need."

He broke cover and jogged into view, playing the part with a theatrical trip and a stumbling recovery, drawing exactly the attention he meant to. In the same breath Gouge crossed the distance to the door guard in absolute silence, and the hobgoblin went down without so much as a gasp.

"I'll keep a shroud of dark ready, if it comes to that," Jude murmured, "though there's no sense blinding ourselves along with them."

A second guard came around the wall's curve then, drawn by some half-heard sound, the click of a crossbow cocking carrying faint on the night air.

Gouge waited, still as stone, until the man had all but closed the distance before striking for the throat. It ended before it began — no cry, no struggle, the body folding backward and away from the

others without so much as a thud reaching the ground below.

Gouge searched the corpse with the same unhurried efficiency he'd used to kill it — a purse of coin, a ring of keys, a hobgoblin badge, a crossbow, and, odd among the rest, a flat steel disc stamped with a skull and some grim motto about the fleeting nature of life.

"Cheerful sort," Gouge said, pocketing it.

Beyond the tower door lay a stairway down into the fortress proper, and a corridor leading toward what the commander had called the inner sanctum — the most likely place, if anywhere, to find Fairwind or whatever remained of his loyal men.

"What lies through there?" Paul asked, studying the passage.

A long, fortified hall answered him, columned, twenty-five feet across, arrow slits lining one wall and all of them facing out toward the battle at the gate. Some twenty hobgoblins stood posted along it, every eye fixed on the fighting below, none turned toward the shadows behind them.

"Twenty's too many to take quietly," Jude said.

"Then we march," Gouge decided. "Disguises on, heads down, like reinforcements running late."

"I'll take point," Tyrus said. "I'm built enough like their bigger sort to sell it."

"I'll flank you," Folsom offered.

"I'll stay small and unremarkable near the back," Jude said.

"I'll take the rear," Paul said.

They fell into rough marching order and started down the hall at a brisk, purposeful clip, boots striking stone in a rhythm meant to say *sent for, in a hurry, nothing to remark on*. Halfway down, one of the hobgoblins turned and studied them a beat too long.

Tyrus waved him off without breaking stride, pointing back toward the gate as though ordering the man back to his post — and his sheer size did the rest of the work, the hobgoblin muttering something low in his own tongue before turning back to the wall.

They walked the full hundred fifty feet of that corridor, past twenty armed and watchful strangers, and no alarm rose to meet them. At the far end, the passage opened toward the deeper forti-

fications of the Helm — further into the fortress than any of them had yet set foot, with whatever waited for them there still unseen ahead.

PART FIVE: INTO THE HELM

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The Council Room

The door to the inner sanctum stood ahead of them now, two guards posted before it — one of them in a breastplate like their own borrowed gear, marked with a red badge of office that set him apart from the rest.

Folsom studied the distance, judged it at thirty feet, and let a small working of charm slip loose toward the officer as they closed the gap, walking with the easy, unhurried confidence of a man who owned the ground beneath him.

The guard's eyes drifted over the approaching party, caught for a moment on Folsom, and something in his bearing softened — not quite trust, but the absence of alarm. He said something in Hobgoblin that needed no translation to understand as a challenge.

Folsom walked straight up to him without answering it directly, close enough to crowd the man's space, and tipped his head back toward Tyrus — looming and silent at the head of the party, every inch the ranking brute. "Pardon my general," he said in Common, low and dismissive. "His throat's raw; he'll not thank you for making him use it." Already he was reaching for the ring of keys taken off the corpse on the wall above.

"Why do you speak like a human?" the guard muttered, baffled, more to himself than to Folsom. "We are not among them—" He caught himself, shrugged the confusion off as not worth pursuing, and asked instead, plainer: "Why are you here?"

The rest of the party filed past while the guard's attention stayed fixed on Folsom, walking with the loose, unbothered gait of men who belonged wherever they were standing.

"Important business," Folsom said, as though the answer bored him.

"Are you speaking on behalf of the Toli?" the guard asked.

"As it happens," Folsom said, without missing a beat.

The name settled the matter. "He outranks me," the guard muttered, and waved them through, stepping aside from the door to let them pass.

They passed inside and set the bar down behind them, sealing off whatever might come from the corridor they'd left. The chamber beyond ran some twenty-five feet before opening onto a second barred door, and beyond that, Merrick judged from what little he could see through the gap, lay the inner sanctum proper — a place none of them had ever set foot before.

"If Fairwind's men are holed up in here with only this much standing guard," Merrick murmured, low, "that's not going to hold against fifty men, if it comes to that."

"Does this look worse for him the deeper we go?" Folsom asked.

"That's exactly what I'm thinking," Merrick said. "And that hobgoblin guard said Toli, plain as day — and we saw the Toli ourselves, on that ship."

The second door, when they reached it, gave beneath the key with a low groan, opening just enough to make one thing plain beyond any doubt: whatever the inner sanctum had once been, it was compromised now. Voices carried through the gap — low, unhurried, deep in conversation.

"Don't move," Folsom breathed. "Someone needs to listen first."

"My little scout can do it," Paul said, drawing the small clay lizard from beneath his cloak and setting it low near the crack beneath the door, where it crept forward with visible reluctance before slipping through.

He sent it on along the shadowed edge of the wall, and fell into a listening trance, watching through its borrowed eyes as it crept toward the sound of voices — down a passage, a turn, another turn, following the sound to what could only be a council chamber, a great table before it carved in the likeness of the three outer isles —

Flotsom, Jetsom, and Fairwind — the kind of room where admirals gathered to plot the movement of ships and men.

And there, seated at its head, was Lord Fairwind himself.

"Don't trouble yourselves," Paul heard him say through the scout's ears, addressing two figures across the table. "They'll never breach the defenses here. Your hobgoblins can hold them indefinitely. If you believe this little assault of theirs will succeed — it won't."

"We're not worried," one of the two answered — pale, white-haired, unmistakably Toli even at a glance. "We've taken most of what we need from the caves below, in any case. It seems, Lord Fairwind, you kept rather more of the compound for yourself than our arrangement allowed. We'll have the rest before we're through, and carry it home to Cain Toli's island."

"Our arrangement still stands, then," Fairwind said. "You'll vouch for me before the council — press Jeon into granting me a fairer share of what his trade brings in from the other nations."

"Of course," the Toli said. "You'll be well compensated. Once the pressure on Jeon has served its purpose, everything returns to how it was. We'll return every barrel of the — pest control, shall we call it — and you may go about your business undisturbed. Until then, it stays with us."

Paul came back to himself slowly, the trance releasing him by degrees, the words still echoing. The compound. The pale yellow powder from the hidden room in Monmurg — could it be one and the same? He had no proof, no barrel in hand to point to, only what that room had left him: his mother's voice from boyhood, sharp over the three-marked barrels, that breathing even a little of it would kill him; and the letters he had since read, between her and his father, describing a weapon that killed the sahaugin outright and poisoned the very water against them. The same used a hundred fifty years past in the old wars, bought at cost from the Duke of Berghof because no one in the sea principalities had ever learned to make it themselves. His father had tried, and failed.

Most of Monmurg believed the island's protection came of some

ancient enchantment, not a sack of poison sprinkled into the tide — a secret buried deep, and whether to let that belief stand or break it pressed on him now with sudden, uncomfortable weight.

He decided quickly enough. Whatever the compound's true nature, that was a secret worth keeping close — his uncle would want it kept close, given how thin a thread it hung by, tied as it was to a single foreign supplier. But Fairwind's dealings with the Toli were another matter entirely, and those he meant to report in full. The man was sitting not thirty feet away, trading in his own people's defense like a merchant haggling over spoiled grain.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

Blood in the Sanctum

"We've found him," Paul said, coming fully back to himself, voice pitched low with something between triumph and dread. "Fairwind. He's in there, talking with the Toli right now."

"What do they look like?" Jude asked. "Pale — casters, or blades?"

"No armor," Paul said. "Swords, daggers. Could be either."

A hobgoblin stood posted across the passage ahead, a corridor branching down and to the left beyond him. Paul eased his homunculus in closer for a better vantage, the little creature creeping unnoticed along the wall's edge, and the guard, sensing something at the periphery of his attention, nearly turned to look — until Jude, with a murmured cantrip, threw a small scrape of sound down the far passage, and the hobgoblin's focus went after it instead.

"I want Fairwind alive, if we can manage it," Jude murmured. "Whatever else happens."

Paul and Jude signaled the strike together — a coordinated shot, dagger and bolt aimed as one at the unsuspecting guard. Jude's struck true and deep; Paul's deflected harmlessly off the man's armor. It was enough regardless. The hobgoblin cried out once in his own tongue and went down bleeding, and from somewhere deeper in the chamber, shouting answered the sound.

"Push forward, or hold?" Tyrus asked, blade already coming up.

They took their positions fast — Gouge at the front, Tyrus and the others close behind, Paul and Jude covering from range, Merrick flanking wide.

"Who goes there? Identify yourselves!" a voice called from within, sharp with authority.

"Sorry, sir," Gouge called back, pitching his voice to pass for the fallen guard. "Wasn't feeling well — took a turn, went down. I'm all right now."

The act bought nothing. "We have Lord Fairwind here," the voice answered — unhurried and unfooled, no hobgoblin's at all. "Attack carelessly, and you'll kill him yourselves. State your names."

"Don't harm our lord!" Jude called, loud enough to carry through the door — then dropped his voice for the others alone. "If they've truly got him bound in there, they'll open his throat the moment this turns — and we need him breathing, whatever else he's done."

"Don't spend your worry on him," Paul said, and the hard edge in his voice startled even him. "That binding's a performance. He heard us at the doors and had them truss him up, so we'd take him for a hostage worth sparing — a lord to bargain over. I watched him through the scout moments before, selling the city's own defense across that table for a fatter cut of Jeon's trade. He's no captive in there. He's a traitor who reckoned every life this island guards — ours among them — coin he could spend."

"Show yourselves first," the voice demanded.

"You first," Jude said.

A hobgoblin edged around the corner instead, hand-crossbow rising, and loosed a bolt at Jude, who twisted aside at the last instant and took only a graze for his trouble.

The fight that followed came fast and ugly. Two figures stood among the hobgoblins who could only be the Toli — pale, fair-haired, unarmored, moving with the fluid ease of trained blades. Gouge closed on the nearer of them, a rapier answering his cutlass in a fast exchange that neither landed cleanly at first. Paul slipped in behind Gouge's shoulder and buried his dagger where the man's guard couldn't reach — a killer's strike, sure of exactly where to aim.

The second Toli gave ground before Tyrus, then threw out a hand and snarled a word, and a lash of force cracked across the room that no mere swordsman had any business loosing.

"They're casters — both of them," Jude called, the warning rippling through the others as they adjusted. "Blades and spells at once. Watch for it."

After that it was attrition. Merrick took a hobgoblin's blade across the arm before he could put an arrow through its throat; Tyrus weathered two heavy blows without breaking, Folsom lending healing where it was needed most, while Gouge and Paul ground their Toli down between cutlass and dagger until the man swayed on the edge of collapse.

Jude drew a burst of fire tight enough to spare his own and loosed it at the two Toli where the fight had pressed them close. One threw up some trick of resistance or ward and the flame guttered harmlessly around him — but the other was a beat too slow, and it caught him full, Merrick's arrow following close behind to drop Gouge and Paul's man to his knees, all but finished.

"Grapple the caster! Don't let him cast again!" Merrick shouted.

A clean strike from Paul finished the kneeling Toli for good. The last of them — beaten, out of tricks, his ward spent — broke for the door rather than stand and die.

"Not happening," Gouge said, and between him and Tyrus they ran the man down before he'd gone more than a few steps, pinning him fast.

"Take him alive," Tyrus called, and switched from blade to fist, landing two solid blows in place of a killing stroke until the man dropped — unconscious, not dead.

They stripped him where he lay, tearing strips from his own fine silk shirt to bind his wrists, and Gouge shoved him against the wall the moment he began to stir.

"Grubby hands," the Toli said, sneering, the instant he found his voice again, "ruining a perfectly good shirt."

"Shut up, you filthy pig," Gouge said, unmoved, and the man only looked back at him, entirely unbothered by the insult.

It was Tyrus who found the side room a moment later — a table, and beside it, bound to a chair and gagged, Lord Fairwind himself.

“Good thing he’s gagged,” Tyrus observed dryly, and went to see the last of the fight properly finished.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

The Prisoner's Bargain

They turned the chair to face them, Fairwind still bound to it as they'd found him, and worked the gag loose from his mouth so the man could speak — Paul keeping his crossbow trained on him all the while, a precaution more than a threat.

"A precaution, I take it," Fairwind said, eyeing the bolt with cool good humor. "I've no intention of attacking."

Even trussed to a chair with the ruin of a fight around him, the man carried the room. Tyrus had gone straight-backed, the way a soldier does before rank; Folsom, who could charm a lord himself, watched this one with a deference that surprised even him; and Merrick — who trusted almost no one — felt the edge come off his own hostility despite himself, some countryman's instinct that a lord of the isles was owed a hearing. Gouge felt none of it, and let it show. Paul, who had watched the man sell his own city an hour past, felt less than none. Jude simply did not care.

"Fairwind, you're under arrest by order of Prince Jeon," Paul said, flat and formal. "I'm here as his representative. You've committed treason."

"Paul Revero." A flicker of recognition surfaced as Fairwind studied him. "You were beneath my notice, last I knew of you — yet here you stand, carrying a prince's authority as though you were born to it. It suits you. And Merrick — good to find a steady man among them. No one has served these waters, or the isles, more faithfully than you; so you of all people understand — a man may be true to the Hold and still stand against Monmurg's overreach. I'm no traitor to the islands, whatever they've told you.

Are you truly going to allow this?"

Merrick hesitated a beat too long. "These are Lord Jamis's orders," he said at last, "and Prince Jeon's. Under suspicion of treason."

"Suspicion." Fairwind let the word sit, unhurried. "You can see well enough I'm already your prisoner. I could order my own men to cooperate, if you'd only—"

"Where are they?" Paul cut in. "Your garrison. What did you do with them?"

"Moved them somewhere they'd not be harmed. Not cells, exactly." A mild smile. "You misunderstand the whole of this, gentlemen. There is a dispute among the princes of the sea principalities — a conversation, several of us party to it. It seems Jeon neglected to brief his nephew."

"It sounds," Paul said, "as though you've sided with the Toli against us."

"I've been allied with Port Toli for hundreds of years, as have all the outer isles — equal partners in this nation's decisions, same as Jeon. If I choose to side with them against Monmurg, that is my right to exercise."

"Not any longer. Not in this company." Paul held the man's gaze. "You're a prisoner accused of treason, and I mean to see you before the courts of the principalities."

Something colder moved beneath the courtesy, and Fairwind's eyes settled on Paul. "They've handed you a little authority, and already it's gone to your head, boy. You'll regret this."

For a breath Paul faltered. A lifetime of being no one — the scarred nephew kept at the edge of every room — rose up against the man's easy certainty, and the threat found the old doubt and leaned on it.

Gouge came back from prowling the exits and set a hand on Fairwind's shoulder, unhurried, his bulk sliding between the lord and the boy. "Keep your mouth shut."

"You'll not silence me in my own keep — I am a prince of the Hold, and I'll—" Fairwind's easy assurance thinned under Gouge's

flat, unhurried stare, and the words lost their footing and trailed away to nothing.

"I've Toli trash enough to deal with," Gouge said, speaking over the last of it, "without adding you to the pile."

Paul pressed while the man was off balance. "The sahaugin, then. How do we drive them from these waters?"

For the first time the performance thinned. "I can't make them simply vanish," Fairwind said. "But the old protection can be restored. There's a powder — copper and sulfur, an alchemical thing and no spell at all — poison to the shark-folk, sprinkled into the water around the island. That is how the principalities have held them off a hundred and fifty years, whatever the world believes of enchantments. One barrel secures ten square miles of water for ten days." His mouth thinned. "And the Toli are carrying our supply off even now. It's already aboard the ship."

"We've seen the barrels loaded," Paul said. "What's left?"

"Little enough. For months I moved what I could to Fairwind Island, to a place only I know; the Toli have taken the rest to the Sea Ghost. What remains is staged below, by the water caves." Fairwind spoke with the patience of a man explaining the obvious to children. "And before your elf suggests it — burn that ship and you lose the very thing worth saving. Aged in seawater, the barrels take fire badly."

Across the room Jude, who had been studying the great map carved into the council table — the cove, the water caves, the ship's likely berth among them — shut his mouth on whatever he'd meant to offer.

Paul turned to his own, pitching his voice to carry over the charm he could all but see settling on them. "Hear me, all of you. Fairwind's case is for the princes to weigh, later and properly. What's ours tonight is the sahaugin and this island. He's a traitor who counted every life here as coin — there are two hundred Marines dead in that bay already to prove it. Don't let the fine manners tell you otherwise."

Tyrus shifted, plainly ill at ease to hear a lord spoken of so. Mer-

rick said nothing. Gouge nodded once.

Gouge drew Paul a half-step aside, his voice low but not so low the others missed it. "He's a hundred and fifty men of his own somewhere on this rock, caged or not. If he calls out and they learn he's alive, this gets a great deal harder. We get him off the island quiet — I'd sooner hand him to Jamis whole than wring him out here." His eyes flicked to Tyrus and Merrick. "And mark it: he's got half of ours half-charmed already. Lord's manners on a traitor. Don't let it cost us."

"I'd already seen it," Paul said. "It won't."

The plan came together quickly enough. Down to the water caves for whatever barrels remained; then the smaller ferry that ran between shore and the Sea Ghost — the one presently in the cove — seized and turned for Monmurg, and the signal tower lit on the way if they could reach it, to bring the city's relief. The great ship they left to itself; the Sea Ghost was Cain Toli's own, hundreds of hobgoblins and his hand-picked guard, and no work for six.

Fairwind heard it out with the calm of a man holding a card he had not yet played. "You'll not leave this island alive," he said quietly, "unless I allow it. I'd need lift no hand — only let the sahaugin have you. But guide you to what remains, I will; it seems I keep a bargaining chip yet." He inclined his head, unbothered. "You'd have killed me already if you meant to. Let's not pretend we treat as equals — we don't. But I'll not grovel for it either."

"No one asked you to," Gouge said. "Don't take that for mercy — I could have you on your knees quick enough, if it came to it. It's only that we've no time to waste on it." He got Fairwind to his feet, a hand still on his shoulder. "You'll walk us down; we'll hood you where the way allows. Come along, then, friend. Best of friends, you and I."

Fairwind took the menace without a flinch. "There are hobgoblins in the upper shafts — not on the road we'll take. And sahaugin in the water caves near the stores. Carry the powder through, and it kills or drives off whatever we pass; you'll need to go near them regardless, for the last barrels are staged close to the caves."

"Your men," Gouge said. "Not locked away, you claimed."

"On the lower level, bolted in from without, hobgoblins on the passage — no key needed, and none in my hands. Caged, for all that." He said it without shame. "The ones you walked past on your way in were mine — moved to the barracks, disarmed."

It was gone three by Gouge's reckoning, and the far lighthouse had never been truly held, only fainted at. Whatever they meant to do, they would do it in the little dark that was left.

"Then take us down," Gouge said. It was not a question.

"Yes." Something eased in the man's face, and was as quickly mastered. "Let's go."

They fell into order — Gouge and Tyrus flanking Fairwind, Paul close at hand, the bound Toli hauled along by his bonds, Jude carrying light enough to see by. At the head of the stairwell Fairwind paused.

"The only way down," he said. "Fine. I'll take you to the veils, as it were."

And they began their descent, a spiral stair turning into the dark beneath the Helm.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

What Folsom Learned

The spiral stair gave out at last onto a rickety wooden walk — no bridge and no rail, only planks pinned to the rock, running out over a chasm that dropped away black beneath their boots. Somewhere far below, water moved: an underground river threading the roots of the Helm. The path went down with it, turning and doubling back on itself as it went, three hundred slow yards winding into a dark that gave back only the scuff of their own steps and, now and then, a whisper from the shapes ahead, pitched too low to catch.

Near the front Gouge and Tyrus went with their lantern hooded to a sliver, reading the boards by hand — there was torchlight somewhere far below, and forms that crossed it, and it fell to the two of them to find whatever waited there before it found the rest of them. Jude kept the gagged Toli in hand; Merrick held the rear, his ranger's ear bent to the dark behind them and the moving water below. Which left Fairwind. With Gouge wanted at the front and every other man to his task, the guarding of the bound lord fell to Folsom — a hand on the man's arm to steady him down the treacherous walk, and the prisoner, for the length of the descent, his to mind.

It suited Folsom well enough — better than well. He was a bard before he was a Marine or anything else, and a bard lives on the tales he can carry out of places like this; and here at the end of his own hand walked a prince of the isles, a lord, the greatest man Folsom had ever come near enough to speak with plainly. There were songs in a man like that, he was certain of it — histories, secrets, the shape of how the great ones lived and schemed — and he wanted them

the way he wanted every good story he had ever chased. He had no notion yet what he was about to be handed; he knew only that he had never once had a chance like it. So he fell in close, in the shuffle of the descent, near enough to Fairwind to risk a quiet word — and as he did, he let a thread of his own gift slip into it, the same warmth that had turned a hundred hostile rooms friendly, winding it gently about the bound lord. It took hold easily. A charmed man's guard comes down, and his tongue comes down with it.

And the pull, if Folsom was honest, ran both ways. For all his own easy charm, there was something in Fairwind — the unhurried certainty, a lordship worn like a second skin even in bonds — that he found himself leaning toward despite everything, half of a mind already to think well of him.

"Can we whisper?" he asked. "In case anyone's near."

"What is your name, boy?" Fairwind asked, ignoring the question and answering it all at once — the words pitched low, a murmur meant for Folsom alone.

"Folsom. Marine bard, for what that's worth." He hesitated, half in wonder. "And you're — you're truly Lord Fairwind?"

"I am. You seem a decent young man. Why have you fallen in with these cutthroats?"

"Following orders," Folsom said. "I was put on this mission by my commander."

"Orders." Fairwind turned that over. "I wish I might speak with Paul Revero alone, when this is settled — do you think it could be arranged?"

"I don't see why not."

"Perhaps once we're through this." Folsom's charm had done its quiet work in him, and Fairwind spoke now with the easy confidence of a man among friends. "You should know something, before it's too late to matter — Prince Jeon is being betrayed, by one of his own greatest advisors. You know the name Lord Jamis?"

"I know the name," Folsom said. "Never met the man myself — he's a good way above me."

"A powerful man — more than most below him ever guess. Do

you know he's kept contact with agents of Keoland?"

"I didn't know that."

"Do you know his wife?"

"I couldn't say I do."

"Lady Jamis, she goes by now — but Azane was the name she was born to. Her brother is Lord Zafar Azane, a high noble of Keoland, loyal directly to the Duke of Gradsul. You know the Duke?"

"I'm sure I don't."

"The most powerful lord in Keoland," Fairwind said, "and the sea principalities' oldest enemy. His navy is the one blockading Monmurg this very moment. And Zafar Azane is Lord Jamis's own wife's brother."

"That's not the best news I've heard today," Folsom admitted.

"You didn't know it, did you." There was no triumph in it, only a settled certainty. "It's not common knowledge — though I make a point of watching such things. Zafar has come to Jamis's castle several times these past months. The Azane are Suel — scheming bred into the whole line of them, Keoland to the bone. Jamis himself is Oeridian; I'd have named him an honest man once. But that wife of his is Azane through and through, and I believe she's drawn him into the Duke's service by degrees — a traitor now, whether he ever set out to be one or not."

And that was the unnerving part of it, Folsom thought. Fairwind did not speak like a man telling a lie. He spoke like a man reporting a truth he had carried a long while — the conviction gone deep and quiet in him, worn smooth with handling. Whether a word of it was so, the lord plainly believed the whole; and a naive corner of Folsom, the part that could not make a picture of a prince of the isles selling his own people to the enemy, found it easier by the moment to believe the man than the charge against him.

"Jamis?" Folsom said, working through it.

"Yes. Do you know this Gouge, the one leading all of you?"

"A day, perhaps. No more."

"One of Jamis's own assassins. He's killed a great many people — not a kind man; vicious, in truth. The elf is the same, another

of Jamis's creatures, both of them well-practiced in whatever dark work the man has needed done." Fairwind's voice softened, turning almost fatherly. "It would go badly for you, if I were killed and you found yourself innocent in all this. Badly for your companions too — most of them innocent as well, I'd wager. That large, honest fellow — Tyrus. And Merrick, whom I know myself, and know for an honorable man. None of you truly grasps what's at stake here."

"I appreciate the consideration," Folsom said, and found he meant it more than he'd expected to.

"Good men of the principalities shouldn't be dragged into the quarrels of princes," Fairwind went on. "And Paul Revero — I hope he knows what he's doing, bringing you all into this. I believe he means loyalty to his uncle, nothing worse. What I'd ask of you is only this: do what you can to help him survive his time with Gouge and the wizard."

"Absolutely," Folsom said.

"There's so much I'd ask, given everything you've just told me," Folsom admitted, "though I don't know you, nor you me. But we are men of the sea, both of us."

"I'll do everything in my power to see you survive this," Fairwind said, "so that you might be properly questioned, in time."

"I'm not so sure I'll be the one facing questions."

"Understand me. You will survive, if I have any say in it — you and your companions both. Gouge I can't speak for; I believe him Jamis's man, the elf as well — but if you don't resist, you'll come through whole. And know this: if I don't survive what's coming, carry word to my family of what I've told you. Tell Paul Revero of my concern as well — that I believe Lord Jamis a traitor, in league with Zafar Azane, who leads the Office of Forbidden Magic in Gradsul. Little of this may mean much to you now, but understand: there are secret orders of wizards whose whole purpose is the ruin of this principality."

"I understand," Folsom said, quiet now. He did not, not truly — half the names were fog to him, the wizards and the offices and the Duke only shapes moving in it. But two things had come clear

all the same. The first was that Fairwind was laying a heavy thing across his shoulders: a lord's last testament, near enough, pressed on a bard he'd known the length of a staircase as though the two of them were old friends — and Folsom understood, dimly, that it was his own charm doing that, loosening the man toward him. The second was worse, and the charm had no part in it. Whatever the truth of any of it, Fairwind believed every word. No man spoke of the ruin of his own principality like this — earnest, unhurried, afraid — unless he had come to believe it down to the bone. And it was the belief, not the facts, that Folsom found he could not set aside. "These are dangerous times," he said.

"And the course I'm taking, I take for the survival of all of you," Fairwind said. "I know we're no friends, not truly, not yet — but I promise you can come through this, and be dealt with fairly after."

"I appreciate your honesty," Folsom said. "And your concern."

"No," Fairwind said. "Thank you. For reversing your witness against me, if it comes to that."

And Folsom, who had reversed nothing and promised nothing outright, found he could not quite bring himself to say so.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Into the Caverns

While Folsom talked quietly to Fairwind near the back of the line, the rest of the descent went in tense, careful silence — down the long rickety walk above the unseen river, deeper into a dark that gave back only the scuff of boots and, now and then, the far, indistinct whisper of voices no one could quite place.

Then, rounding a turn, torchlight showed ahead — a hundred feet off, marking the mouth of some chamber, and a figure crossed briefly through it before vanishing into the passage beyond.

“We should let the others know,” Tyrus murmured.

“I’ll go ahead,” Gouge said, and Tyrus covered his lantern with his shield as Gouge crept forward alone, feeling his way by touch along the wall in the total dark — slower than any pace he’d have chosen, testing each board with his foot before trusting his weight to it.

Behind him, in the confined stone, the others’ hushed voices carried further than any of them meant them to. Gouge pressed on regardless, and the dark swallowed him whole — whatever he crept close enough to find up there by the torchlight, the others were left to guess at, waiting on his word for it.

He was a long while returning. When at last he came feeling his way back along the platform, his footing slipped at the edge and he began to go over toward the black water below — before Tyrus’s hand closed hard around his arm and hauled him back onto solid planking.

Somewhere far below, something surfaced — a tail slapping the water, a sound only Merrick’s ear caught, and knew at once for what

it was.

"Something's down there," Merrick murmured, straining to listen. He held the rear, close enough to the water below to catch what the others could not; ahead of him Jude kept the gagged Toli in hand, the prisoner stumbling along at the wizard's side.

"There's something we need to talk about," he told the others quietly, drawing them back within earshot. "There's something big in the water — I heard a tail slap against the surface."

"How did you hear it and we didn't?" Tyrus asked.

"Ranger's ear, that's all. Doesn't matter — it's maybe thirty feet below us now, and we've been descending toward it the whole while." He studied the dark water as best he could, drawing on everything he knew of the sea, and made out at last a shape moving beneath the surface — something built along the lines of a shark, but far larger than any shark had a right to be, patrolling a slow loop through a channel wide enough, here, to swallow it whole.

"How big?" Tyrus asked.

"Forty feet, near enough."

"That's a massive creature."

"And it's not noticed us," Merrick said. "Just patrolling."

Gouge, still shaking off the fall, cut through the murmuring, low and hard, and put it to Tyrus. "There's men on ahead — I got close enough to be sure of that much, no more. We keep moving regardless. If it comes to a fight, whoever reaches a barrel first cracks it and gets the powder into the water — sprinkle it, dump it, whatever it takes. It's either going to work, or we're all finished, Fairwind included. In that case, I'd suggest pushing him in first."

"Understandable," Tyrus said, and turned to Fairwind, bound and helpless behind them. "Any magic dust in your pockets, by chance?"

"In my pockets? No," Fairwind said, dry. "It's in the barrels you're all so eager to reach — which is rather the whole of the point, is it not?"

"Long as the creature stays in the water and doesn't come crawling out on legs," Tyrus said, "I'm not overly worried."

"It's a shark, not one of the shark-folk," Merrick said. "A beast, not a soldier — it hasn't the legs to come up onto the boards after us, nor the wit to try. It stays in the water." He said it with a seaman's certainty, though the truth was he had only ever heard such things spoken of by old fishermen — beasts forty feet long, able to cut a man clean in two — and had never once laid eyes on one until tonight.

They pressed on in careful, deliberate silence, Gouge creeping ahead alone once more despite every attempt to rein him in — "Gouge does Gouge, I guess," Tyrus muttered, with the weary resignation of a man who'd already given up trying. And Folsom, even as he walked Fairwind down at the back of the line, spared the wit to reach Tyrus up ahead — a whispered thread of his magic carried straight into the big man's mind.

Normally I'd have a joke ready for this, the message ran, in Folsom's voice, carried the same way Folsom always got a man's attention across a crowded room. *Not this time. There's a forty-foot shark directly beneath us — one of the sahaugin's own, by the look of it. We're all of us standing near water it could reach in a heartbeat. Move faster if you can, or at the very least, don't fall in.*

"Don't have to tell me twice," Tyrus murmured, and pressed forward with rather more care than before.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Voices in the Dark

Gouge crept the platform's length alone, one hand trailing the wall, testing each board with painstaking care despite the noise carrying from behind him — hushed, urgent whispers that echoed further through the caverns than he'd have liked. He reached the edge of the torchlight's reach and held there, in the last true shadow before the light would betray him outright, and listened.

Two voices, unmistakably human, speaking Common — though not what they said. Not hobgoblins, whoever they were. He held a long moment, confirmed no one followed, and turned to make his way back.

He nearly walked onto Tyrus in the black — the big man waiting at the edge of hearing, so still and silent that Gouge had his own dagger half-drawn before the shape ahead resolved into a friend.

"Why'd you pull that?" Tyrus murmured.

"Didn't know it was you," Gouge admitted, and slid it home again.

"Humans, up ahead," Gouge said, low and urgent. "Two of them, talking — Common, not hobgoblin. Couldn't make out the words."

"Let's get off this platform," Tyrus said. "If we go over the edge here, we go in right where it's patrolling."

They gathered the rest and pressed on, Gouge taking point again near the torchlight, watching the passage ahead through the flickering glow — until, without warning, a voice rolled out of the dark toward them, echoing off the stone.

"Who's there?"

Folsom seized Fairwind by the arm. "Do you know these men?"

"Yes," Fairwind said.

"Speak for us, then. Please."

"It would benefit you," Fairwind said, weighing it, "if I spoke for you — and for Merrick."

Jude set the tip of his wand against the gagged Toli's ear. "You'll speak for us," he told Fairwind, quiet and cold, "or I paint the wall with this one — and leave you to answer to Cain Toli for the loss."

"Just tell them it's you," Folsom pressed, shoving him a step toward the dark. "'This is Lord Fairwind.' That, and nothing more."

Fairwind raised his voice, calling out toward the dark ahead. "It is I—" And then, breaking from whatever script Folsom had hoped for, his voice rose sharp and clear, carrying every bit as far as he could throw it: "I am being held prisoner, by agents of Lord Jamis! Cover your minds!"

The warning rang off the stone in every direction at once.

"Go, go!" Gouge shouted, already moving. "Off the boards — rush them, take the fight to solid ground!"

Jude's answer came without hesitation — the wand still at the gagged Toli's ear, a burst of pure force loosed point-blank that dropped the prisoner dead where he knelt and pitched the body off the edge, down into the black water below, before the echo of Fairwind's warning had finished dying against the walls. Jude had promised as much; Fairwind had chosen for him.

For a long, ringing moment, nothing else moved. Then the caverns erupted into motion on every side, and the fight that had been building since the moment they'd descended those stairs finally broke wide open.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

The Chasm Fight

A guard rose ahead of Gouge, shield already up — and Tyrus, with no room on the narrow walk to push past to the front, threw his voice down the passage instead. “Give us passage, or your lord dies!” he shouted — more threat than promise, though Folsom’s dagger at Fairwind’s throat lent it weight enough.

Merrick, firing from the deep shadow at the back where no enemy eye could find him, put an arrow into the nearest guard with the ease of a man shooting at something that couldn’t shoot back. “Under attack!” the guard cried, and the alarm spread through whatever chamber lay ahead.

Folsom fought to keep the prisoner pinned — the dagger at his throat more to hold him than from any wish to use it — but it was Paul who undid it. Trying to slip past on the narrow ledge to reach the fighting ahead, he drew even with Fairwind, and the lord’s boot hooked his leg and swept it out from under him.

Paul went over before anyone could catch him, down toward the black water and the pale shape of the Toli’s corpse already floating in it.

That was all it took. Folsom’s eyes went after Paul for half a heartbeat — and in that half-heartbeat Fairwind snapped his head up under the bard’s jaw, a short, stunning crack that knocked Folsom’s grip loose and his wits sideways, and tore free of him.

He did not run for the dark. He ran forward — straight at Tyrus, whose back was to him, the big man set on the planking between Fairwind and Gouge at the front — and brought his bound fists down on the back of Tyrus’s skull, a clubbing blow that dropped

the big man to one knee, stunned, though not out.

Jude's answer was quick and wild: a bolt of fire loosed at Fairwind's back that streaked past his head and burst against the far stone, no more than singeing him.

Gouge turned from the guards at the sound of Tyrus going down, and found Fairwind already on him — the charm long since shaken off, no purpose left in the man now but escape. What followed was no contest of skill but of leverage, two men grappling on planking that punished a single wrong step. "I've got this bastard right beside me," Gouge said, getting his arms locked around him and hauling him toward the edge.

Fairwind fought it, and spat a last taunt as he went — "Come to Fairwind Island, and perhaps I'll share what I've hidden there." He looked back once at the long drop.

"Go drink with the fish, then," Gouge said, and threw him over.

The splash carried up from thirty feet below, and for a moment nothing else happened. Then, further out in the dark water, something surfaced — a violent thrash, a shape rising and dragging something under before the water stilled again. Whether it had been Fairwind or some other unlucky soul caught in the current, no one watching from above could say for certain.

Tyrus, the daze clearing, pushed on toward an open doorway ahead, readying a burst of righteous fury for whatever waited there, and found two guards in breastplates rounding the corner to meet him, swords already drawn.

"Jude!" he called out, even as he engaged them. "Get to Paul — pull him out of that water!"

Jude was already moving, casting his sight across the dark surface below with the clarity only elven eyes could offer in such blackness, and found Paul there, flailing weakly, something unseen brushing past his leg in the current. The spell caught him and lifted him clear in a single smooth pull, twenty feet up out of the water in an instant, hanging now above the platform with the rest of the climb still ahead of him.

The fight at the doorway ground on in the meantime. Tyrus had

drawn one of the two guards — a particularly skilled one, plainly his better with a blade — and the man beat through his guard and knocked the longsword clean from his hand, the next stroke already rising to finish the disarmed paladin. Before it could fall, Gouge whipped a hand axe from his belt and flung it over Tyrus's shoulder; it clipped the guard's helm and bit into his ear — no clean kill, but enough to stagger him off the killing blow.

Gouge came in on the pair of them then, dagger and cutlass working together — a clean stroke that opened one guard's throat, and a hard thrust into the second that left the man badly wounded but still on his feet. Wounded or no, the guard swung low to sweep Gouge's legs from under him — and missed, the blade hissing past a hand's breadth short.

Tyrus finished it in his own fashion. With his sword still on the floor where it had fallen, he snatched the dagger from his belt and drove it twice into the standing guard's gut — no swordsman's flourish, just a big man ending a fight with whatever came to hand — and the guard staggered back against the wall and folded.

In the sudden quiet that followed, they turned to finish getting Paul out. He still hung where the spell had left him — lifted clear of the black water, but stranded out over the drop, for Jude's working was a lift and nothing more: straight up, and not an inch sideways. Jude took the weight of him again and drew him in by slow, careful degrees, easing him toward the ledge until Gouge and Tyrus could lean out, catch hold, and haul him the last stretch in over solid stone — soaked, shaken, spitting river-water, but alive.

"Look for Fairwind!" Paul called out, the moment he had breath enough to shout it, and the cry went up from more than one throat at once, echoing uselessly into the dark water below.

Nothing answered. No sign of the man surfaced, not then, and not in the long minutes that followed while they searched the black water by whatever light they could manage — until, further along the current, something pale drifted into view.

An arm. Nothing more attached to it, no other feature to mark whose it had been.

"I don't care whose arm it is," Jude said, when the argument over it flared briefly among them, "if someone's bleeding to death down there—"

"It matters," Paul said, "because either we're still chasing Fairwind, or he's already dead and this tells us nothing worth chasing at all."

Jude nodded once, and without a word raised his hand and set a small working of light on the floating limb, close enough now to make the markings out clearly.

Toli. Not Fairwind's arm at all.

"Then he might still be alive," Paul said, a flicker of relief in it, though relief was hardly the right word for what still lay ahead of them.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

The Poison Sea

"We need to keep moving," Tyrus said, watching the water darken with movement below. "We've got to reach those barrels."

They pressed on, deeper into the cavern system, until the passage opened without warning into a vast grotto — five hundred feet across if it was an inch, wide enough that a proper ship might have sailed into it whole. A wooden walkway descended from the platform where they stood down to a landing far below, docks visible in the gloom, and mounted on a ledge overlooking it all, a ballista — a siege weapon, plainly meant to cover anyone approaching from the water.

No ship rode at the docks below, but tents stood there, and beside them, a stack of barrels waiting to be moved.

"That ballista wants turning on the barrels," Tyrus decided. "Not to wreck the stores — only to crack one open near the water and let the current do the rest. It'll take two to work it: one to load, one to loose."

"Jude and I have it," Merrick said, and the two of them made for the ledge and the great siege weapon mounted on it. A bow and a ballista both in play would tell for more than two men doubled on the one — so Merrick kept to the bow he was surest with and left the ballista to Jude, and the high ground gave them both a clean line on the passage behind besides, for anything still coming out of the chasm: Fairwind, the sahaugin, whatever else the night had left to spend.

Jude took the great weapon's cord, Merrick loading for him between shots of his own bow, and between the siege bolt and the

ranger's arrows they had the black water and the stacked barrels below well covered.

The rest went down — Tyrus, Gouge, Paul, and Folsom — along the long wooden walkway toward the landing and the barrels waiting on it, the dawn still an hour off and the cave lit only by scattered, guttering torches. They reached the beach proper, and the water answered their arrival almost at once — pale shapes breaking the surface near the barrels, three sahaugin rising from the shallows in a rush.

“Right by the barrels,” Gouge said, grim.

The ballista spoke first, Jude's aim true enough to skewer one creature clean through and lodge the bolt in a second body behind it — a devastating opening blow that dropped the first outright and left the second reeling. Merrick, loosing from the platform above, put an arrow into a third before the fighting on the beach had properly begun.

Folsom's voice cut in next — a mocking verse flung at the nearest sahaugin that left it staggering, rattled and off-balance, easy prey for the crossbow bolt Paul put through it a moment later.

From the ledge above, Jude held the fire he might have loosed, biding for a tighter cluster before he spent it, while Merrick's arrow struck the creature nearest Tyrus with a force that nearly finished it outright. Gouge closed on a wounded sahaugin and ended it with cutlass and dagger together, a blade across the throat and a second through the eye, and turned to find another already closing on him in its place.

“I want a barrel,” Tyrus said, and bulled his way to the stack — shouldering bodily through the sahaugin packed thick between him and it, shoving one clear with his shield and trampling past another, taking a raking blow across the ribs for the trouble but breaking through regardless, dropping his own sword and shield to heave one of the heavy casks up into his arms and stagger with it toward the waterline.

The sahaugin pressed their advantage as Tyrus struggled toward the water, sensing blood and closing in, until Folsom

dashed in and ran the nearest one through with his rapier.

"That's a kill, bard — keep 'em coming," Gouge called, even as he fought to keep his feet against the sahaugin pressing him, the wounds already gathering across his arms.

Jude, judging his line at eighty feet and finding it enough, loosed the fire he had been holding — a bloom of flame he shaped with an evoker's care to spare the men below while it caught the three remaining sahaugin square. Two died outright, incinerated where they stood; the third, catching only the edge of it, collapsed into the shallows regardless, badly burned and finished a moment later by Merrick's arrow.

Tyrus reached the water at last and pummeled the barrel open with his bare fists, no weapon free for the work, and the head of it gave way to reveal a pale yellow powder that carried the faint, unmistakable stink of sulfur.

"Gods," he muttered, flinging the contents wide across the shallows, "we could've set this whole cave alight without meaning to, this entire time." He heaved what was left of the barrel out into deeper water for good measure, dousing himself in the doing of it — his own skin, where the powder had touched it, shifting slowly toward a sickly greenish yellow.

The last wounded sahaugin lunged at him with spear and claw both and missed on every count, and a moment later let out a strange, wet cough, blood and water bubbling from its gills before it collapsed face-first into the poisoned shallows and did not move again.

Paul finished the last standing sahaugin with a dagger driven home while it was still reeling from the powder's effect, and then there was nothing left to fight — only the four of them standing on the beach, watching the water for further movement.

It came, in its own way, ten seconds later. A bloated shape surfaced first, then another, then dozens more scattered across the open water of the grotto — sahaugin corpses by the score, forty or fifty of them at least, and among them the massive carcass of the great shark itself, floating belly-up in the tide.

"That's the same one from before?" Gouge asked, studying its size.

"Looks to be," Merrick said, reading the water. All told — the shark and the shark-folk both — far more dead drifted there than had ever reached the beach: a host that would have overwhelmed them entirely, had it come at them at once instead of in the scattered handful that actually had.

Paul caught Tyrus's arm, sharp with alarm. "Don't breathe it — not any of it." The powder was still dusting off him where it had dried, and Paul knew with a cold certainty exactly what a lungful would do; his mother's voice came back to him, sharp over three red-marked barrels a lifetime ago: "Breathing in even a minute amount of that will kill you." He kept that part to himself. "It's far deadlier to the gilled things — but it'll take a man down just the same if he draws it in. Wash every trace of it off, keep it clear of your mouth and eyes, and for the Gods' sake don't breathe the dust."

"I should wash this off," Tyrus agreed, eyeing his own discolored skin, and turned to see it done — quickly now.

"Any sign of Fairwind, among all that?" Paul asked, scanning the drifting bodies.

No sign of him surfaced. Whatever had become of Lord Fairwind, the poisoned water gave no answer, and the grotto settled slowly back into silence around them — the barrels secured, the sahaugin driven from these waters for what might yet prove to be a very long while, and the fate of the man who had once ruled this island still, for now, an open question.

PART SIX: ESCAPE FROM HELM ISLAND

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

What Fire and Iron Decide

The party had gathered on the docks by then, the fight behind them and the grotto's dead settling slowly beneath the surface, and the talk had already turned from recovery to reckoning. Paul counted the barrels twice to be certain — twenty-five, stacked and waiting — while Gouge went hunting through his gear for a flask of red-eye and Tyrus searched the tents pitched near the water's edge. They gave up their answer quickly: a staging ground, weapons and armor matching what the hobgoblins had carried, plainly where the enemy had geared up before ever setting foot on the island proper.

"The ship's going to come back," Gouge said, low and certain, "and we have to be ready to take it when it does."

It came down to timing, then. They could not linger — not with twenty-five barrels sitting exposed on the beach for the taking — but neither could they afford to be caught hauling them when the Sea Ghost returned. Paul wanted the barrels moved up by the ballista while there was time; Jude shook his head. "If the ship comes and we're still carrying barrels, we lose the only advantage we've got. Load the ballista, post a bowman, and cover this beach from above." Gouge had already sighted along the great weapon: its arc could reach the water approach as easily as the docks. The dead floating in the shallows they left where they were — anyone coming by daylight would see them regardless.

"Well," Paul said, frustration breaking through as he looked out over the grotto, "we've lost Fairwind entirely. Do we burn the bridge behind us and be done with it?"

Tyrus turned the larger question over aloud. Without Fairwind

to chase, they could hold this ground from the high vantage and use the time properly — strip what remained of the stockpile, destroy what they couldn't carry, and free Fairwind's locked-away troops, a hundred and fifty men shut in unarmed rather than truly imprisoned. Kill the guards set over them, and the island itself might be held.

"The whole island?" Paul said. "We've barely cleared this stretch of it."

"One barrel does the job for the better part of a week — Fairwind said as much himself," Tyrus said. "We overdid it, dumping what we did into this one cove. Spread thin and rationed, twenty-five could hold the whole approach a good fifty days — long enough, certainly, to summon reinforcement from Monmurg."

The likelier reason the garrison would turn came clear as he talked it through. Fairwind's outer men had never known of his treachery — they'd trusted the party readily enough once they understood it spoke for Prince Jeon — and a proud man like Fairwind would never have looped his own household guard into a scheme like this. That was why they'd found those Marines shut behind a bolted door rather than had to cut through them; the dead on the sand at their feet were the exception, the few he'd trusted enough to keep close.

"So he meant to hand over the barrels and let the blame land elsewhere," Paul said, working it through. Tyrus wasn't buying the softer read, and he worked through why aloud — as much to settle it in his own mind as to bring the rest of them round. "Think on how we found him. Sitting free — unbound, no gag — back when he was first overheard bargaining with the Toli. The ropes and the gag only went on once boots sounded in the corridor. That's no prisoner. That's a man playing one." The certainty hardened in him as he said it. "He's in it to the neck — and likely working both ends at once, meaning to shortchange the Toli even as he sold out Jeon."

Folsom turned it over and said nothing. He did not quite doubt Tyrus; he only kept remembering the man he'd walked down that stair himself — courtly, unhurried, certain of his own goodness —

and could not lay that face cleanly over the traitor the others named so readily. He kept the reservation to himself, but he did not nod along either.

"Undercutting Monmurg while keeping a hand in every pot," Paul admitted, "letting the rest of the principalities tear at each other while he slips clear with the profit."

"He walks away either way," Tyrus said. "The Toli in there with him are already dead, and sitting here weighing his motives buys us nothing."

They took stock instead — who could still fight, and what remained to fight with. Jude had little left in him: a single working of any real weight, and whatever cantrips still answered. Merrick was worse off than he let on; Folsom claimed himself fit; Tyrus shrugged off his own wounds. Against the outer garrison and whatever held the keep — call it three hundred, all told — and Cain Toli still somewhere out there with the Sea Ghost, they would manage nothing until they knew the numbers they truly faced.

They weighed the alternatives and let them fall away one at a time. Burning the bridge behind them would only strand them on the wrong side of it as surely as it slowed anyone coming. Hauling the barrels off to some hiding place tempted Jude — "Given an hour," he said, "I could raise a floating disk of force and carry the lot of it out myself" — but he talked himself out of it in the same breath. "We don't know this island well enough yet to trust any hole we'd put it in. Whoever comes looking will find it, given time enough."

So they fixed on the simpler course: hold this ground. The sa-haugin were no longer any threat — the poisoned water had seen to that — and the only danger left worth the name would come by sea, under sail. They would haul the barrels up to the vantage and lay the ballista on the water, ready to hole any ship that stood in for the cove before it ever reached the docks. Turned in its cradle, the great weapon proved fully adjustable, able to cover the narrow stair they'd come down by as readily as the open approach — one man at a time forced through it. Not a wall, but a very costly door.

Even the boldest plan carried a flaw, and Jude named it: if Fair-

wind surfaced somewhere unlooked-for, would his men follow him over strangers wearing borrowed loyalty?

"Then one of us kills him," Tyrus said simply, "if it comes to that."

"Hopefully not in front of his own troops," Jude said.

They settled, in the end, on a short rest — an hour, no more — with Folsom's fife lending its own quiet measure of healing to whoever needed it most. Merrick came back from it nearly whole; Folsom, untouched by the fighting himself, played on regardless, filling the cove with something gentler than the violence that had so lately filled it. Jude rose from the hour all but restored.

"Keep what's left for the others," he told Folsom, when the bard offered to share the last of the healing. "I've enough in me for what I mean to do."

"You want company?"

"No," Jude said. "I'll go alone."

He cast invisibility over himself and slipped away without further ceremony, bound for wherever Fairwind might have gone — the outer garrison, if he'd made the beach; the inner troops, if he'd somehow slipped back inside; or nowhere at all, if the water had already claimed him.

CHAPTER FORTY

The Empty Racks

Morning of the third of Wealsun found Jude retracing his own steps up from the grotto, invisible and alone, moving slow and careful along the ledge, watching the stone floor for anything the water might have left behind. No dripping trail marked the passage back the way he'd come — no sign that Fairwind, if he'd survived that fall, had hauled himself out anywhere along this stretch.

He reached the stair and considered the lower levels, the barracks, the armory, before recalling there was only the one route through — the chamber where they'd fought the Toli, no side passages branching off it anywhere he'd seen. That left the climb upward, toward the inner sanctum, and the bar still sitting fast across its door exactly as they'd left it, sealed from the inside by their own hands hours before.

He unbarred it and stepped through into the familiar hush of the council chamber — the dead hobgoblin still slumped where he'd fallen, the dead Toli beside him, neither disturbed. The stone around both bodies lay dry, untouched since they'd sealed the room. Whatever had happened to Fairwind, he hadn't come back through here.

Jude eased the outer door open next and looked out on the passage beyond — hobgoblins still posted along it, the same troops they'd slipped past on the way in. He drew the door shut again without a sound, invisible as he was, and barred it once more behind him rather than risk contact.

He turned instead to the two rooms he hadn't yet searched — a library of sorts on one side, records and almanacs and old trade

charts, nothing that spoke to sorcery or secrets; a council room on the other, the map-table where they'd first overheard Fairwind's voice. Nothing else led anywhere. This inner sanctum sat sealed off from the rest of the keep entirely, built more like a lord's private tower than any proper fortress wing.

From the council room's window he could see clean across the island: the force that had feinted against the gate the night before — the diversion meant to draw the defenders' eyes while the small party went over the wall — had already pulled back, its work done, no sense spending men on an assault no one had ever meant to press. The library's window looked the other way, out to sea, and there, where a ship had ridden at anchor when they'd first climbed these stairs, the water sat empty. The Sea Ghost was gone.

Thirty minutes, he judged, turning the timing over. Long enough for a strong swimmer to make the distance from shore, even through waters that had lately held sharks — though those same sharks, he reasoned, would have scattered the moment that first barrel went into the grotto, drawn off by the reek of the compound rather than toward any struggling man in the current.

He left the library as he'd found it and made his way back down, checking the floor at every turn for water that wasn't there, until he reached the one passage he hadn't yet explored — a barred gate, standing open, leading into a wider cavern system beyond. He slipped through.

Racks lined the walls inside, empty now, stretching back further than he could easily judge — space enough, by the look of it, to have held tens of thousands of barrels in better days. Whatever this place had once been, it had served as the island's great warehouse, and someone had been quietly emptying it long before this night's chaos had ever begun. Here too the floor was dry, unmarked by any man come dripping from the sea.

Beyond the racks, a second tunnel opened onto a second barred door — this one locked fast, no key at hand to open it. Through its grate, though, morning light spilled in from a small cove beyond, sand pale in the new sun, and there, unmistakable even at a dis-

tance, footprints crossed the beach.

He studied them as long as the grate allowed him to, but there was nothing more to learn from their outline alone — only the confirmation that someone had come this way, and gone. He turned back at last, retracing the full length of the passage, and made his way toward the others to report what he'd found, and hadn't.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

What the Shark Gave Up

While Jude searched, Merrick turned his attention to the carcass floating in the grotto — the great forty-foot shark, belly-up now, and drifting a little way off the ledge. To bring it in he loaded the ballista, made a length of rope fast to one end of the bolt, and put the shot deep into the carcass; then he worked the rope hand over hand, hauling the massive body in against its own dead weight until it rode close enough against the ledge to climb aboard.

Two-thirds of the bulk sat submerged even now, but what remained above the waterline was mass enough to stand on, and Merrick set his feet against the pale, ruined belly and began to cut — carefully, enough to open a passage into the creature's interior without so weakening the whole that it might sink beneath him.

The anatomy proved rougher going than any ordinary shark he'd dressed before, the hide thicker, the proportions all wrong for anything he'd trained on, but the work went forward regardless, and after a long while he began drawing the contents out into the cave light, one grim discovery at a time.

A head came free first — half of one, rather: pale hair, sharp Toli features ruined down one side, the skull blown open where Jude's point-blank blast had caught him. It was the prisoner Jude had put down on the plank bridge and tipped into the black water; the current had carried him this far, and the shark had done the rest. One arm was gone at the shoulder — torn away, Merrick judged, the very limb that had drifted up in the chasm and set them arguing over whether it was Fairwind's. He set the head aside without ceremony and kept working.

Half an hour passed in that slow, reeking work, the rest of what the beast had swallowed surfacing piece by piece, tossed overboard as it came free. No sign of Fairwind turned up among it — only, near the very end, a shirt far too large and fine to have belonged to anyone still living on this island, which gave Merrick a moment's pause before he cast that overboard as well.

Down at the beach, meanwhile, Gouge weighed the wreckage of the tents more than he worked it — canvas and lumber, the makings of something that might, with enough charity, be called a raft. He was only turning the possibility over, one option among several: could this island's leavings carry six people and whatever barrels they judged worth saving out past the tide and home to Monmurg? He thought they might. The tide would do most of the work — the currents ran strong through this stretch, in and out with the hours — and a raft riding that outgoing pull needed little more than a paddle and a scrap of sail. And they had Merrick, who could read water like a page and coax a poor craft through the worst of it; if anyone could see six of them across five hours of open sea on a heap of lashed lumber, it was him.

What gnawed at Gouge was the Sea Ghost. A raft was a fine thing for empty water and a plain death trap if Cain Toli's ship stood between them and Monmurg — no speed to run from it, no deck to fight from, the lot of them riding low and slow with barrels lashed across the boards. An option, then. Not yet a plan.

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

Watch the Waves

Jude returned a little before eight that morning, dropping his invisibility as he crossed back to where Gouge stood waiting.

"Where did you go?" Gouge asked, some sharpness in it.

"Up to the inner sanctum — to see whether Fairwind had doubled back through it."

"We'd barred that door behind us," Gouge said.

"I needed time to think — and to be sure of things." He gave it to Gouge short as they walked: the empty racks, the barred door onto the little cove and the footprints in the sand beyond it, no wet trail anywhere to say Fairwind had come back through the sanctum. "But here's the part that matters. The Sea Ghost is gone — not anchored where she lay, not anywhere I could see from the heights. And the feint at the front gate is finished; our people drew off once it had done its work, and the hobgoblins it had pulled to the wall have gone back to garrison."

That last was what made the difference, and both of them felt it. It was the fear that had gnawed at Gouge over the raft timbers — a raft was a death trap if the Sea Ghost stood between them and Monmurg. With Cain Toli's ship gone from the water, that danger went with it, and nothing was left to command the strait between here and home. The way was open.

Gouge turned the rest of it over in his own way. He had what Jamis had sent him for, or the heart of it: the truth of Fairwind laid bare, the treachery no longer suspicion but fact, and that much he would carry back and set before Jamis plainly, as was his charge. It should have sat better with him than it did. But he had held the man

in his own two hands at the lip of that drop and let the water take him rather than his blade, and he could not yet call Fairwind dead — not with only a fine shirt in a shark's belly and a line of footprints in the sand for proof. It nagged at him the way any unfinished thing did; he did not like leaving a man such as that alive behind him.

"I doubt he swam clear out to the Sea Ghost, if that's what's eating you," Jude said, as if he'd caught some of it off Gouge's face. "That's a long haul of open water — too far, I'd think, for any man to make under his own power, sailor or not, sharks or no sharks. Those footprints in the cove are the likelier story."

"No," Gouge said. "But I'd sooner have known."

They found Merrick down among the tents, sail rigged from canvas that had lately kept the rain off hobgoblin heads, and the raft itself taking shape plank by plank under Gouge's direction.

"What's all this?" Jude asked, eyeing the construction.

"Getting us home," Gouge said. "I'll send Folsom up to the sanctum to signal Monmurg — on our way, watch the waves. Should meet us partway if the winds favor us. Five hours, maybe less."

"And the sharks?" Jude asked.

"We're bringing enough of the barrel powder to keep them off," Gouge said. "That's our whole ticket through open water."

"My concern's the same as yours," Jude admitted. "I don't care what else is happening on the rest of this island right now — there's a hundred messes we could chase down here, but the only sensible course is getting back, reporting what we've learned, and letting Jamis decide the rest from there."

"That's the whole of what we're doing," Gouge said.

They gave the work two hours in all — Merrick lashing the sail, Gouge and Folsom tearing free what lumber the docks would spare, Tyrus lending what strength he had between naps, still mending. Twenty-five barrels sat counted on the sand; only four would make the crossing, the raft judged too slight to carry more without risking the whole venture. Twenty-one would stay behind, enough — barely — to hold this stretch of shoreline against the sahaugin's return until reinforcement arrived to make the count matter less.

Before they launched, Folsom climbed to the inner sanctum, the dead hobgoblin and the dead Toli still lying undisturbed where they'd fallen, and worked the signal lantern at the window with the practiced hand of a man who'd learned the art properly — "On our way. Watch the waves," and then Gouge's name, spelled out letter by letter across the strait toward a city he could not see but trusted was watching all the same.

They loaded the raft at last — Tyrus carried down bodily and settled to finish his rest aboard it, Gouge taking a rope-lashed hobgoblin corpse in tow as proof of what had happened here, Merrick working the crude sail while the outgoing tide caught the hull and drew it clear of the cave mouth.

"Keep sprinkling the powder as we go," Gouge said, cracking one of the four barrels loose and working handfuls of the pale yellow dust into the wake behind them at intervals. "Worth more than gold to us right now."

"And still just as ready to catch fire, given the chance," Jude reminded him, and Gouge only grinned at that, unbothered.

The crossing ran a full hour before the island fell properly behind them, the raft holding a slow but steady mile-an-hour pace under Merrick's sail, the tide doing the rest of the work. Another hour on, past ten in the morning by then, three corsairs broke the horizon ahead, cutting out from Monmurg's harbor toward them.

"Finally," Jude said, something in his shoulders easing for the first time since the fighting had ended.

Half an hour more brought the first corsair alongside, and willing hands hauled the six of them — and the barrels, and the grim, roped proof of a dead hobgoblin — up onto her deck. Merrick gave the account to her captain in broad strokes: the sahaugin, the fighting, the island reclaimed in part and still contested in the rest. No word passed to the ordinary crew of what the yellow powder truly was, or why it mattered as much as it did — that account, all of them agreed without needing to say so aloud, belonged to Lord Jamis alone.

"Back to Monmurg," Gouge told the captain, when the question

of course came. "Send the other two on to the island — the cove we cleared is secure, but the Helm itself still needs retaking, and our people at the barracks need reinforcing."

The captain gave the order, and two corsairs peeled away toward Helm Island, full of Marines bound for whatever remained to be done there, while the third turned her bow toward home, carrying six exhausted, salt-crusted survivors and four barrels of a secret that had already cost more lives than any of them yet fully understood.

Some way into the voyage, once the island had shrunk to a smudge astern, Merrick found Gouge at the rail and held out a book — worn, its edges salt-swollen, plainly older than either of them. "Off the shelves in the lord's sanctum. I've been through the first of it; you ought to have the rest."

Gouge turned it over without much interest. "I'm no great reader."

"Read this one. Admiral Flotsom set it down fifty years back — what that yellow powder truly is, and why it matters as much as it does. More than any of us knew, going in." Merrick nodded back the way they'd come, toward the water they'd poisoned to win clear of it. "If Jamis means to have the whole of it out of us, best one of us understands what we've been carrying."

Gouge weighed the book a moment, then tucked it under his arm. He had the hours for it now, if nothing else.

PART SEVEN: DEBRIEFING IN MONMURG

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

What Gouge Told Jamis

Evening found the corsair docked, and the party scattered to separate summonses before they'd so much as washed the salt from their skin. Paul and Jude were led up toward the Royal Palace and Prince Jeon's own offices; Gouge and Merrick were taken instead to the Harbor District, to the chambers where Jamis conducted the quieter half of his business. Tyrus and Folsom answered a summons of another sort entirely — the Marine barracks in the same district, and the undeniable draw of camaraderie and revelry that follows a victory.

Jamis wished to speak with Gouge and Merrick each apart, and Gouge went first.

He knew the room well enough to help himself without asking — crossed straight to the sideboard, poured from the cheapest bottle in reach, and settled into the chair across from Jamis's desk — though he sat with less ease than the room and the drink might have lent him, a burr of shame in him yet for the one job he'd left half-done: Fairwind, loose and alive somewhere, when the man should have died on his blade.

"Report," Jamis said, without preamble.

"Paul made it back safely," Gouge said, leading with the good news — the one clean thing he had, set down first to cushion the self-doubt he'd have to come to.

"Thank you for that." Something in Jamis's bearing eased, fractionally, at the words.

"Barely," Gouge admitted, "but safely."

"Was his performance in question?"

Gouge turned the glass in his hand, weighing his answer. "He's got a proud streak to him — fair enough, given who he is. Overall he did well. Interesting young man, gaining experience fast. Whether that chip on his shoulder wears down with more time in the field, I couldn't say for certain."

"I think it will," Jamis said.

"I'd agree — a few more hard knocks ought to chisel it down. I didn't push him too hard, this time, given you had me watching him as much as fighting alongside him. I expect I can work him harder next time, now I know what he can take."

"Was there conflict between the two of you?"

"None. He seemed respectable to me, and I'll take that. He had insight into events out there worth reporting — though understand, everything we have of Fairwind dealing with the Toli rests on Paul's word alone. He watched the whole of it through that clay creature of his, the homunculus, from another room; no other eye was on it. Witchcraft or no, I believed every word he gave me of it: Fairwind was dealing with the Toli, and gave up the island."

Jamis sat with that a moment, saying nothing — a suspicion he'd carried a long while come home at last as fact, and little comfort in the confirming of it.

Gouge watched it land. When he spoke it was half to himself. "There was more going on out there than even you'd braced for, sending us in — the sahaugin were a part of it, unwitting though they were: strip the warding and the shark-folk come, and their coming was half the design." He gave the barest shrug. "And Prince Jeon's own view of what was happening struck me as too lax by half, sending only one company — slow to name Fairwind's dealings the treason they are — though I don't care to overstep my bounds, saying so of the Prince."

"No mystery in that," Jamis said, folding his hands before him. "Jeon and Fairwind are, in truth, very good friends. He wouldn't wish to think ill of the man. That's simply how it is, Gouge. My own eye has to stay entirely objective in these matters — I've watched Fairwind closely some while now, his jealousy of Prince Jeon, of

Monmurg's prosperity generally. There are ongoing negotiations between the Toli and the outer princes, and Fairwind's the most outspoken among them. Jeon's inclined to give him some part of what he wants — certain outcomes he means to see in this country, and he's willing to spend real weight at court chasing them. Personally, I don't think the unity he's after is worth the cost of it. Jeon's an idealist — that's the trouble in him. The other princes of the outer isles are nothing of the sort; put to the choice, they'll take personal gain over loyalty every time."

Gouge set his glass down and gave the fuller account — the landing near the southern beacon, the thirty men put ashore, the bridge tower taken and held, the standstill against the hobgoblins garrisoning the barracks beyond it. The push north with Merrick to the Helm's own barracks, the garrison commander there, the secret entrance they'd learned of but never used. The diversion that let them circle to the Helm's blind side. The strange Onwallian ship, eastern in its lines, loading barrels from a skiff that came and went beneath the fortress.

"The Sea Ghost," Jamis said, before Gouge had finished naming it. "I've had reports of a ship by that name — Cain Toli's. Bought from Onwal; not common construction for us, though our own yards are beginning to copy the lines. Purchased specifically by him, I believe."

"That fits — the Toli were aboard her." Gouge went on: the climb into the Helm itself, the hobgoblins holding it under the same diversion, the creep to the inner sanctum, Fairwind found at last through the eyes of Paul's homunculus. "He was in there dealing with the Toli — not under any duress that Paul could see. Making an active bargain with them. We caused enough of a ruckus getting in that we engaged them all at once — killed one Toli, took a second alive, and took Fairwind himself, bound and tied, not at all pleased about it. Demanded to know why."

"And what did you have to go on to suspect him, besides Paul's account?"

"That's the whole of it," Gouge admitted. "No one else

witnessed the conversation directly — only Paul, through that creature's eyes. Fairwind tried to play it off once we reached him — tied up, claiming he'd been forced into it. We believe he'd bound himself, to make it look that way, rather than being taken by force."

He laid out the rest — the passage down through the smuggling caves, the barrels of granular substance, not spell nor enchanted fog but a manufactured compound, sprinkled into the water to keep the sahaugin at bay. The Toli hauling it away by the shipload. Fairwind's admission of his own private stash, kept back at his own keep, even as the rest of the island's stores were stripped bare. The dead Toli prisoner, killed in the scramble and dumped into shark-crowded water; the confirmation, later, of an arm floating free. Fairwind's own fall from the ledge, thrown loose in the chaos, gone without a trace once the search was done.

"So Fairwind directly attacked Paul Revero?" Jamis asked, something sharpening in his voice at that.

"He tripped him in the struggle but I wouldn't call it a direct attack — Fairwind was cordial enough to speak with, arrogant as ever, conversed with me readily. Said something like, 'I've got information, I've got a role to play here — I'm no captive in this.' Very unhappy about being dragged back against his will. He admitted to the barrels outright."

"So he did remove them from Helm Island?" Jamis asked.

"Yes, at least some of them. I believe he was lying to cover the rest — denied being in league with the Toli on it, though we had to weigh that against Paul's own account, given he's Jeon's nephew, and frankly I don't think the lad's skilled enough yet to be part of anything that calculated against Fairwind, even as a noble."

"That thought crossed my mind as well," Jamis said.

"You sent me to watch him, so I wasn't working off assumptions. I don't think he needs an agent watching for betrayal — his general attitude might give that impression more than any real evidence does, but I sense nothing genuinely wrong there."

"With Fairwind, though," Jamis said, something colder settling over his face, "I believe there is something. He's clearly up to more

than we understand yet. Why strip the island's protection at a time like this, with the blockade already cutting off supplies to Monmurg — and no apparent concern for it?"

Gouge finished the account as plainly as he'd begun it — the fall into the chasm, Jude's levitation pulling Paul clear before the sharks could reach him, the search that turned up no trace of Fairwind but soft footprints on a passage leading east. "Jude scouted that himself, under invisibility, while we readied to leave. We couldn't bring Fairwind back for proper questioning in the end — I don't know how that would have gone politically, frankly, keeping him prisoner and bringing the matter to you. In the end we didn't have him to worry over either way. We sprinkled what we could on the way out, and Merrick built us a raft that got us home in one piece — fine work, that."

"The Navy men with you were quite capable too, from what I understand," Jamis said. "They told me you came back with twenty-three barrels."

"Someone miscounted, then," Gouge said. "Four came back on the raft. Twenty-one we left on the island — twenty-five found in all."

"Four and twenty-one." Jamis turned that over.

"Twenty-one still out there, then," Gouge said. "I never told the crews precisely what the substance was, or how it works — whether the ones sent back to the island were briefed on its use, or simply told to use it, I couldn't say. Nor who ended up minding what we left behind. It wasn't me."

Gouge finished his glass. "To summarize my own part — I protected Paul, and observed what I could. He saw considerably more directly, and no one else can independently verify the conversation between the Toli and Fairwind, or confirm he wasn't simply bound the whole time as he claimed. We're going entirely on Paul's word for that. If Jeon sent him with instructions not to reveal too much, he seemed angry and on edge enough that he may have exposed more than intended, confronting Fairwind directly. I read that as more genuine than Fairwind's calm denials — a young man who couldn't

hold back his anger struck me as more honest, in the moment, than practiced deception would look.”

“The simple fact that Fairwind admitted to removing barrels from Helm Island at all is telling enough,” Jamis said. “That substance, and its dwindling supply, is one of our most closely guarded state secrets. His admission suggests he transferred at least some of it to Fairwind Island itself.”

“As I said, Fairwind admitted as much in his own words — a personal stash there,” Gouge confirmed, “and seemed content to let the Toli take the rest. Suggests he’s looking chiefly to his own island’s interests just now.”

Jamis rose and paced a slow turn behind his desk before he spoke again, and when he did it was less a briefing than a man thinking aloud in the one room where he could afford to. “A hundred and fifty years ago the sea principalities formed as a single body — an alliance between the Duke of Berghof and the pirates of the outer islands. You know what drove them to it?”

“The sahaugin,” Gouge said.

“The sahaugin. Kingdoms of them in those days — one vast enough to rule the Azure Sea from a stronghold north of our own coast, raiding everything from here to the Dragon Isles to Redshore to Monmurg’s own harbor. The trade we live on now would have been unthinkable under them; they were the true lords of these waters.” He stopped at the window, and for a moment said nothing.

“There’s a book Merrick carried back from the inner sanctum — I read it on the crossing,” Gouge said. “Admiral Flotsom’s, written fifty years past, a warning. It sets down how thoroughly the shark-folk gutted the undersea world in their day, and how the yellow powder was the one thing that ever broke them — nothing else the principalities tried had so much as slowed them. Flotsom wrote it around the time the Duke of Berghof first stopped selling it to us — and warned that a day would come when the sahaugin returned.” He turned the glass in his hand. “Why’d Berghof stop?”

“Claimed it was no longer needed.” Jamis’s mouth thinned. “We held a vast reserve on the Helm by then, the outer isles their own

stores besides. There is a great fortress, in the middle of the bay to the north — it holds the greatest concentration of the substance anywhere, and it was the staging ground for the whole war. Ships sailed out and dumped barrels of it over the cities of the sahaugin, season on season.” He was quiet a moment. “It did not take long. Hundreds of thousands of them died, a hundred and fifty years gone — and that slaughter is what let this nation prosper after. I don’t tell it proudly. But I’d have you understand what the powder is, and what it bought, before you hear the rest of what troubles me.”

Gouge said nothing, which was its own kind of answer, and let him go on.

“Keoland benefitted from the good of our work and later turned it against us — once we were a nation, once there was profit in the quarrel. Because the powder doesn’t stop at the sahaugin. It strips a reach of sea clean of everything — fish, wildlife, the very floor of it. Keoland’s diplomats convinced the elves and the other peoples of the Ulek states that our methods were butchery — and they were not wrong. We drew back to salting Monmurg’s own waters and a handful of strategic points, no more — enough to keep the shark-folk from creeping home.”

“And now even that’s failing,” Gouge said.

“Now even that’s failing.” He said it as though the words had weight he’d rather not lift. “This past decade the supply’s dwindled so far we’ve cut back even that little salting, and it’s forced us to rethink our coastal defense entire — which is the whole of what we’ve been begging off the Duke of Berghof, who shows no interest in selling us another barrel. And then the lease lapsed on that same bay fortress, where most of what remained was held, and Cain Toli took the island outright. At first he honored our shipments. This past winter he cut us off cold — told us the Duke of Berghof had ordered it, that the outer islands were to have no more. The same winter Gradsul’s ships closed the blockade on Monmurg.” He turned back to face Gouge. “And there’s been word passing directly between the Duke and Prince Toli, which ought to be unheard of —

the Duke of Berghof is a famously secretive man, and he and Prince Toli have had nothing of consequence to do with each other in a hundred years. Tell me that's chance."

"Doesn't sound like chance."

"No." Something in him settled, having said it aloud and heard it come back. "It doesn't."

"Then who's making the stuff," Gouge asked, "if Berghof won't? Gradsul?"

"Not Gradsul, whatever they claim. They keep a grand Magical Academy — the Duke of Gradsul's own school of transmutation among them — and not one of their transmuters comes near the Duke of Berghof's own knowledge of how it's made. That knowledge is the whole game, and he holds it alone."

Gouge turned his empty glass in his hand. "Then here's what I don't follow. If the Toli can buy it straight off Berghof, why do they need Fairwind at all — why strip it off the Helm? And why would Fairwind help them?"

"There." Jamis pointed at him, almost grateful for the question. "That's near a provocation in itself, isn't it — which is why I keep worrying at his reasons more than his acts." He sat again. "Jealousy, I think, at the root of it for Fairwind. Of all the modern principalities, Monmurg's gained the most from the old alliance — the trade, the taxes, the wealth running through us, far past what raw piracy ever gave the others. I don't believe Fairwind sees himself as working against the principalities. I think he tells himself the reverse — that he stands with all of them, and that Monmurg is the one truly working against the rest."

"He say as much?"

"No. I'm putting words in his mouth." He allowed it readily, almost ruefully. "He's never shown much love for Monmurg, for all his years with Jeon. There's something colder under it — envy of what we've built, and a real quarrel with Jeon's leaning on him in council, both together."

He was quiet, and what came next came slower, as if he weighed whether he had the right to say it. "And — it costs me to be fair

to the man just now — his grievance isn't hollow. I think Berghof throttles our supply because of Jeon. Jeon means to end the slave trade out of the Amedio Jungle — he's pressed it for years, to stop the raiding of the jungle tribes for gold, for ivory, and above all for slaves. That trade is the bulk of Toli wealth. Take it from them and you take everything they are."

"And Berghof takes his cut of it," Gouge said.

"Berghof and the Toli both, too much to give up. They'll gamble the whole alliance to keep it — court the Duke of Gradsul himself, if that's what brings Jeon to heel." He pressed his fingers to his eyes. "Fairwind's argued in council for years that we oughtn't provoke Berghof over it. Reasonable enough, on its own. But this move of his puts every one of us in the fire, with Gradsul already winning ground against us. Cain Toli's the graver danger by a long way — his betrayal cuts deeper than anything Fairwind's about. Fairwind's only reaching for gold, near as I can tell. It's betrayal all the same, of the principalities and of Jeon, and I understand the wanting of it even where I'll not forgive it."

He turned the last of it over as much to himself as to Gouge. "What I can't yet measure is how deep the Toli have gone in with Gradsul in this war. Cain Toli, chiefly. A month and a half back a wizard came to our docks — you'll recall it; one of his people hired you and Karmirg to stand a watch."

"The Suel?" Gouge said — he had it now. "Lord Phranck, out of Keoland. His man hired Karmirg and me to stand a watch, aye."

"That's the one. What I wanted off him was what the Toli were after down the coast near Saltmarsh. It seems they've found something there — an artifact, I believe, that gives its holder command of the turtle dragons. Our losses at sea trace straight back to it. That does not leave this room."

Gouge sat forward at that.

"It has to be recovered, if there's any way to it, and Cain Toli's the hand behind it — I'm all but certain. It would explain a great deal. When our corsairs close with Keoland's warships, storms rise out of nowhere at a distance — the old sign of dragons near — and

soon after, a ship or two of ours simply isn't there anymore."

"I thought the dragons left us be."

"They do, ordinarily. We've paid them a yearly tribute out of mind to let our fleets pass — greedy things, but gold buys them, and they've no stomach for men; we're poor eating beside sahaugin, more like sardines to them." His face hardened. "But I believe Cain Toli's turning them on us now, on purpose — so much as I can piece from Lord Phranck and others who'd know."

"And the hobgoblins on the Helm," Gouge said. "Where'd he raise that many?"

"The Toli hire them by the shipload — mountain hobgoblins, out of the high country behind the Duchy of Berghof." Jamis's smile had no warmth in it. "Everything on that side of the water runs back to Berghof, one road or another. I've no doubt it was he who supplied the hobgoblins to the Toli."

He leaned back, spent. "Fairwind I take for something of a fool in all this — he doesn't see the depth of the game, nor how far it runs. But a fool's meddling can pull the roof down as surely as a traitor's. It can't be let alone."

"No," Gouge agreed. "It can't."

Jamis was quiet a moment, then gathered himself back from wherever the talking had carried him. "Enough for tonight, I think."

Gouge set his empty glass aside and rose. "Aye."

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

What Merrick Told Jamis

Merrick came in after Gouge, and Jamis cleared away the empty glass he had left before Merrick had even settled. "Ah, Merrick. Excuse the mess. So — what happened over there?"

Merrick gave his account plainly, and in the main it tallied with what Gouge had already laid out: the sahaugin returned in force, the corsair overrun, the landing on the south side and the fight for the tower, the climb into the Helm, and Fairwind found bound in his sanctum — accused, on the strength of Paul's homunculus and nothing else, of dealing with the Toli. Where he could add to it, he did. He had made it his charge, per Jamis's orders, not to let Paul out of his sight, and to keep Gouge to the plan.

"So you didn't witness the business between Fairwind and the Toli yourself," Jamis said.

"No. Only Paul's account, through that creature of his. Once I was in the room, though, Fairwind gave himself away well enough — defensive, going back and forth with Paul, and no innocent man in the way he fought us through the keep after. I watched him shove Folsom back, trip Paul into the water, and end grappling Gouge at the edge of the bridge — that was how he went in himself." He paused. "Jude killed the one Toli — put his wand to the man's ear on that bridge and finished him, tipped the body into the water. Fairwind I take for dead as well, thrown in as he was — though we were never able to find his body."

That much squared with Gouge — though where the others took Fairwind for drowned, Jamis did not. No body had surfaced, and there were the footprints in the cove; a man like that did not oblige

you by dying when a swim would serve him better.

Merrick pressed on to the powder — four barrels loaded onto the raft, one cracked open along the crossing to salt their wake, the twenty-one left waiting on the coast. “Five and twenty in all, near enough. I could carry no more; we knocked a raft together from what the shore gave up and got Paul home fast, per your orders. Staying would have left us sitting for the next thing to come — more sahaugin, more hobgoblins, another Toli ship.”

“Commendable work — everything I’d expect of you, and more.” Jamis folded his hands. “But say nothing of Fairwind’s part in this yet, to anyone, least of all his own men. I must speak with Paul, and with Prince Jeon, before any accusation is made — Jeon never believed the man capable of it. This is a matter between princes now.”

“There’s the question of my own neck,” Merrick said. “Fairwind knows my face and my name. Is my life in danger — assuming he’s alive — and does it trace back to you?”

“You’ve met him — served near him at the Helm, never under him. He knows you, and respects you, which helps. I doubt he’ll move against you; it wouldn’t serve a man pleading innocence. Do your duty, report to me and to Jeon, hold your tongue, and you’ll be fine.”

“As for the powder, I told the corsair crews nothing of what it was,” Merrick hesitated. “It’s a state secret. It needs to stay one.”

“It does. I’ll tell you this much, in honesty: scarcely five and twenty barrels to our name now, all told, the old stores here near spent and no new shipments coming. If our enemies knew that number, they’d know exactly how thin we’ve worn.” He waved it off. “The Toli don’t want the stuff for themselves — they want us without it. A bargaining chip, between Berghof and the Toli and Prince Jeon. Not yours to carry.”

“There’s still a keep full of hobgoblins out there,” Merrick said, “and we salted the water for a day or two at most. Our men are sitting ducks if help doesn’t reach them.”

“I’ll send corsairs. With your report and the barrels, we’ll have

the Helm back inside a day or two — it may even settle by parley. Those hobgoblins are Berghof's, kept in his mountains and hired out; decent soldiers, and no compunction about killing principality men, which keeps his own hand hidden. 'Just hobgoblins.'" His mouth thinned. "Cleaner for him than risking Oeridian troops, and better than Toli — slavers and scum, most of them, useless for real work."

They came at last to the men themselves, and here Jamis leaned in.

"Your read on Gouge?"

"Did what he was paid to do, and did it well. Followed your orders. I'll not turn my back to him — but on the water I trusted him."

"Trust him exactly that far. Gouge you can rely on, so long as you never cross him — he'll knife an enemy in the back, but an ally he'll warn first, before he does it." Jamis let that settle. "And keep clear of him in his cups."

"And Jude?"

Merrick took his time. "A great asset — I don't think we'd have come out alive without him. His levitation, his spellcraft, a quick and clever mind. Hotheaded, though, and a law unto himself. When we were spotted and badly exposed, he did what he judged he had to, and asked leave of no one. And he holds life cheap — kills without compunction when it serves him. That Toli on the bridge, bound and helpless, he put down without a second thought."

"There's my warning, then. Jude is entirely amoral. Effective as you say — but he holds no loyalty to you, nor to anyone. Only to himself and his own advancement, which is the leash I keep him on: favors, and the promise of more. Let him think he'll gain by it at your expense, and he'll take the advantage without a blink. I don't trust him, Merrick — not for a moment — and I'd not have you do so either."

"Then why let him so near Paul?"

"Jeon's doing. He has a genuine taste for the arcane, and Jude's

among the ablest wizards in the principalities — Jeon means him to tutor the boy. I argued against it; Jeon believes it Paul's best road, and that homunculus of his may prove Jeon right." His look sharpened. "This stays between us. I tell you only so you know where the ground is soft, should you find yourself among these men in the dark."

"Knowing what they are, while they don't know what I am to you," Merrick said. "That's an edge."

"It is."

"One thing more, then." Merrick frowned. "Folsom had Fairwind under his escort near the end — I saw the two of them talking, close, and not long after, Fairwind broke loose. I don't know what passed between them."

"Find out. Quietly. Whatever Folsom and Fairwind said to one another, I want it." Jamis turned then to what came next. "You'll not go back to the Helm. Your cousin Owen's returned from Redshore — ran goods past the blockade, cider and the like for the barracks, and turned a profit doing it. Find him in the Harbor District and ask what he's seen. I believe Redshore is where Gradsul is funneling the traders out of your part of the sea."

"Understood." Merrick hesitated. "One favor — a small measure of the powder for myself, if I'm about and run onto sahaugin. Just enough to buy my way clear of a bad spot."

"I'll see what can be spared. Not much, mind you."

Merrick thanked him and rose, turning over as he went the thought of Owen Black — once Navy, always drawn to profit, who had smuggled into Keoland before the blockade and smuggled food out of Redshore into a starving Monmurg since. Whether the man's loyalty ran deeper than his purse, Merrick couldn't yet say. Jamis seemed unbothered. Gradsul be damned, he had all but said — and Merrick found he couldn't disagree.

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

Cider at the Barracks

While Gouge and Merrick sat with Jamis, Tyrus and Folsom found themselves left to their own devices, and made straight for the barracks.

The Marine barracks in the Harbor District were livelier than either of them had seen in weeks by the time they reached it — men gathered outside with cups in hand, more cheerful than the season had any right to allow.

"These are all my men," Tyrus said, studying the crowd with something warm settling into his face. "Half my own unit's still out on the island, but these are still my people — men I know."

"A lot of them died, though," Folsom said, quieter.

"Not mine, specifically — but plenty of Marines did. Still people I know. Let's grab a drink before we hit the real bar properly."

"Agreed."

Tyrus clapped a hand on the shoulder of the nearest man, who turned with a mug already raised. "Folsom!" the Marine called out, delighted. "What's the occasion — Tyrus! Owen Black came back today, from Redshore — smuggled food back for the city. Brought a couple of barrels of cider too, good stuff, not watered down like everything's been these past weeks. You can actually get properly drunk on this."

"I would love that," Tyrus said.

"Go get yourselves one."

"Got to follow orders." As they crossed toward the counter, Tyrus filled Folsom in on the man, for he knew Owen Black well enough. "Merrick's kin. A Marine once, years back — too wild

for the uniform, though he left no disgrace on it; just had bigger ambitions than it allowed. Knows these waters better than near anyone alive. A pirate, near enough — a smuggler, more like, these days.” He grinned. “Good man, mind. But a great teller of tales. Enjoy the half that’s true, and don’t put coin on which half it is.”

“Sounds like half the men I’ve ever liked,” Folsom said.

They found him at the counter, holding court in the thick of some tale, a splint bound round his left arm and a fresh cup in the good hand. He had not been seen in these parts since winter — kept himself scarce, for reasons neither of them knew — but he was his usual self tonight: gregarious where Merrick ran serious, quick with a grin where his cousin ran duty-bound, and, by the flush on him, a good many cups deep already.

“Well, look at you!” He caught Tyrus by the arm and near spilled both their drinks. “Look at the size of this one. You know who’s to thank for all this, Tyrus? Me — Owen Black, who ran the only honest cider left in the city past the whole Keoland navy to get it here. A man ought to be good for something.” He was laughing at his own joke before he’d finished it.

What followed came in pieces over the next hour, the way everything came from Owen — half boast, half tale, and no telling where one left off and the truth began. Tyrus and Folsom caught it in snatches, between his rounds of the room and back.

Redshore, mostly. That was where the trade all sat now, he told them, and told them again — “the whole sea funneled into one whaling town, and not a dockmaster in it who knows his own arse from an anchor” — fifty merchant ships at anchor and none able to unload, merchants half-mad to sell at any price. “So I sail my little cutter in, buy off the desperate, sail her home. Food, oil, what the city actually wants. I don’t even double it on you boys — half again what I paid, no more. Doing my part.” He said that twice, doing my part, a hand to his chest each time.

“There’s opportunity in it,” he told Tyrus — three times at least, before the night was through. “Real opportunity, if you’re the sort that’s looking.”

"I'm always looking for ways to help Monmurg through this," Tyrus said.

"Ha — Marine golden-boy. Wouldn't run with a smuggler, would you?"

"It's not about running with a smuggler. It's helping Monmurg through the blockade. That's the whole of it, for me."

"Fair, fair. Respect that." And he was off again, to the next cup and the next knot of men, and back.

The arm, when Tyrus asked after it, set off the wildest telling of the night — Saltmarsh, two months gone, a job scouting for a certain Cain Toli; a gangly Toli cabin-boy under him then, who turned up weeks later three doors from where they stood and set on Owen in the street. "The same Scarlet Rat the whole city's frightened of now — and a fraud, is what he is." A wizard the boy answered to, one Lord Phranck, tangled up with a Keoland noble, a soldier they called the power of Baywin — "and that's the one broke my arm, mind, questioned me down in the Appleyard shell-keep." Bugbears in the cells, he swore, and a mad dwarf for a gaoler, and a breakout with half of Toli's own crew, and a stolen skiff, and a run down the coast by way of Seaton and home. Tyrus took it the way he'd told Folsom to — enjoying the half that was true, and not putting coin on which half it was.

Other things surfaced in the wash of it, and stuck. Hobgoblins massing off Salinmoor, near a little island the sailors called Turtle Island — Lizard Island, some named it — hard by a marsh town called Appleyard; Owen had sailed through and seen them regrouping himself, and could not say why. Sharks in the bay that very morning, come in with him, though not near enough to overwhelm a well-blooded crew. And Redshore all but undefended, for all it mattered — "three warships, maybe, and two at Seaton, one in Saltmarsh; I've counted them myself" — captains stationed there who plainly wished they weren't. "One good strike and the whole blockade's ash. Why our princes won't send the fleet out and do it—" he spread his hands, sloshing the cup — "well. Whatever lines their pockets matters more than how

they look, is my guess. All of them. Every last prince."

"Where's Merrick, anyhow?" he asked, more than once, casting about the room each time as though his cousin might have surfaced since he'd last looked. "Knows these waters near as well as I do — only other man who can slip the Redshore patrols. I've a use for a man like that." And a beat later, lower, the drink not quite so thick on him after all: "You're not talking to any authorities about any of this, are you, lads?"

"I like my ale too much for that," Tyrus said.

"There's my man."

Owen turned then to Folsom, who'd been quiet through the whole of it. "But, Folsom — you got a song for us?"

"I do, in fact," Folsom said, and looked about for something to stand on.

Someone pointed him toward the counter, and he climbed up onto it with a showman's flourish, calling out over the crowd. "Ladies and gentlemen — for your entertainment, I bring you... Folsom!"

The room roared its approval, cups raised. Folsom grinned down at them, riding the warmth of it. "Tyrus, I won't be needing an announcer for once — everybody's already happy! Well — before I get into the tale of our recent adventure, let's raise our cups for Owen, for this grand festivity we're all enjoying tonight!"

Cheers rose again, and Owen lifted his cup in acknowledgment.

"But I do, in fact, have a song for you all," Folsom went on, "about our recent adventure." He drew himself up, weighing which of several songs he'd composed on the crossing home might best suit a room full of off-duty men still raw from three hundred lost comrades — and he found the choice all but made in him already. The last days had worked on the young Marine more than he'd let show — the men dying in the Helm's bay while they watched helpless from the tower; Fairwind's soft, certain voice in the dark, naming traitors among the great; the flat brutality of Gouge and Jude, who killed the way other men breathed; the uncanny reach of Paul's little clay creature; and over all of it the sense that every

noble of the Hold was moving pieces in some game the ordinary men only bled for. No gentle tune would hold the half of that. And so, in the end, he chose not the safer song but the sharper.

He called it “The Brewing Storm,” and began.

Oh, Monmurg, you’re a jewel on display,
but your leaders have led you astray.
Princes and powers in their gilded halls
can’t see the writing on your walls.
They could grasp the news, if they’d only try,
but it’s your own leaders who are truly blind.

Oh, princes of the sea, what have you done?
Your squabbles and schemes have blocked out the sun.
While you bicker and fight, the city’s in plight,
and the Duke of Gradsul laughs while you fight.

The navy’s strong, or so they say,
but storms and whispers have led you astray.
The enemy’s fleet, the weaker and slow,
has somehow managed to steal the show.
Is it magic, or treachery — who can tell?
But incompetence might be the cause as well.

For Torvin in ashes, the food’s running low,
you sit in your castles, putting on a show.
The Prince of Port Toli, with his ships delayed,
plays his own game while the city’s betrayed.
Internal strife, a festering sore,
while Monmurg starves, you all plan for more.
The traders are stuck, the markets are bare,
and the people of Monmurg are in despair.
The Duke of Berghof, with his meager supply,
leaves you to wonder — is this goodbye?
Your allies are distant, your enemies near,
and you do nothing but stroke your own fear.

Oh, princes of the sea, what have you done?
Your squabbles and schemes have blocked out the sun.
While you bicker and fight, the city's in plight,
and the Duke of Gradsul laughs while you fight too.

So here's to the leaders, the princes and powers,
who've turned Monmurg's fortune to scars.
While you play your games, the city's in pain,
and the Duke of Gradsul wins again.
Monmurg, your fate's in their hands,
but it's their own folly that tightens the bands.

The words themselves were sharp and well-turned, the product of real craft laid down over long hours of the crossing home — but the delivery came out rough despite it, his voice cracking once on the high note of the second verse, and the room, once his final line faded, did not roar back the way it had for his introduction.

It went, instead, very quiet.

The crowd was patriotic to a man, off-duty Marines who'd just watched their fellows die by the hundreds, and a song naming their own princes' folly as the true author of the city's suffering did not sit well in a room like this one — not tonight, and not from a man as young as Folsom, fellow Marine or no, however true the words might ring.

Gouge arrived at the barracks door in that same silence, took one look at the room's mood, and crossed the floor without hurry, setting down his own drink along the way. He drew his dagger halfway from its sheath, let it catch the lamplight a moment, and slid it home again — a small, deliberate gesture, meant to be seen.

"These words aren't welcome here," he said to Folsom, low but carrying, and took him firmly by the arm. "You come down here." Then, louder, to the room at large: "He's had a bit too much." And with that, he hauled Folsom bodily out of the barracks and into the evening air, leaving the crowd to mutter and slowly return to its cups.

Tyrus lingered a moment longer, awkward in the sudden quiet. "Next round's on me," he told Owen, and laid a gold coin on the counter — drink enough, he hoped, to blur the whole sorry performance out of every head in the room by morning — before he turned for the door, his mind already on Folsom, and on how the lad would fare once Gouge had him out in the dark.

Owen raised his glass in thanks, and Tyrus followed the others out.

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

The Gift in the Alley

Gouge walked Folsom into the nearest alley and set him down against the wall, the noise of the barracks fading behind them. He was none too steady himself. Thirty-six hours of fighting, killing, and now drinking, with no sleep in any of it, had caught up with him all at once, and it showed in his feet and his tongue alike.

"You know what you were even trying to do back there?" The words came slow and thick. "Did you — did you even like the song?"

"Loved it, actually," Folsom said, still riding some of the high of the performance despite everything.

"Course you did." Gouge leaned against the wall beside him and slid half down it. "Wasn't taking, though. Whole room, I could see it — wasn't taking. So I got your backside out the door the only way I knew. Made a scene. Pulled the blade, grabbed you, out you went." He waved a loose hand. "Room like that, song like that — near came apart in there, brother. That was me getting you clear before it got worse. Y'understand me."

"And here I thought I was making a life for myself," Folsom said, something rueful in it.

"You've got a — a notion of me. All of you do." Gouge jabbed a finger at him, missed, found him on the second try. "That shout, back on the bridge — you took me for the villain of the piece. That's not me. That's Jude." He got the name out with the peculiar care of a drunk man handling the one word he means. "I keep to a code. You've nothing to fear off me. Not unless you cross a man I'm loyal to. That's the only thing worth fearing off me. Only thing."

"Fair enough," Folsom said. "And I thank you for it."

Boots scuffed at the alley's mouth — Tyrus, come looking, the set of his face easing when he found the pair of them upright and unbloodied.

He went straight to Folsom. "You all right?"

"I'm fine, Tyrus. He got me out, is all."

"Great song," Gouge announced to no one in particular, aiming a loose grin at Folsom.

"Bad room, though." Tyrus crouched to Folsom's level. "Don't let it eat at you. I'll go back in and put it about that it was all a joke — a joke and a round of drinks cures more fear than anything I know. It'll hold."

Gouge fumbled then beneath his own cloak and dragged out a second one — worn, old, plain but for a small green stone set at the collar — and pressed it into Folsom's hands.

"S'a gem. The stone." He tapped at it, or near it. "Don't use it right, myself. But it'll make your songs a little better, I'd wager. Take it. It's magic — proper magic, and wasted on a man like me. You'll get use out of it I never could."

"My thanks," Folsom said, taking it with real care — though in truth he grasped barely the half of what he held.

"There's a price on it, though." Gouge got a hand on his shoulder — steadying himself as much as making the point. "We're in a fight, things happening, and you're about to play your tunes, do whatever it is you do to help a man — you look at me first. Before you spend it." His eyes, drink or no, went hard and clear a moment. "I give you a nod, like so, that means I don't need it — spend it where you please. But I look at you like this—" the flat, deliberate stare — "and whatever you've got, you'd best be sending my way. Understand me?"

"Agreed, and gladly," Folsom said.

Gouge sagged back against the wall, the hardness going out of him again. "Owe you one, then. A few, maybe."

"We'll see," Folsom said, something lighter creeping back into his voice. "Hopefully not. Some red-eye, if it comes to it."

"Ferd's it is." Something like a grin cracked across Gouge's face at last. He hauled himself half upright and laid the flat of his hand on Tyrus's chest. "Do one thing for me first. Merrick — find Merrick, if you can, and bring him along. Then we'll all go get properly ruined." He weighed his own condition a moment. "More ruined."

"I'll find him," Tyrus said.

"Good kid," Gouge told Folsom, and let his eyes fall shut against the wall a moment.

CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

What Merrick Found at the Bar

Merrick came into the barracks a little after the worst of it, and pieced the rest together from the talk still running round the room — the bard up on a counter, the song that had named the princes fools, the cold that fell over the place, and Gouge crossing the floor to haul him out the door and off down the alley. It was the very thing Folsom had been warned against; half of Merrick expected to find the man knifed and left in that alley before anyone thought to look.

The barracks went back to its drinking, and Owen Black leaned at the bar as though nothing had happened at all. Merrick crossed to him, still shaken, and got no further than a nod before Tyrus came back in — sent by Gouge, he said, to round Merrick up — and found the two of them there together.

“What happened with Folsom?” Merrick asked, reading Tyrus’s face.

“A farce,” Tyrus said. “Meant to be one. A joke that landed wrong.”

“Marines don’t care for jokes about themselves.” Owen lifted his cup. “What they like is beer, or cider if they can get it.”

Tyrus set a gold on the counter and called the nearest men over. Merrick did not stay for it.

“I just reported to my commander,” he told Tyrus, already turning for the door. “But I’ll see Folsom for myself — I’ll not take it secondhand that the lad’s all right.” A nod to Owen: “Good to see you whole.” And he went out after the others, the door swinging shut behind him.

Tyrus lingered over his own cup. Owen's talk of Redshore, the patrols, the whole state of the sea, he let wash past for another day — there would be time enough. But Owen came round, as Owen always did, to the matter of profit.

"That business with the bard aside," Owen said, dropping his voice to the register he kept for real dealing, "let me put something to you, Tyrus. And don't go telling me it's not in your blood — I knew old Gaius, and I know well enough what deck you were raised on." He turned his cup slow on the counter. "I run the one boat into Redshore and back. I could run two — double the coin, easy, the way that harbor's sitting — if I had a second hull and the right men to crew her. Your Gouge, for one. A man who fights the way he does is worth his weight when the sahaugin rise on you in open water, or when the trouble walks on two legs. And your cousin Merrick. There's no one alive slips the Redshore patrols like he does, save maybe me. Put Gouge's blade and Merrick's helm on a boat of mine, and there's not a thing on that stretch of sea could lay a hand on us."

He let it sit a moment.

"And I've done that lot a turn already, mind — that elf, Jude, the one who came off my boat asking after Gouge. Carried him into Monmurg myself, week or so back, out of Redshore. The name Owen Black's not nothing to them." He tapped the counter. "But it's you who can bring them in, Tyrus. They'll take it from you sooner than from me. Put it to them — and if you do, I'll stand you a hull of your own on top of it. We'd double what any honest crew makes, and feed a starving city doing it."

"I'll think on it," Tyrus said, and left his cup where it stood, going out after Merrick into the dark.

CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT

Confession in the Foreign District

Merrick and Tyrus caught up with Gouge and Folsom in the street — Folsom a shade sheepish still — and the four of them set off together, Gouge leading, away from the barracks and the lamplit order of the Harbor District toward a bar he said was worth the walk.

“So — what did Jamis make of it, in the end?” Tyrus asked Merrick as they went. “Where does it leave us — back to the island?”

“Hard to say. He’s not a man you can read.” Merrick shook his head. “But he made one thing plain enough: there’s more work here yet, politics and soldiering both.”

“Before any of that,” Gouge said, “understand I was mostly brought along to keep this one’s mouth shut, I am finding.” A jerk of his head at Folsom.

“I walked through a door—”

“You were spilling the most horrendous nonsense I’ve ever heard. Great voice, though, I’ll grant you — knowing when to close it, less so.” His tone went flat. “Helm Island — what we saw, what we learned — you stay silent on the whole of it. There were no barrels. No lords turned traitor. As far as anyone else living knows, I couldn’t tell you whether you got off the boat.”

“You should know better by now,” Merrick put in, no warmer than Gouge had been.

Folsom let a little steel into his voice. “I keep quiet on what matters — I’m smarter than the pair of you credit. It’s jokes and songs I can’t hold in, not secrets. Don’t muddle the two.”

Gouge studied him a moment, and seemed, grudgingly, to grant

it.

The streets changed around them as they walked. The Harbor District's broad, lamp-hung lanes gave way by degrees to something narrower and meaner — houses leaning close overhead until the sky was a grey seam between the eaves, the cobbles greasy underfoot, the air thick with woodsmoke and fish gone off and too many people in too little room. A cosmopolitan crush by day, Gouge told them, second only to the Grand Market — traders and travelers off every ship that still dared the strait, Suel and Olman faces among the Oeridian — but the blockade had ground it down hard. Doorways they passed held families with nothing to do but sit in them; a child watched the four of them go by with the flat, pricing eyes of someone weighing their boots. Beggars worked the corners, and where the beggars thinned, the thieves began. Gouge walked it easy, at home, a nod for a face here and there. The others did not. Tyrus kept a hand loose near his belt without seeming to choose to; Merrick watched the rooflines; Folsom, for once, had gone quiet.

"There's the other matter," Tyrus said, to fill the silence as much as anything. "Owen's offered me work — a smuggling run, Redshore and back, and he wants you in on it, Gouge, and Merrick besides. Says he'll stand me a boat of my own for it."

"Take it," Gouge said, before Tyrus had half finished weighing it. "Take your leave of the Marines and take it. I'll square it with Jamis as reconnaissance — eyes on Redshore, his own men playing smugglers; he's run that game before. Owen needn't know the crown's anywhere near it. Cleaner all round if he thinks we've simply stepped off duty for reasons of our own."

Merrick said little to that, but the thought turned over in him all the same. There would be no surer way to learn what Owen truly knew — of Redshore, of the sahaugin, of who moved what through that stranded harbor — than a few days at the man's side on open water. And that was the very errand Jamis had set him, not two hours gone. Whatever else the job was, it would serve the spymaster's purpose as neatly as it served Owen's.

"He knows my name, though," Gouge went on, lower, "and I

can't say how. That I'll want answered. A man who knows me when I know nothing of him is a man I hold at arm's length till I do."

"He knows Tyrus and me, mostly," Merrick said. "Why he asked after you, I'll learn what I can."

They pressed deeper in, and Gouge came back to it. "Now — the other matter. Folsom. What did Fairwind tell you, back there, when you had him charmed and talking?"

Folsom took a moment, and when he spoke the performer's lightness had gone out of him. "I'll give it as near word for word as I can. And I'll say plain — I don't know how much of it's true."

"He was under your charm," Tyrus said. "Could that make him say what isn't?"

"A charm's more like talking to a trusted friend," Folsom said. "A friend can lie to you still — but likely he gave me the truth as he saw it. Whether Fairwind's an honest man or a crooked one under it all, I couldn't tell you; he'd bend a thing to suit himself either road."

"Then we don't throw it out."

"No." Folsom kept it low, under the street noise. "You know Lady Jamis. Her brother, he told me, is Zafar Azane — who serves the Duke of Gradsul, and runs the Duke's Office of Forbidden Magic."

Tyrus walked a few paces in silence. "The Duke of Gradsul. The man blockading us. Our oldest enemy — Lucian the Fourth died at the Siege of Westkeep coming at us, and every time that bloodline seats a king in Keoland, Keoland marches on the principalities." He stopped in the middle of the greasy street. "And Lord Jamis's own wife's brother runs that man's forbidden-magic office."

"That's what he told me," Folsom said.

"That's... not good," Tyrus said. "The suspicion's shifted, then — off Paul and Jeon, onto Jamis."

"None of us knows what's true," Merrick said — and it plainly cost him, Jamis's own man that he was. "But if Jamis asks any one of us a thing, we say nothing of this. Not a word."

"Careful how you tread." Gouge's voice had gone hard, defensive all at once. "Jamis is the man who's kept me fed and out of

a noose these years. My loyalty runs to him, and I'll not have him painted a traitor on a charmed man's word. Suspect the rest of it all you please — but name Jamis, and you're on thin ice with me."

"I'm not naming him anything," Folsom said. "I'm saying every thread Fairwind pulled runs back toward the man, whether he meant it so or not. Lord Jamis, Lady Jamis — and we all know she works her own influence out of sight. That's a great deal of coincidence."

"I don't believe in coincidence either," Gouge admitted. "It's still a long way from proof."

Merrick let that lie, and turned to Folsom. "You're on this job as well, then. A few days out of the city would do you good — and keep you from putting your foot in your mouth again while the barracks cools off."

"Wherever Tyrus goes," Folsom said, brightening, "I go."

"I was bringing him anyway," Tyrus said.

By then they had come as deep into the district as any of them but Gouge had ever been — a warren of the truly desperate, where the lamplight gave out and the only law was whatever a man could keep with his own two hands. They passed a crude sign daubed on a wall that read Blood Alley, and another beside it.

"This is where I grew up," Gouge said, dry.

"What's that second one?" Tyrus asked.

"Murder Alley."

"Subtle."

The bar sat across from both — its custom a scarred mix of the world's leavings, Olman from the Amedio jungle, half-orcs from the Hool, broken-down pirates out of Port Toli. Folsom mimed a dainty salute at the door. "Very refined."

Gouge only laughed and steered them to the man behind the counter — Ferd himself, who looked the three strangers over with a lifted brow.

"What have we here?"

"They smell better than Karmirg, at least," Gouge said.

"True enough." Ferd's grin thinned. "He's been gone a week or two — muttered something and went. You've not seen him?"

"Fortunately and unfortunately, no." Gouge leaned in, dropping his voice. "And if the elf comes round asking — you've seen nothing of us. Four red-eyes."

"Done," said Ferd, and set to pouring.

And then, for one night, they let the whole of it go. Ferd kept the cups coming, and as the drink did its slow, dulling work the four of them fell in with the bar's own custom — the down-on-their-luck rabble of Ferd's, men who belonged to no people and no banner but that of the outcast, cast off by every port and prince that had ever laid claim to them. They were not, the newcomers found, so despicable nor so frightful as the walk in had led them to fear; Gouge moved among them like a man come home, and an easy word from him for this one and that smoothed the way, until the barrels on Helm Island and the dead in its bay and the long tangle of lords and traitors behind them all went soft at the edges and, for a few hours, weighed nothing at all. Blood Alley and Murder Alley waited beyond the door, but the names seemed almost quaint now — a slum's grim boast, set against what they had seen on the Helm. That had been the face of true war, and no back-alley killing could match it for blood spilt, nor for the treachery that lay beneath it — for the cutthroats of Ferd's murdered honestly enough, for coin or grudge, while the Helm had been the work of lords betraying their own. Inside there was only the drink, and the warmth of it, and Folsom's voice worked low and easy now through the old songs the room could bear to hear. They had earned the oblivion, and they took it while it was theirs.

Some months on, when the tale of that night had gone round the taverns and barracks more than once, it was Folsom's disastrous "The Brewing Storm" that men remembered longest — not the fighting, not the barrels, but the song, and how a room of patriotic Marines had bristled to hear their own princes named the authors of the city's ruin. Yet as the weeks turned, and rumor of Fairwind's treachery spread, and the Sea Ghost was sighted again,

and the Toli's hand in it grew harder to deny, those same Marines came round: the bard had seen the shape of the thing before any of them. In time the men who'd wanted Folsom thrown into the street wished instead that they could sit him down and ask what else he knew. And so began his career — and his infamy — as a bard whose name would carry a good deal further than that one rough night had promised.

For the storm he had sung of was only gathering. It was not the Duke of Gradsul's doing alone — the jealousy and infighting of the sea princes fed it, and the peril of the Hold came not only from its enemies but from those it called friends. Fairwind's body had never washed ashore. The Sea Ghost still ran the strait under no flag any man among them knew. Out past Redshore the sahaugin were massing toward some purpose none had yet put a name to, and the Toli were whetting the same knives twice; and in a quiet office in Monmurg a spymaster turned the four men's accounts over in his hands and drew conclusions he kept to himself. They did not know it yet, drinking in Ferd's while the lamps burned down — but that rough night at the barracks would come to seem, in the years after, the smallest of the things that began that evening. The journey was only starting. Before its end they would stand against the final enemy — and the storm, when at last it broke, would be worse than any song could hold.